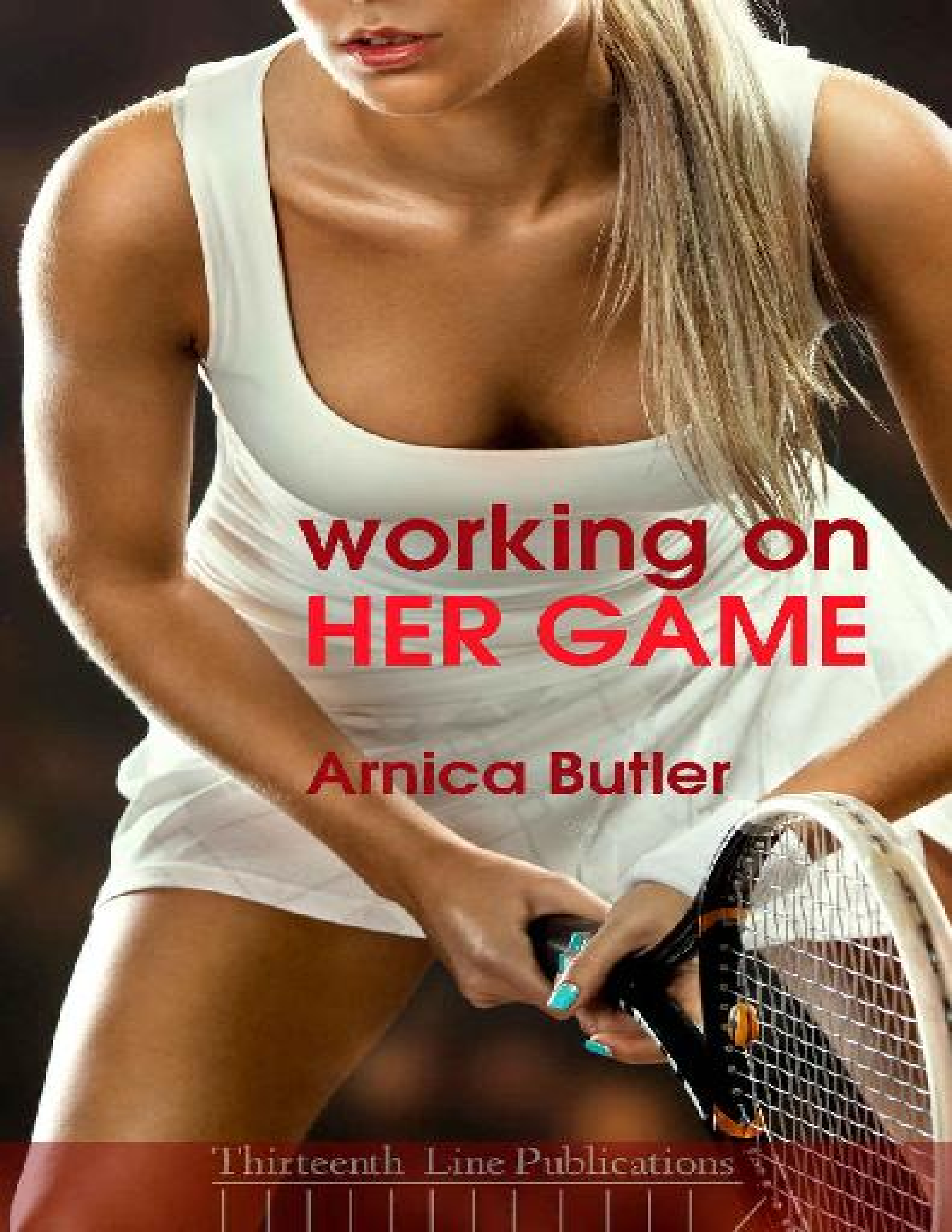


A woman with long blonde hair, wearing a white tank top and white shorts, is shown from the waist up. She is holding a tennis racket with both hands, preparing to serve. The background is dark and out of focus. The title 'working on HER GAME' is overlaid in red text, with 'working on' in a smaller font and 'HER GAME' in a larger, bold font.

working on HER GAME

Arnica Butler

Thirteenth Line Publications

WORKING ON HER GAME

A Hotwife Erotica Novel

By Arnica Butler

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Chapter 1

I barely noticed when the waiter set the drink I had ordered in front of me. The heavy thud of a thick-bottomed glass against the white tablecloth made its way through my mind slowly, and when I finally looked up to thank him, he was gone.

I took the drink in hand and tried to remember what I had ordered. A Coke Zero, as I was “supposed to?” A rum and Coke Zero, as I had been tempted to? A rum and Coke, which I had considered, since I was about to break my diet rules anyway and there was no sense being un-manly about it? Or was it a Coke, an idea that I had tossed around in my head as a weird compromise between finally having a drink, and not falling completely off the diet wagon?

My attention was pulled away before I could give it any more thought, or take a sip.

I had a nice view, where I was, in the dark-wood paneled bar with a wide window looking into the tennis courts. Sure, it was mid-week and midday, and no one wanted to look like they were relaxing or drinking when they should be yelling into a phone somewhere, so I was the only one near the windows. This seat was ordinarily hard to get.

I could see why. I had a good view of three courts, which all happened to be occupied by women receiving tennis lessons. Short white skirts and tanned legs abounded.

My focus, however, was on one specific pair of tanned legs. In the center court, right at eye level, and close enough to see (or so I liked to imagine) the beads of sweat running down her thigh.

When I had arrived, I’d ordered a coffee and sat by the poolside view. A water aerobics class with a lot of older women – some of them quite attractive – had begun, and then my attention had wandered to the courts. I hadn’t realized there was such a great view.

And there they were: sculpted legs, a delicate tan color that reminded me of a milky latte, dangling from a blinding white skirt that just grazed the curve of a small, taut bottom. The owner of the legs had them set slightly apart, one knee bent, the long line of thigh muscle highlighted by a late-

morning shadow. She spun a racket in her hand, which I think is what so effectively masked her identity: the motion was effortless, the racket spun and her lithe fingers kissed the rotating frame, she used that hand to push a strand of blazing white hair over her shoulder.

I took in the sudden narrowness of her waist, the same tinted, milky skin flashed between the waist of her skirt and the powder-blue of her top. She was turned slightly, and a generous curve pressed out at her chest, hinting at a well-proportioned and firm breast.

I let my eyes wander back to her bottom, where the skirt hid the shape of her ass. It was not flat; the material dangled behind her tantalizingly. But was it a heart-shaped, middle-aged bottom, or was she young and impossibly pert? With her legs relaxed it was impossible to tell her age or even how athletic she was.

Suddenly, the legs sprang into action. The length and slenderness of them seemed to disappear; muscles tightened and showed beneath her skin as she shifted in two, effortless-looking bounds that pressed the shape of her thigh muscles outward into a curved line from knee to exposed hip. She was sideways for a moment, and the very slight curve of her belly, the generous curve of her breasts, and the delightful shape of her ass were all revealed to me in profile.

And even then, as she stepped into a shadow, and her hair color was revealed to be a sun-kissed wheat color and not the platinum I had first seen; even when I saw the curve of her cheek and the length of her neck, my mind still didn't process who she was. I had even turned my chair away after the waiter took my incomprehensible order, so that when Scarlett arrived she would not see me gawking over some other woman.

Scarlett, you see, was not athletic. She didn't play sports with balls or really do a lot of anything except walking the dog, and skiing, which she liked but always quit after a few runs, to have a glass of wine or a margarita. That was why it took so long, as all the pieces of the woman I had just seen – specifically, the fingertips strumming the spinning racket, being lightly whipped in a vaguely sexual manner – bubbled away in my mind, to realize that the woman on the court was my wife.

The chair had made a grating sound as I turned it on the tile floor, eliciting an arched eyebrow from the bartender, who was wearing a bow tie

on a Wednesday afternoon, just to give you an idea of what this club was like.

And then I sat, transfixed, watching my wife bounce around on the tennis court, stretching her lean muscles, her white skirt flashing a view of her firm bottom, her skin starting to glisten with sweat. She was breathing heavily, but in that Olympic athlete sort of way, where you look like you deserve to be out of breath. She spun the racket as if it were part of her body. The tip of her dark blonde pony-tail was wet with sweat. I could practically taste the salty drips that ran down her inner thighs, smell the sweet aroma at the back of her neck, feel the curve of her flesh right where her flash-pants ended under her constantly flapping skirt.

She was *good*, too. Her opponent was a man, a tennis player through and through – thinner than a rugby player, arms of steely valleys and hills of muscle. His skin was darkly tanned, his hair was black, and he paced with a panther-like steadiness until she returned his volleys. It was clear that she wasn't causing him much trouble, but the game was not pathetic to watch.

I stared openly, and then squinted. Maybe it was just someone who looked like Scarlett. That was it.

I almost had that illusion built up in my mind when the woman-who-looked-like-Scarlett spun to chase down a ball, slamming it into the ground just outside of the baseline.

Her smile, generous and brilliantly white, was unmistakable. She was facing the windows of the restaurant, saying something to her companion, laughing, and I had a full view of her face. A white visor cast a shadow over her eyes, but their smokey grayness behind her thick lashes was unmistakable.

It was Scarlett.

She turned, bounced the ball back to the man, and twirled her racket again, leaning from side to side on her sinewy legs.

By then I was holding the drink and staring blatantly. I watched them play, my mind numb with confusion. The game ended, and I still had the drink in my hand, suspended in mid-air. They met at the middle of the court, and stood talking to each other over the net for what seemed like a long time.

I felt a flare in my chest. It started just like a phosphorous road flare, burning hard, dying down, sizzling slowly.

Scarlett walked along the net as the man moved back, trotting on his muscled legs with his eyes on her. I studied his face: he was good-looking, young, square-jawed and slightly foreign-looking. Scarlett approached him and the flare in my chest spread out, moving downward.

Mystery man reached out, and placed his hand on her arm. Scarlett turned, and her white-clad butt wriggled up against his groin. His hands slid down over her smooth arms, taking their time, feeling the length of my wife's arms like he was eating a rich dessert. He moved her foot with his leg, and her bottom melted into his groin a little more.

My neck started to burn. I sipped the drink, which had warmed in my hand. Diet Coke, and maybe some rum. I looked down briefly at my paunchy stomach and then back at the man who was spooning my wife.

It was such a classic scene it almost made me laugh, and it might have, if I hadn't been so hot under the collar: the youthful instructor guiding the pretty woman's hands and legs and showing her how to "play tennis."

The lesson looked semi-legitimate, until he placed his hands on her hips, fingers pointed toward the center of her body, lying over the front of her skirt where they were almost certainly grazing her innermost thigh. Maybe even brushing over her trim bush.

The waiter's voice, tinged with a tone of polite irritation that comes with having asked a question three times, broke through my angry reverie. "Sir?"

I looked up at him.

"Can I get you another?"

Did this man – who was really a boy – know that I was watching another man touch my wife? Was my neck red, my face ruddy as the blood inside of me roared? I felt like someone had stabbed me with adrenaline. "I want a Scotch," I said, and my voice sounded quietly venomous.

I turned back to the scene. They were facing each other now, talking. Close-talking.

Another wave of anger rolled through me: was Scarlett having an affair?

The image swam in front of me. The man looked at his watch. They smiled and chatted and he left, spinning his racket in his hand.

Scarlett walked toward the window. A faint smile was on her lips; her eyes were unfocused and gazed at an elevated non-point in the air. She was daydreaming.

As she came closer I started to worry that she would see me, but I remained as I was. I was ready for confrontation.

Scarlett dropped to the ground in a squat that gave me a peek into the shadows between her thighs, to the white fabric that covered her snatch. She picked up a light jacket, stood, and paused.

She was looking directly at me, her face zombie-like. My mouth opened; I don't know what I was planning on saying. A cold, terrible, beautiful pain spiked through my chest.

She lifted her hands to her head and removed her visor. A bead of sweat rolled down her cheek. She wiped it with the back of her hand, and eyes on the glass, she primped herself, tying her ponytail freshly back.

Of course. The window was one-way, mirrored on the outside.

She had placed her racket between her legs, and as she had worked on her hair, it had started to tip forward, until the shaft of the handle was pointed up between her legs, under the skirt, grazing the white center of her flash pants. Another bead of sweat rolled down her outer leg.

She rubbed the back of her neck sensually, made a very subtle pouty face in the mirror – a gesture I don't even think she's aware that she makes – and then turned on her heel. A flash of her bottom, and the skirt fell back against her skin. She walked quickly and cut through the shrubs.

She was gone.

My heart was pounding. The Scotch was on the table, and I wondered what kind it was and how the waiter had known I wanted it neat. Probably just a guess, I thought, my pulse loud in my ears.

My hand had the feeling that it was shaking, even though it wasn't, as I reached for the Scotch.

The single image that replayed in my mind, that I could not keep submerged, was of the man with his thumbs hooked on my wife's ass, his fingers curled against her pelvis.

The heat that burned at my neck, I understood. But something I did *not* understand was the throbbing in my cock.

I slammed the drink and considered my options.

I had come here to surprise her. She had been coming to the club almost every day during the week, which was unusual in retrospect but not something I'd paid a lot of mind to. Scarlett had several months before her new job started, and not much to do. She had claimed to be working out, and I had assumed she went just for the socializing. We were new in town and Scarlett loved meeting new people. As soon as she had seen the place, and realized that she could come whenever she wanted, as part of the perks of my job, she had pounced on the opportunity.

I had assumed I would find her by the pool, reading a book, her long legs crossed, a red bikini peeking out from under a plain white shirt, her skin slightly burnt because she had not realized that the sun was so strong further south.

If someone had tried to bet me that Scarlett was playing tennis I would have mortgaged the house.

And yet, as I thought about it, it had all been there for me to see: the long days at the club, the mysterious answers to questions about her day, the way she spent more time getting ready in the morning.

If I added to this that Scarlett and I were not, to be honest, on the best of terms in our marriage: we rarely had sex, we rarely talked outside of the most perfunctory exchanges, we both seemed to be guarding our own secrets about how we felt about this move to Santa Fe and the change in our lifestyle – if I added all of it up, then, it made perfect sense.

In fact, I was an idiot for not having added it all up before then.

Another flare of jealousy ate at my chest. *How long*, I wondered. *How long had she been cheating on me?*

And where was she going now?

I stood up, dropping cash on the table. The waiter was coming toward me, waving me off, trying to explain that everything was done on credit and that a bill was sent at the end of the month, but I waved him away.

I didn't know where I thought I was going. I was just storming, angry, ready to confront my wife or the man she was fucking...

But as I stormed, it occurred to me that maybe it wasn't the *best* idea to confront them.

I was angry, sure, but there were other feelings inside of me as well.

I was just coming to terms with all of them, rounding a corner too sharply, when we ran right into each other.

Scarlett's slightly damp hair slapped my cheek and her hands pressed into my chest. Was it just me, or did she linger against me a bit too long, for someone she didn't expect to see?

"Oh! Sorr-" she exclaimed. And then her mouth fell open. "Will?" she said.

She looked behind her, and my blood burned like acid. When she turned back to me, her face was calm, but surprise hovered around on her features. "What... what are you doing he... isn't today Wednesday?"

Her cheeks were turning pink, which meant she was flustered.

"I came to surprise you," I said dryly. My voice was cold. I lifted an arm and pointed to the bar. "I was sitting right there, about to send you a text."

Her eyes followed my hand, and I watched her face as she analyzed the chair, the bar, and the window looking out onto the court. Her eyes moved side to side as she thought about what she had just been doing.

She had an expression on her face that, for some reason, made my cock hard as steel.

Her eyes passed over my face, and she lowered them. I noticed that she had dark shadow on her lids, and black mascara on her lashes, which were mysteriously red-tinted like her pubic hair when they were unadorned.

She took in a deep breath. "I'm sorry," she said, and the words deflated all of my excitement and dragged me quickly to an abysmal low. Cold seized my heart and I could hear the loud, slow beats of it in my ears through the tinny sound that began to roar.

This was it. The end of our marriage.

"I wanted to keep it a secret," she said, and her mouth turned up slightly at one corner while she nibbled at her lower lip.

Funny? Did she think this was funny?

My anger returned, surging up through my arteries like acid. My mouth started to open, when Scarlett draped her arms on my shoulders and turned her face up to mine. "I hope you're not mad at -"

Her voice was sexy, sultry, until she caught my expression and took a step back, cutting herself off. "You okay?" she asked.

"Okay?" I volleyed. My voice was hoarse, and I couldn't think of anything else to say, or exactly how to say it. It sounded a bit like I was choking.

Scarlett looked at me strangely. “I know it’s sort of expensive,” she said. “And it’s too, too bad that you caught me, because I wanted to surprise you with a -”

She cut herself off again. She smiled a coy smile.

My head whirled, so I didn’t say whatever it was I had been about to say.

She walked her fingers along my chest. Each one of them burned a hole through me.

“Well,” she said. “I’ll keep that part a secret.” Then she lifted her eyes to me and smiled again. “Did you eat already? How’d you get off work, anyway? I thought,” she began walking into the bar, “that once you started this job I’d actually never see you again.”

When she turned to me she was flush with excitement, smiling broadly, and had her hands clasped together. It was childlike, and it sent me into another tailspin, because it was *not* the expression of a cheating woman who had just been discovered by her husband. “Oh! Everything is working out perfectly!” she exclaimed. She rushed forward and gave me a kiss – a brief peck on the mouth that sent a tickle through my lips and along the roof.

“I’m sorry I was such a Negative-Nelly,” she said, in what I understood to be a reference to our move to New Mexico. Her pony-tail whipped again, and she plopped onto a stool. “Can I get a water, James?” she said cheerfully.

James. James was my waiter, I thought, as James shined up a glass, looking at me with a bemused smile on his own face.

Scarlett took the water and gulped it, then tapped her fingers on the bar. She pushed a strand of hair from her forehead and looked at me expectantly. “So?” she said. “What’s the plan?”

Then, as an after-thought: “But I have to shower either way.” She stood up. “I guess I’ll go do that. Wait for me here? But seriously, what is the plan? Did you see Alessandro walk through here?”

This was Scarlett’s perfectly normal way of talking. Sentence after sentence, not waiting for an answer, stream of consciousness. She was a good attorney, and in the courtroom all of this desultory rambling was tossed out in favor of very precise, targeted language.

With me, however, she just rolled ahead like a freight train.

“Alessandro,” my mouth repeated.

She was looking around. “James” raised his eyebrows and pointed the glass he was drying toward the windows facing the pool. We both followed his gesture, where indeed “Alessandro” was easy to spot.

He had exchanged his tennis outfit for a pair of swimming trunks that were loose but somehow still revealing. They were black like his hair, and his tanned skin was everywhere else. Muscled and dripping with water.

He looked like a fucking ad for... I don’t know, Perrier or butter or something... as he brought a towel to his hair and rubbed his head. It had the special effect of making his abs flex and roll in hardened, muscular waves.

“Oh!” she said. She grabbed the glass, took a last gulp of water, tapped me lightly on the shoulder, and ran away. “I gotta just... really quick!” I watched her run out to the pool deck.

When I turned back to the bar, my mouth was open and my hands were out, turned up. “What the fuck was that?” my gesture said.

James smiled shyly, gave the weakest shrug I have ever seen, and walked toward the other end of the bar, furiously drying his already-dry glass.

I was now on the opposite side of a one-way glass looking out to the pool area, where Scarlett approached Adonis or whatever his name was, touching him on the elbow.

One thing was for sure: he liked my wife. His mouth turned into a smile, but not a cheesy one. A sort of predatory, dominating smile. Not a sneer, which he might have used on a man, but not a suburban-dad smile either.

Wolfish.

Scarlett was waving her hands a lot and smiling big.

She turned away, and Alessandro’s eyes slid along her body and back up, before he turned around to pick up a towel from the deck chair.

A smug smile was on his lips.

I strode toward the door that connected the pool and the hallway to the rest of the club and the restaurant.

Scarlett ran past me, her hand out in her “no-time” gesture. “Just give me one minute,” she said. “I’ll be back here in a jiff.”

“One minute” in Scarlett hours meant half an hour, especially if she was taking a shower.

I stared after her. I still really didn't know what the fuck was going on.

My legs, however, seemed to have an idea. They were turning me around, walking me out to the pool.

It was a deceptively hot day, and I was in a suit. Since I'd taken this job, I'd gotten a wardrobe stipend that rivaled my first year's salary when I got out of law school. I looked great, I had to say. The suit was gun-metal colored, but with no sheen, and my tie was an authoritative blue. I smoothed it and let my legs carry me to a deck chair near Alessandro.

While half of my brain busied itself wondering what the fuck I was doing, and what the fuck Scarlett was doing, the other half of my brain seemed to have awakened and put itself on auto-pilot.

It was the dumber half of my brain, for the record. The one that had guided me, up to about the age of thirty, in a series of dumb ideas, near-criminal charges, and broken bones. The other half of my brain had taken over in my forties.

I sat down, smoothing my tie again. Alessandro gave me a glancing over out of the corner of his eye and was just starting to turn away, when something seemed to get on his radar. He twisted a little more toward me, rubbing his towel all over his chest.

He was glowering when he asked:

"You Italian or something?"

His own accent was Italian, though maybe not; it was very faint. He was grinning. "Only Italian guys wear a suit to the pool," he said, as if I had responded.

I looked at him blankly. "I'm meeting my wife," I said icily.

It could have been my imagination, but something seemed to stiffen in Alessandro's body. He sniffed, and tossed the towel at the chair. He ran his fingers through his hair. "A lot of wives here," he said.

His tone was so neutral I couldn't tell if he was fucking with me or not. The heat was eating away at my skin. I wondered what the hell my dumb-brain had been thinking. Come out here and start a fight? Certainly it hadn't been thinking about the poor combination of the combustible desert heat, and a wool suit.

"Well," Alessandro said. "Enjoy your day."

He whistled as he walked away, turning right, heading into the corridor that led in the same direction Scarlett had gone.

I glowered into the sun, which was getting stronger.

I stood up, walked toward the doors, was grateful as I was embraced by air conditioning, and paused where the corridors split into different directions.

Part of me was entertaining the idea that Alessandro was heading to the ladies' shower room, ready to peel off his swim trunks and slide up to my soapy, wet wife. "I think I met your husband," he would say into the soft part of her neck, and flick out his tongue to taste the skin that was still salty from her sweat. Her body would turn in his slippery, soapy hands, and they would run the length of her torso, down, slipping right between her legs...

My neck was hot again.

I made a sharp left and went back to the bar.

I had that high pulse and buzzed feeling that had all but disappeared from my life almost a decade ago. My stomach was in knots, adrenaline licking at the insides of my arteries. My head felt like it was going to float away if my neck would just set it free.

I turned on the high bar stool and looked out at the tennis courts. I had my third drink in my hand and the first two were fizzing in my brain with the memories of the past fifteen minutes.

The scent of soap, plain and soapy and distinctively Scarlett, who did not go in for fruits or flowers, preceded her. Wet hair, a hint of salon-smell from her expensive shampoo. Probably almond butter or some ingredient I didn't know the name of, but all together, definitively her.

I felt my blood boil as the scents reached my brain. Another sensation that had been gone from my life long ago.

I swiveled slowly in the chair to face her.

Her hair was damp and tousled. There was a loose wave in it that only appeared when it was wet. It gave her a beachy appearance. Her cheeks were bright pink where the sun had gotten to them.

She was wearing a form-fitting white dress that came to just above her knee. It hugged all the curves of her body, and for the first time I noticed that the very slight mounds of extra weight at her hips and the sides

of her ass, at her belly and even under her arms, were gone. Her skin was tanned, and she looked... stunning.

"Sorry that took so long," she said, setting a matching white purse on the bar. "James get me a big glass of water, please." She looked over at me and then jerked back swiftly to James. "Oh! Carbonated!" she added, calling out to his retreating form as if her life depended on the order.

"Carbonated," I said, because I had no idea what else to say.

She was facing me again, and she shrugged. "Alessandro drinks it all the time, he sort of turned me on to it. I think I prefer it now."

She was digging in her purse, saying his name as if it was the most casual thing in the world. The syllables of his stupid Italian name hissed through my ears and slithered down my spine. Al-e-sssssan-dro.

"So," she said cheerfully, uncapping a lipstick tube. "How on Earth did you get away for the day?"

I was speechless. I was beginning to have the vague idea that I was not coming to the right conclusion. It's a feeling I'd had before, in a courtroom or two, when it was about to be clear I'd had the wrong idea all along.

Or was it worse than that? Was my wife cheating on me and not only that, she just didn't give a shit that she was and that she'd been caught?

The skin on the back of my neck and along my upper arms prickled with goosebumps at the thought, which added another perplexing dimension to my situation.

It's a courtroom lawyer's curse to be a performer. This sometimes causes me to be the type of person who is always saying something. I have to tell myself to just shut up sometimes.

Especially, *especially*, when dealing with Scarlett, who is also a courtroom lawyer and who also knows how to perform.

Shut up, I told myself.

"So. Alessandro," I said to Scarlett.

She turned the lipstick tube and a phallic stick of pink-red, just the color of a cock, swiveled, erect and poised next to her lips. She guided the stick over her lips, smearing the color on the plump heart shape of her mouth. She made the face all women make while applying lipstick, and then pressed her lips together. She capped the lipstick and dropped it into her handbag. Her eyes fluttered open and met mine.

The corner of her mouth turned up and she rolled her eyes. “I didn’t know it was ‘Alessandro,’ when I signed up,” she said. “Anyway. He’s good.”

“I bet,” I said. The picture, because I’m an idiot but not *that* kind of idiot, was coming together in my mind: Alessandro was nothing more than what he appeared to be. A tennis instructor.

But my blood was boiling and there were still so many loose threads with that story. I was also trying not to look like a jackass, and I still wasn’t 100% certain I was sussing the whole thing out.

Scarlett brought a ferociously bubbling glass of water to her lips. I could hear the fizz from where I was. “*So good*,” she said, her eyes hovering over the rim of the glass.

“At tennis.”

She set the glass down. “He’s a really good teacher.”

It was at this moment that it occurred to me that Scarlett was being sincere. Absolutely sincere. She was making my cock hard, but her sexual innuendo was totally unintentional.

I swiveled the chair around and looked at the pool, where Alessandro had been earlier but I knew full well he was not. “I bet he could teach you all kinds of things,” I said.

I was half-joking around, but only half.

Scarlett was giving me a look of disbelief when I turned back to her. “You’re so stupid,” she said, after a long pause.

“Don’t tell me it never crossed your mind.”

Scarlett picked up her glass and rolled her eyes as she took a sip.

“A nice athletic Italian instructor. You’re bored, your husband is always working... you’re middle-aged -”

“Watch it.”

“-you decide to have a little adventure...”

Scarlett finished the water. “So stupid,” she breathed into the glass.

There was a moment of silence, and then we looked at each other and laughed.

“Anyway, since the surprise is ruined, I can tell you about it.”

My brain worked very quickly on this one. “The surprise about your Italian lover?”

Scarlett ignored me, opening her purse. “I ran it by Dan,” she was saying. “So you have to formally request the time but he said it’d be no big deal as long as some case... Herbert or something... gets wrapped up. Oh. It’s not here,” she continued, rummaging in her bag. “Anyway, we’re going to the French Open, and then we’re going to the French Riviera.”

I was dumbstruck. “Huh?”

She folded her legs up on the highest rung of the bar stool, and I was distracted by the promise of seeing what was between her legs, but she kept her knees close together. “I’m learning tennis so we can play doubles with Dan and Marie.”

I had nothing to say.

I loved tennis. Scarlett had never taken an interest in it, for the reasons I’ve already mentioned: she didn’t like sports involving balls. This gesture was incredibly sweet.

But also erotic, because of Alessandro.

And also...

“How long have you been taking lessons?” I asked.

“I *know!*” Scarlett exclaimed, jumping ahead to what she apparently already knew. “I’m really *good* at it. Who would have thought?” She slid the glass toward James, who was approaching with a foreign and expensive-looking bottle of carbonated water. She nodded to him and he poured her some more. “The lessons really help,” she added. “I mean, Alessandro is probably the reason. He’s such a great instructor.”

My cock flexed again, and my stomach seemed to roll inside of my abdomen. “Hmm,” I said suggestively.

Then I looked at her face. She was expectant, happy. Excited about... Tennis.

“You are really good,” I told her. “I didn’t realize it was you at first.”

“It’s such a good workout,” she said. She looked down at her figure and touched her hips and belly. “I’m surprised you haven’t noticed. I’ve lost ten pounds.”

I was surprised I hadn’t noticed, and the thought only occurred to me at that moment. Because Scarlett did look fucking great.

Why hadn’t I noticed?

“So,” she said, moving on, apparently not in need of a compliment from me. “What are you doing here?”

“Someone told me my wife was having an affair with a young Italian gentleman and I came to see for myself,” I quipped.

Scarlett made a face at me, narrowing her eyes and shaking her head. “I really want to know,” she said.

“That’s why. Frankly I think he’s not as attractive as everyone described him.”

“Fine, don’t tell me.” Scarlett slid off the stool. “But take me to lunch at this place down the street that has salads.”

I followed her after signing the tab that James had produced as magically as if it were movie. “Because you want to look good for your lover?”

Scarlett was shaking her head. “So stupid,” she was saying under her breath.

It was all a big joke now.

All a big joke.

Chapter 2

The real reason I had gone to surprise Scarlett was because I had found the perfect house and wanted her to come see it with me. Dan had suggested I just take the afternoon off and get an offer in if she liked it, because deals moved fast here and we'd missed out on six homes.

Scarlett had this figured out by the time she reached her car, because there was a trail of text messages to that effect. "Oh," she said, and her voice sounded only partially excited. "A house. Uh... okay."

She was standing by her car door, holding the handle, looking at the phone.

"You don't sound very enthusiastic," I said.

Scarlett blew on her hair to get it out of her face. It was sticking to the exposed skin on her back. "No. Good, this is good... I just... I'm so tired of it."

Just like that, in the blazing heat of the black-topped parking lot, squinting into the sun, we were back to reality. And reality was Scarlett being annoyed about everything to do with this move, and me feeling bad about it.

"It" - whatever "it" was that she was tired of, hung in the air, a nondescript proclamation for me to read into however I wanted. She was tired of "it:" Santa Fe, our marriage, this new life, me.

"I'll drive," I offered. "My air is fast-acting."

We had driven one of our cars to New Mexico and Scarlett had ended up with it - a Toyota Camry. A mid-level lawyer's car, old, with a slow-acting air conditioning system that we had only cursed for the two very hot weeks of the year in Chicago.

Here in the desert heat, the Camry took lengthy and frequent verbal abuse, and it was looking like that would be a year-round thing.

Scarlett shrugged and walked toward me, following me to the car the firm had given me use of: a 2017 Lexus LS.

Inside, it cooled down almost immediately. I looked over at Scarlett, whose nipples had hardened beneath the white fabric of her dress. It was a thick fabric, but her nipples were long and cylindrical, and they showed through the gauzy material.

She wasn't wearing a bra.

I was turned on again – not just by her appearance, but the events at the club. I couldn't exactly explain why, but who can explain arousal anyway?

I turned toward her, and then I realized I was being quite an ass. Scarlett was annoyed, and she had leaned her hand on the window and was staring through the windshield.

"Scarlett," I said. I put a hand on her knee.

She didn't push it away, but the way her body went rigid, she might as well have.

I sighed and gripped the wheel. "I know this hasn't been easy -"

"It's not that."

My mouth was still open. "And I know the house thing is -"

"It's not that."

I leaned back in my seat.

"Aren't you hungry?"

"Not really."

"I don't understand -"

"God. Just go." Scarlett was quickly devolving into anger.

I backed up.

If you're married you probably know this drill.

Of course I knew that the thing she was mad about had something to do with the tennis and the plan to go see the house, and probably it had something to do with the way I was acting about something. But hell if I could get my mind around what exactly had soured her mood so much between the bar and the parking lot.

"You want to stop and get something?"

She waved her hand impatiently at me.

"I don't want to go look at a house if you're in a bad mood."

Scarlett waved her hand again. "Just get going, or we're going to miss it like we missed every house so far. I'd live in a box at this point."

I frowned.

"Put your foot on the gas, Green," she said.

It was a conciliatory tone. But Scarlett was still mad.

Still. I've been married almost fifteen years.

I know when to cut my losses.

I had it figured out by the time we reached the house, a bungalow with arched windows and doorways, and brickwork laid into the exterior adobe. The sort of house Scarlett would have oohed and ahed over just weeks before.

Our real estate agent, a smarmy hustler assigned to us by the firm, met us at the door. Neither one of us could ever remember his name. Scarlett followed him around, arms crossed, nodding by lifting her chin when he opened closets and told her how much space was in them.

“Okay,” Real Estate said, snapping his leather-bound folder closed with a soft flump. “I’ll leave you two to talk. I’ll just be outside in my car if you need me.”

He was on the phone before he was out of the house.

“I’m sorry,” I said, as soon as he had left.

Scarlett was leaning on the kitchen counter, arms crossed, face unreadable (which meant she was mad). Her eyebrow arched and two of her fingers lifted and rolled along her arm. She stopped herself from drumming her fingers, because she didn’t like having a “tell” that she was impatient or annoyed. Scarlett worked in labor law and if there was one place it was easy to be annoyed, it was there.

Her lips tightened, almost microscopically.

Did I know what I was sorry for?

Being a lawyer who is married to a lawyer adds an extra layer of challenge to marital disputes. You can bet that each person brings a whole dossier to the table. And the sorts of people who go to law school and stick it out only do that because they really, really enjoy being right.

So every banal dispute between us was a Legal Fight Club.

“I know I’ve been really busy with the firm lately,” I began. Scarlett’s mouth started to open so I held up a finger, slowly, to remind her we had rules around here. No interrupting. Just like a courtroom. “And that the change is causing a lot of stress.”

Scarlett inhaled, so I marched bravely forward before she could interrupt:

“*And*, I know I haven’t been sensitive to that. I’ve been totally caught up in my own stuff. And I’m sorry.”

For a tense moment, Scarlett's face was frozen, and I was worried I had it all wrong.

Then her mouth closed and she lowered her eyelids to take a deep breath.

Scarlett had read somewhere that women have a longer physiological half-life of anger. I didn't read the article myself, but I'd say it seems pretty accurate: evidently women still feel, physiologically, angry, even if the argument is resolved. Their blood pressure is still up and they have all this physical rage, so they start looking for logical reasons to feel that angry.

Which is why you, the man, hear about all this shit that happened 80 years ago at the end of every argument, right when you thought it was over.

Scarlett exhaled.

Then she surprised me by wiping a tear away from her eye.

My heart crumpled and then sank right through my body. Scarlett held up a hand to keep me from coming over to her. "I just... I was so happy to see you because I thought... you'd planned to do something with *me*."

"I know," I said. This is what I had figured out just before we arrived, and I *had* felt like a genius for "getting it." I had felt like so much of a genius that I hadn't really thought about how Scarlett felt.

Now that she was crying, I felt like an ass.

Scarlett sniffed and lifted her chin. She wasn't one to sit around crying about anything. She folded her arms up again and looked around at the house.

"This is a pretty cool house," she said. "I like it."

"Me too," I said.

She looked at me. Her eyes were still wet, which was heart-crushing, and sent me thinking ahead to where we could go for dinner and I could make it up to her.

She whispered: "I have no idea where the fuck we are, though. I was so mad I didn't even pay attention."

I smiled. "It's Santa Fe. We are ten minutes away from everything else."

Scarlett laughed. "We're soooooooo big-city."

"Chicago's soooo much bigger than here," I joked.

"You call ten minutes a commute?" Scarlett said.

I made my way over to her in the bonhomie of the joke exchange and took her hand. “Wanna go out for a late lunch and talk it over? Have some wine? Get drunk in the afternoon?”

Scarlett leaned against me. A mixture of tenderness and arousal swamped me: tenderness, because I’d made her cry, and arousal because the events at the country club had been so... erotic.

I wondered what the hell was wrong with me. My wife was beautiful. Smart, funny, kind. Able to chill out when an argument got out of hand. How did I end up acting like such an idiot sometimes?

“Did we look at the yard?” she asked.

She took me by the hand and walked toward a back door.

We looked out on the sparse but tasteful landscaping, and the glistening blue pool.

“I say we just take it,” she said. “I’m so tired of losing out.”

For whatever reason, the real estate market in Santa Fe was on fire. We had taken a while to catch on to that and let a few houses get contracted right out from under us.

She pressed her fingertips to the glass and tapped on it. “We’ll have to fence that in,” she said.

But before the impact of her statement – a vague allusion to the children we wanted to have – could make its way through my mind, she turned upon me suddenly. “But I still want late-lunch. And margaritas. Let’s get Mexican food.”

She strode away toward the front door. She turned back when she was close, and scrunched up her nose. “You really don’t remember his name at *all*?” she whispered, referring to the agent again.

I shook my head.

Scarlett made a face, but forged ahead.

“So what made you decide on tennis?” I asked Scarlett.

We had moved out onto the porch area of a purple and pink restaurant called, unimaginatively, “Las Margaritas,” where we were, unimaginatively, having margaritas and Mexican food.

I had all kinds of shit to do that night, and an early morning, so a cloud of guilt was hanging over me, but we were having the first really nice

evening we'd had since we'd moved here, and it felt so good I didn't want to end it.

Scarlett was quite intoxicated. Her eyes were wide and alive, her cheeks flushed, her hands fluttering around her like birds. Her smile, which had lately been something she doled out tersely and sparingly, as though there were some kind of rationing going on, was wide and constant. She was telling jokes about enchiladas. It was a great time.

She waved her hands in front of her face at the brain freeze she had just given herself by gulping a frozen margarita. "God, I'm so stupid, why do I keep doing that?" she said, when the pain passed. She re-opened her eyes. "I don't know. It was really Marie who talked me into it. She said Alessandro was really good, and I thought... well, Dan's so into it, and those other guys too."

She held a finger up. "But, I did it in secret so if I sucked at it no one would know about it but me."

I shook my head slowly. I was still smiling, still floating on a high, but something Scarlett had said was bugging me, threatening to bring me down.

"You're really good," I said, genuinely. "For someone who just started... how long have you been at it?"

"Six weeks. But, you know, almost every day."

"Still," I said.

I was struggling to maintain my smile, and I looked at my drink. I was so drunk I wouldn't be able to drive home, and maybe those complications were starting to bug me.

No. It was something else, something I was too drunk to figure out at the moment.

Scarlett leaned back in her chair. A breeze picked up and gave us a refreshing chill. "I could get used to this," she said, smiling.

I smiled. Her comment took away my angst temporarily.

Scarlett had grown up in Chicago, gone to school back east, and considered herself a Chicago woman, born and bred. People from Chicago were often like that. So it had been a big deal for her to move here, where it was too hot to go outside until nighttime most of the year, the town was small and the streets – which she derided constantly – were so wide they looked like highways. She hated the colors, the adobe, the rugs and pots, the

lack of snow and cold, the heat, the smallness of the city, the slowness of the day. She also hated the firm that had hired me, and she didn't care for rich people and excess, so she professed to hate belonging to a country club, driving a Lexus, and things like playing tennis.

"You look good in your tennis outfit," I said.

Scarlett smiled. "I do."

And then it came around the corner, blaring in my ear as though through a foghorn placed against my head:

I didn't even know Alessandro was the instructor.

I blinked slowly, checking and re-checking my memory, to see if she had really said that.

"So," I said, leaning back in my own chair and bringing the margarita to my lips. "Marie is the one who recommended Alessandro?"

Scarlett hadn't looked at me, she was too busy stabbing at her slushy margarita. She nodded and took a sip. As she was answering, I could see that she realized that I was trapping her, that she had mis-spoken somewhere.

"Yeah," she said, and she nodded too much. She squinted at her margarita.

"She recommended him because he's a good..."

Scarlett rolled her eyes. "Tennis instructor. I lied, okay, you got me. I said I didn't know it was him and I did."

She lifted her drink and settled back into her chair, wriggling a little. Challenging me.

I had to admit, I was surprised by her charging right back at me. It wasn't her style.

"Why'd you lie?" I asked innocently.

Scarlett chewed on her straw. "Please," she said. "For just this reason."

I was pleased to see that she was staying in a good mood.

"What reason?" I said, playing dumb, but in an exaggerated way so she knew I was joking. I wanted to keep a hold on that light, festive mood we were in.

"This reason. Because you were going to be like... "ooh, Alessandro....pooh, he's so good-looking, I bet he's teaching you so much tennis...' blah blah blah."

I shrugged. "He *is* good-looking."

I felt the return of the same odd feeling I'd had at the club earlier. Not jealousy, exactly. Not the kind of feeling that made me want to punch Alessandro in the face, but rather a feeling that I wanted to keep talking about him, keep extracting details about him with my wife. The idea of him being with her was like a hot coal, but instead of recoiling from it I wanted to juggle with it, letting it scorch into my skin.

Scarlett smiled coyly. "Is he? I hadn't noticed."

I paused.

"So you're there all day... with Alessandro. God what a name. And he's, like, grinding up behind you to show you how to improve your serve, and you're just like: 'Meh.' I'm not attracted to this hot Italian man?"

As I said this, I was starting to realize that I *wanted* her to be attracted to him. Sort of. Somehow. Why *was* that?

Scarlett leaned on the table and bit the end of her straw while looking at me impishly. It was the hottest expression I'd ever seen on her face, and I had a thought flash through my mind that if she looked at me like that while she sucked on my cock I'd come in a second. "*Is* he Italian?" she asked. "I hadn't noticed."

"He's gotta be hitting on you all the time," I said.

Scarlett's mood changed for an instant. Something moved across her face. It could have been guilt, seriousness, too much margarita, a chill. I don't know. She lowered her eyes and looked at her drink before she composed herself and looked back at me. "It's about the same as any guy," she said quickly. "Seriously. He's a very professional instructor."

She let go of her margarita and flopped back against her chair.

"I have a hard time believing that," I said. I wasn't sure why I was pressing the issue.

Scarlett gave me an appreciative laugh. "Well..."

She waved her hand in the air. I knew full well that she meant "Well, that's how it is, so shut up now," but I was...well.... Being male and disregarding all obvious road signs in my quest for... who knew what?

"Well...?"

Scarlett looked at me incredulously now. "*Well*," she said. "Well, *well*. That's all there is to it."

Both of us were drunk, so I think neither one of really knew, for sure, what we were talking about at that point.

I knew what I wanted to talk about, though.

“How many hours do you spend with him every day?”

Scarlett leaned her head back and ran her fingers through her hair.

“Are you jealous?”

“Should I be?”

Scarlett rolled her eyes again.

“Don’t tell me you don’t find him attractive,” I pressed.

Let the record reflect that I was, inside of my head, telling myself to shut up at this point. It’s just that Drunk-William was talking now, and *that* guy...

He never shuts up.

“Don’t be stupid,” Scarlett said breezily.

“Don’t be stupid, you do find him attractive, or don’t be stupid you’re going to try and tell me you don’t?”

I tried my best to make my tone playful.

Scarlett stirred her drink. “Of course he’s attractive. Where is this going?”

“Would you sleep with him?”

The words were out of my mouth before I could stop them.

Scarlett stared at me for a moment.

Then she laughed and reached for my phone. “I’m calling a cab,” she said. “You’re drunk.”

“Use Uber,” I bossed. “Would you? Sleep with him?”

“Uber is crazy, and takes too long here, and partially illegal, and I’m calling a cab.”

“Would you?”

Scarlett glared at me as she held the phone to her ear.

The things I had just been saying were finally, finally, making their way through the fog of my brain, and I decided I needed to back-track. I made a puppy-dog face. Scarlett broke into a smile as she told the cab where we were.

She placed the phone on the table.

“Would you?” I asked again.

Scarlett paused, stirring her drink.

In my mind, a little vignette played out, so realistic that it felt as though it really happened, and my face lit on fire and my heart crashed against my chest. In the vignette, Scarlett stirred her drink, placed her puffy lips on the straw and closed them, just like she would close her mouth around the tip of my cock every time she started to give me a blow job.

“Maybe I already have,” she paused to say.

And then she gave me that simmering look over her drink.

In real life, though, Scarlett rolled her eyes again. “I’m married, you idiot. And I love you, of course,” she added.

This answer, which should have thrilled me in its sincerity and obvious honesty, actually disappointed me. I even furrowed my brow trying to concentrate on why that might be.

“I don’t even think he’s that good-looking,” Scarlett added. “He’s sort of... I dunno. Too, like... Guido for me.”

My heart leaped inside my chest.

“Too Guido,” I said slowly.

“That’s a poor choice of politically incorrect -”

“So you’d sleep with some other guy, if he was a little ‘less Guido,’” I mused.

Scarlett rolled her eyes.

The phone buzzed on the table. I saw the yellow of a cab in the corner of my eye and realized we hadn’t paid the check, wondered how they’d gotten here so fast, raised my hand to get the waitress’s attention. Scarlett stood up. There was a lot of hustle and bustle, so I can’t be sure if she said this in real life or if it was just something I hoped she said:

“Maybe.”

But chairs scraped over the sound of her voice, if it was ever there at all, and Scarlett dropped her purse and squealed about it, and we very laboriously made our way out of the small gated cement porch area (of the restaurant we would later learn was in a really bad part of town, by Santa Fe standards), and fell into the cab.

The moment, temporarily, forgotten.

There’s a need, I think, to insert here that this night with Scarlett was one of the better nights we’d had in a long time. It ended with us going home, Scarlett claiming to be “pooped,” and then her looking at me across

the smoothed covers of the bed in a hesitant way, like maybe, maybe, she would change her mind, cross the coverlet on her knees, play with my tie, suggest that we have sex.

I hesitated, too. Maybe Scarlett was waiting for *me* to act, but after so many nights of making an overture to her and getting turned down, I was out of energy for going there. We looked at each other, and a hopeful static was in the air, for the first time in a long time. Like maybe someday we could get back to where we used to be. Having sex every night. Hell, sex once a week at this point would have been something.

But Scarlett turned, and went into the bathroom, closing the door to take her clothes off and shower. Whatever was in the air between us evaporated as fast as water in this crazy desert.

It was easy to blame it all on New Mexico, on the move, on this arid wasteland with just Santa Fe and its too-bright buildings hunched over on the streets. On making more money and forgetting where we came from, on the stress, on the weight of the decision to have or not have kids lingering in the air and wasting away without anyone making a decision about it, and on the time ticking away.

But I knew that we had started to grow apart long before any of that. And what I wanted, more than anything in the world, was for Scarlett to look across the bed at me like that, and just once in a while, make the long journey over to my side of the bed with an impish smile on her face and her hands reaching out for me.

Chapter 3

The blazing sun had already sunk from the high sky into the red earth by the time I got home to our temporary town home in South Capitol. In New Mexico, heat radiates from the baked ground in the early night, while the air temperature drops drastically. Scarlett liked how it warmed her feet but gave her neck a chill.

A chill of my own rolled down my spine as I looked at the empty house, black windows, paper in the center of the driveway. I picked it up (papers were delivered unwrapped here, which we found fascinating every day) and went through the front door.

“Scarlett?” I said, and felt silly because it was pretty obvious that Scarlett wasn’t home.

I frowned and took out my phone, which was already piling up with work-related messages and alerts. It took me about ten minutes standing in the dark with the door open, to swipe through them all, marking unread those I needed to come back to later, to determine that Scarlett had not called me or sent a message.

I looked behind me at the silent street and kicked the door closed.

The model-home scent of the condo engulfed me. I flicked on a light and started to message Scarlett.

[Me]: *you okay? Just got home and looks like you haven’t been here all day. Where are you?*

Before I had even finished the text, though, my mind had already traveled to Alessandro. A cold fist gripped my heart and squeezed the blood up into my head, which felt suddenly like it was going to explode, along with my heart. The air rang in my ears, like millions of tiny bees buzzing. I was breathing fast.

But worse than all that, I was sort of enjoying it.

Really enjoying it.

I made my way to the kitchen, the whole time imagining various scenarios: Alessandro spooning my wife on the tennis court, showing her how to hold her racket. Her skin flecked with goosebumps as his breath

grazed the back of her neck and he said something tennis-instructory against her skin. Her pussy pulsing with a pearly gush of liquid as she felt the shape of his enormous cock taking form against her lower back.

Or was he trying a more traditional route? Seducing her slowly? Were they flirting at the poolside bar, moving closer and closer to each other, losing track of time, lips just inches apart as they talked about all the things new lovers talk about to lure the other in?

My cock was getting hard as I thought about it, and then I started imagining Alessandro peeling my wife's tennis skirt away from her bottom, bending her over the ball machine, dipping his fingers into her pussy to taste her juices, and sinking into her with his lower lip between his teeth. Saying something in Italian while he stretched her open and her eyes went wide with disbelief at the size of his cock -

My phone, which I had slipped into my pocket, hummed against my burgeoning dick, making me jump and thicken at the same time.

[Scarlett]: *OMG! I totally lost track of time. Be there in... you guessed it... twenty. Did you eat?*

I read the message and re-read the message and went on a thousand paranoid loops.

Why would Scarlett not tell me where she was, or who she was with? Why wouldn't she say what she was doing? Why wouldn't she reassure me that she wasn't with Alessandro? Was it because the image I had conjured, of their poolside chat, was not so far off?

I lifted my eyes and stared at a disturbing piece of art that hung in the kitchen. It was a tortured-looking Anasazi figure, twisted like he was on the rack. It was a strange choice for a kitchen.

Innocent people don't cover their tracks, I told myself. If she didn't reassure me that she *wasn't* with Alessandro, then it was probably a sign that she wasn't.

I made myself a drink and kept stewing about it.

Since last week, Scarlett had seemed to push the whole encounter, and everything that we said about Alessandro, out of her mind. Things went back to the way they had been, at least for her: she didn't behave as if anything had changed.

And it infuriated me, because for me, it had. For me, my thoughts were crowded out constantly by the thought of her doing something with Alessandro.

I drank too much while I waited, glowering, for her to get home. The whole time hoping – just a little – that she would come home and confess that she was late because she had done a very, very bad thing. I didn't know why I wanted that. I just imagined it, and re-imagined it, for the whole half hour I waited.

"Hey," Scarlett said, pushing through the door with a shopping bag in each hand. "Can you help me with this?"

I took a bag and opened it. I half-expected and mostly wanted to find a racy lingerie set folded neatly at the bottom, looking up at me, guiltily stained at the crotch. Instead, I found what looked like a bath mat.

Scarlett dropped the bags and pulled the long strap of her "casual" bag over her head. She always wore her bags across her chest so people couldn't steal from her (Chicago born and bred). She sighed loudly. "I'm sorry. I ran into Marie at Bed Bath and Beyond, and then we had a coffee and started talking about the house... you know she's really very interesting? I really hit it off with her today."

I looked at my phone. 8:27.

"That was *some* coffee," I said. "What time did you run into her?"

"Look at this shower curtain," Scarlett said, digging in another bag and ignoring my question. "It's got all the elements on it."

I looked at the plastic curtain and my eyes fell on the word "lithium."

I was thinking about the paper, the dark house, the time between tennis lessons and now, shopping and coffee.

I looked Scarlett up and down. She was wearing a pair of capris, which fit a little loosely on her, and the same light jacket I had seen at the club. The zipper opened and revealed a black Lycra sports bra.

"You have tennis today?" I asked, trying to sound casual.

Scarlett bent down. "Every day," she said. "We are going to kill those guys."

"But... you didn't come home first?"

Scarlett stood up. She half-closed her eyes and looked as if she were searching for the answer. Then she shook her head. "I don't... think so..."

My face must have registered alarm. She punched me on the shoulder. “No. I went for a swim and then I went shopping because I was already on the other side of town.”

She moved her zipper up and down. It seemed playful to me, but she did it with a distracted air.

I was probably imagining things.

She scooped up her bags and marched into the kitchen. “Why were you so late?” she asked, and then added to it immediately. “Forget I said that, I’m sure it’s really boring.”

“Lawyer-stuff,” I said. It was an old joke between us. Scarlett played along, primping her blonde hair and making a vacant, bimboesque face. “You *know* I don’t understand that,” she said. Her mouth turned upward in a smile as she started to put something away in the cupboard, but there was an element in the smile that was unusual. Secretive.

I took in her form as she crouched bouncily to put things in the lower cupboards. “Your legs look really good,” I erupted.

She tossed her ponytail over her shoulder. “Thank you,” she said solemnly. “I’ve been waiting for that complement forever. Do you have any idea how many jelly beans I’ve turned down at the store? And black coffee. Ugh.”

I approached her so that I would be close to her when she stood up. My palms were itching to touch her now; already I could feel myself pulling her capris away, hear them dropping with soft sound on the kitchen tile, smell the scent of her as I turned her around and drew my hand between her legs.

My intentions, though, were not purely to have sex with my wife.

There was a sinister element lurking beneath my plans: a desire to find that she wasn’t wearing any panties, and for her to have no explanation for that. A desire to find her panties soaked, or worse yet, crusted dry with liquid that, when I brought it to my nose, would bear the unmistakable briny scent of another man’s cum. Alessandro’s, of course.

It was these sinister intentions that drove me past the point where I usually gave up and decided that my advances would be rejected. It was because I wanted to catch her at something that I was able to move on, keep going.

Scarlett stood up and I moved closer to her. She had a faint bleachy scent lingering on her skin and in her hair, and it testified to her claim to have gone swimming, but I ignored it in favor of my own demented fantasies.

“So... you keep a suit at the pool?” I said.

Scarlett’s lashes swept across the counter and then lazily opened. She looked at me strangely and then squinted, because it didn’t take long for her to hear the investigative tone to my voice.

“I bought one. And thank you for reminding me, it’s in the car in a plastic bag.”

She pushed me out of her way with a gentle prodding of two fingertips, a gesture that was designed to let me know that *she* had some idea I was being a little strange.

Though I also knew that she didn’t know the half of it. How could she? What sort of woman suspects her husband of enjoying the idea that she’s fucking another man?

Definitely not Scarlett.

As she passed me, I tried to detain her. I slid my hands over her firm waist, taking note of the fact that she seemed even fitter than the night before. I brushed over the front of her capris, feeling for the telltale ribbed edges of a pair of panties. Then I swatted her bottom gently as she walked away.

She cast a smoldering look behind her as she exited the kitchen. “Be right back,” she said, and then said something about mold and how she couldn’t grow it in a petri dish here, but she better get her suit anyway.

My cock had been stiffening against my pants that whole time, but the sultry face she made solidified my dick completely with one last pulse.

I brought my thumbnail to my forehead to scratch it and looked over at the darkening kitchen window, at my reflection there. Here was a guy, forty-two years old, trim because he had always been skinny but slightly pudgy with age, good head of hair but drooping face, deepening lines. Here was a guy with a great job and a really, really attractive beautiful wife... thinking, gleefully, about her sleeping with another man.

The same odd, not-quite jealousy burned through my torso. It was a cold burn, like a liquid was sinking through my organs, eating them away

like an acid. It wasn't exactly "glee" I felt; no, the sensation was more perverse. It was a kind of euphoric pain.

I shook my head as I heard the front door open and close for the second time. Scarlett breezed through with a plastic bag and headed toward the basement steps.

"New suit, huh," I found myself saying. "Were you going to show it to me?"

Scarlett stopped, holding the bag in her hand as if what I had just said made it almost tragic to continue toward the door. "It's... wet," she said, confusion on her face.

The moment was awkward. Unnecessarily awkward, which only served to fuel my fantasies. Scarlett looked at me for a minute, and when I didn't say anything, she shrugged, gave me a polite laugh, and walked haltingly toward the basement door.

She slapped the light off when she reached the top of the stairs and gently kicked the door closed. "Well... what should we do for dinner? Did you eat already?"

"I know what I'd like to eat."

It came out of my mouth before I even had time to ponder saying it. When I did say it, it sounded good. Very manly, very alpha.

Bolder than I had been in a long time.

Scarlett was dumbstruck. Then she smiled. "Uh... okay," she said, grinning. "Really? Right now?" I watched her eyes flick over to the stove clock and then back at me. An incredulous grin was forming on her lips, deepening with each passing second. She folded her arms over her stomach. "What's gotten into you?" she asked.

"I'm a man."

Scarlett waved her hand like she didn't need to hear any more. "I'm going to just take a shower," she said.

I practically pounced on her. I moved forward, closer, putting the ten-years-of-marriage version of the "moves" on her. I took her hand in mine and placed her other hand on my hip. "No need to shower," I said.

Scarlett gave me a weird look. She shook her head and wriggled away. "I smell like a pool," she said. "And I feel grimy from sweating so much. It's so hot here—"

“I like your sweat,” I said, my hands reaching for her waist. She had her back to me now, she was slipping away.

I was aroused by the fact that she wanted to shower: was it because she wanted to erase the scent of Alessandro?

I let her go and followed behind to our master bedroom. I sat on the bed while she peeled away her jacket and sports bra, freeing her fistfuls of pert, pink-tipped breasts. She walked to the bathroom and turned on the water. I could see her in the mirror, unbuttoning her capris, which dropped loosely to the floor. Her panties were white, and she shimmied out of them. Then she left them on the floor, in the pile with the capris.

I gave it some time before I approached her, rounding the corner of the wall that minimally divided the bathroom from the bedroom. I admired her body as she leaned back into the stream of water, enjoying the sheen of water on her skin, the glow of sun on her limbs. The shapes of various sports bras crisscrossed her tanned glow in various shades of wheat and cream. The place where her tennis skirt met her belly was a similarly blurred line, though the shades of her skin did not contrast as much.

I leaned over and picked up her capris and the panties lying atop them, as if she had removed them as one unit, the holes resting partially with the shape of her legs intact.

“So I think you might have been right,” she said, loudly and suddenly, just as I was bringing her panties toward my nose to sniff them. I was startled and jumped a little.

“About what?” I asked, as I ran my thumb over the center of her panties. Damp, but not crusty or wet.

A normal man, I thought, would have been relieved that his wife hadn’t borked her tennis instructor and then spilled cum into her panties for her husband to find. But the melancholic bite of disappointment gnawed at me from inside my chest.

“Uh... well, about... you know how you were, like, making that joke about Alessandro?”

The man’s name pierced through my disappointment and ignited my jealousy anew. “Uh...” I said, taking her clothes to the hamper and bringing them to my nose as I did. The tangy scent of her pussy, lightly dusted with the bleachy scent of the pool, filled my nostrils.

“You know how you were like, oh, I *bet* Marie recommended him, kind of insinuating that he was some kind of... I don’t know... gigolo?”

My heart was racing, but I feigned disinterest. “Mmm-hmm.”

The shower water turned off. I turned around to watch Scarlett as she grabbed a towel and wrapped it around herself. She flipped her head over and wrapped it up in another towel. While she was upside-down she spoke.

“I think you might be right.”

I tried to keep myself calm and somewhat dignified, despite the fact that Scarlett had turned the conversation in a direction that was, improbably, incredibly exciting to me. “Why’s that?”

Scarlett flipped her head up, and her face was bright red, draining slowly to her natural, cream color. She had not forgotten sunscreen on her face, which had gained color but slowly and evenly. Her cheeks were a little sun-kissed. She looked younger, freshly-scrubbed and sunburned like that.

Her eyes went wide. “Let’s just say that, uh... Marie was asking some *very suggestive* questions. About *him*.”

“Like what?” I said. Again, I was trying to be casual.

Scarlett put her hand up to the very large towel she’d twisted into a turban atop her head. The towel had been part of a set, given by an obscure relative at our wedding. It was plum-colored and so large we rarely used it. It was twisted almost two feet high on her head. Her mouth made that odd smile again. “Just... things. She was like, ‘oh, has Alessandro showed you his *special serve* yet,’ but with this sort of wink-wink face, you know?” Scarlett shook her head, and the towel threatened to collapse. She pushed it back up and it pulled her head the other way. “And then I started thinking about it, and some of the things he does are sort of like...”

She flipped her head down again and started to rearrange the towel, without finishing the sentence.

“Like what?” I asked as dryly as I could manage. “Like he’s hitting on you? You can’t seriously have just figured that out.”

Scarlett sighed and flipped her head up, leaving the towel in a pile on the floor. She ran her fingers through her wet hair, while I stared at the color draining from her face again. The towel on her body was coming apart slightly, sliding down, revealing the dark crevice between her breasts.

“There’s, like, regular flirting, though... and then, you know... something more.”

I arched an eyebrow. “Regular flirting?”

Scarlett rolled her eyes. “You know what I mean. How every guy, in every interaction with every woman is sort of like, leaving the door open in a way.”

She approached the sink, looking into the mirror and admiring her face for a moment before pulling a drawer open. “I just have to put some aloe on my face,” she said.

“Leaving the door open?” I asked.

“Yeah,” she said cheerfully, squirting some green gel out of a tube. I found it erotic, watching the gel squeeze from the end of the tube, cliché or no.

Scarlett continued. “Like, you know, how every guy, even if they’re married or you’re way out of their league, is kind of... I don’t know, nice or something, even though there’s no real chance of anything between you, but there’s like some point-zero zero zero zero zero zero zero one percent chance that the world will end and you’ll be the only two people left and have to repopulate it or something? *That*.”

I snorted as I laughed. “I had no idea you had all of us all figured out,” I said.

Her fingers, which were smearing the aloe on her cheeks sensually, stopped in mid-air and her eyes shifted to look at mine in the reflection. She was drawing her face taut by lowering her jaw to make an elongated, sad “o” with her mouth. “You’re kidding.”

“All the ladies know this? You girls aren’t supposed to know this.”

She started dabbing the aloe again and rolled her eyes, responding to my question as I made my joke. “God, I hope so.”

She kept smearing.

I was fascinated to discover that women had us all figured out, and I ordinarily might have put up a better fight on the part of men everywhere (like, the chance needs to be a little better than all that, and certain *really* unattractive women are exempt...) but I was more interested in something else.

“So Alessandro’s up to more than that?”

At first Scarlett kept dabbing, and shrugged, and I thought that might be all she had to say about it. But she became suddenly animated and turned

toward me, holding the aloe in one hand and touching the end of it with her fingertip.

I wondered if she was doing it deliberately, rubbing her fingertip over the end of a tube that was welling up, oozing liquid from one end. She did this for a bit longer than seemed purely natural, and she had a vacant expression on her face. Then she smiled shyly. “I don’t know. You know? Maybe Marie just planted the idea in my head.”

She turned back to the mirror.

“But what does he *do* that makes you think he’s flirting... you know, *more* than just... in-case-of-Apocalypse-flirting?”

She met my eyes in the reflection of the mirror again. “I don’t know. He just says stuff that’s a little...” she looked up at the ceiling as though the answer would be there. Then she sighed and shook her head slightly. Her fingers busied themselves capping the aloe. “Oh. You know what? I can’t even think of an example. I’m just being silly.”

She turned around and faced me.

I must have had a peculiar look on my face, because she cocked her head and extended her arms toward me. “Oh, don’t be like that. I’m totally talking out of my ass.”

“Speaking of your ass,” I said, moving toward her.

I liked the feeling I had, that nothing was going to stop me from trying to get my wife to have sex with me. As I pulled her by her hips back toward me, and slid my fingers under the slightly damp towel along her smooth, smooth skin, I wondered what it was that had been stopping us from doing this all the time, every night. What had stopped me from even trying?

Scarlett was receptive to me. Her body melted against mine and she smiled into the mirror. I pushed her wet hair away from her neck and kissed her, tasting a little bit of sweat that had somehow not been washed away, and inhaling the fresh scent of her shampoo. I put my hands back on her hips and went under the towel again.

Scarlett helped me out, unwrapping the towel at her breasts. She turned toward me, and the terry cloth bunched and fell away, giving me glimpses of her creamy skin, access to her thighs, blockading certain parts of her body with bunched-up thickness.

She wriggled out of it, and I pushed it away. She was naked, leaning against the counter, and I couldn't help stealing a glance in the mirror at her bottom, at the firmness of it and the pale color of her skin where her tennis skirt was worn. The dark tan came all the way to just below where ass curved out. My cock pulsed as I thought about Alessandro watching her, standing behind her, with so much of her skin hanging out of her little skirts.

We kissed, and it was a lusty, passionate kiss. I couldn't even remember the last time we'd kissed like that, full of excitement and promise. A kiss that was definitely going somewhere. I worked my fingers into her wet hair and pressed her mouth against mine as we explored each other's mouths in wet movements and heavy breaths.

She pushed against me and we walked, still locked at the lips, back toward the bed.

My free hand had been exploring her body, feeling out the places where it was different, thinner, more toned, and enjoying the exploration. My fingers had also come across things that were just vaguely nagging in the back of my mind: a bumpy patch of shaved skin at the crease of her thigh, more smoothness than usual. Minute changes that made me wary.

But they were not enough to stop me from enjoying having sex with my wife for the first time in a long time.

She pushed me back on to the bed and I started to fumble with my suit pants as she let the towel fall away from her body and kicked it aside with her foot. My eyes moved over the leanness of her muscles, particularly where her tennis lessons had sculpted her the most: her belly was taut and her legs were toned to perfection.

Her pussy was shaved to a neat landing strip, and this was new, and made her look thinner and younger. I put my hand out to touch her there as she climbed onto me. The scent of shampoo and soap hit my nostrils in the first wave, but it was followed by a wave of her tangy pussy juices.

I slid my hand down to her pussy, felt the light bumps on one thigh, the smooth skin everywhere else, and my cock throbbed. My thumb barely touched the smooth inner lips and a glob of her excitement dripped out, hot and sweet-scented.

I reached up for her, unable to really contain myself. She didn't seem like she wanted to engage in much foreplay either: she climbed onto me and

freed my cock at the same time, so that as I grabbed her and rolled over, she was guiding me inside of her.

Her pussy was a liquid sheathe of heat as I sank into her. Her feet rose up to enclose me, something that she had done a lot when we were first married but not so much these days. Her ankles rubbed against my lower back as her thighs squeezed me. Her cunt throbbed around my cock, and our mouths met as we fucked wildly, quickly, like we were new lovers.

When she came, which she did quickly, she dug her heels into my back and her fingernails into my shoulder blades. Her body arched up from the sheets and she ground her smooth pelvis against me. The walls of her vagina squeezed me tightly, milking the building orgasm from my cock.

I watched her face, pleased, as she moaned and her pussy pulsed around my dick. Then I felt myself letting go, filling her up, lying on top of her with her wet hair reaching out to stick to my face. Beneath me I could feel the hard nipples at the center of her soft, full breasts, and her abdomen twitching wildly with her pussy as she recovered from her orgasm.

We lay like that for a while, and then I rolled off of her and propped myself up on the bed. We were sideways, my clothes rumped, the duvet cover sliding around and the pillows akimbo. It felt good to have messed up that stupid town house bed, for the first time since we had moved. We had sex once, but it was a perfunctory, morning, under-the-sheets and without much enthusiasm sex.

This was different.

I kissed her, and she smiled. We lay like that for a while, enjoying the afterglow. Then she scooted up to the top of the bed, pulling me with her. She got under the covers. The air conditioning was making her cold: I could see the goosebumps all over her skin.

I trailed my fingers down her stomach, and then along her thigh, into the crease between her leg and pussy, until I found the bumpy area that she had shaved. "What's this all about?" I asked.

She looked down, as though she didn't know what I was talking about. "That? Oh God, isn't it awful? That swimsuit is teeny-tiny and I had to do something about it quick, so I shaved, but like, in a hurry. I have to go to a spa or something and fix it."

I was hot inside again, jealousy and arousal entwining, lighting each other up. My wife didn't shave hastily, she didn't wear teeny-tiny bikinis,

she didn't do things in a hurry.

"Why were you in such a hurry?" I asked.

She was starting to doze. She moved her shoulder as an answer.

"Were you meeting Alessandro?" I asked. And as I said it, my mind lit up with all sorts of ideas. Maybe she had wanted to "run into him" at the pool. Maybe she had bought the teeny suit so that when she did, he saw her body, her lean muscle, her rounded belly, her perfect breasts, dangling from the teeny suit.

Why else, I thought paranoidly, would she have even gone swimming in a teeny suit? Not for the sport of it. Not for a tan. Not even, really, to cool off, because if there as one thing Scarlett hated it was chlorine in her hair.

Scarlett opened one eye to peer at me with a cool curiosity. "What?"

She pushed herself up on her elbow, rolling in my direction, and looked at me.

"Well," I said. "This trip to the pool is just... you know. Curious."

As I was saying this, I was moving my hand along the shape of her body, following the slope of her bottom down to her lower back, grazing each bump of her spine, dipping down to brush over her ribs. It was a strange, tender thing to be doing while simultaneously interrogating my wife about potential infidelity.

Scarlett was missing none of it. She cast her eyes down at my hand and then put on her thinky face.

"Are you... what the hell are you up to?" she asked.

"Just wondering why you bought such a tiny bikini. And just *had* to go to the pool this afternoon after lessons."

She gave a toss of her wet hair, and it slapped her skin. Her expression was defiant, and curious. "It was the only suit they had."

"And you just had to have it. Today. You couldn't wait until you went shopping."

Scarlett had rolled slightly to her side, with some prodding from my hand, and I could now make my way to her nipple with my fingertips.

"What are you getting at?" she asked. Her eyes dropped to my cock. "Are you getting off on that?"

The question wasn't necessarily accusatory. It was more like a question of curiosity.

Scarlett's eyes flew up to meet mine.

I was in a state of excitement that made it almost impossible to breathe. My fingers were on her nipple now, stroking it to bring it to life. My heart was beating erratically inside my chest, and my cock pulsed against her thigh, as if to answer for me. “Well,” I said. “Did you? Did you buy the suit for Alessandro to see you in it?”

Scarlett’s mouth fell open a little. Just a fraction of an inch. It was on its way to denial, to expressing shock and outrage. But in the very twilight of its mission, it stopped. Her cheeks flared with a bright red that made my cock pulse again, and her eyes dilated. Scarlett, paradoxically (because she was a lawyer), was a terrible liar.

Her eyes dropped and she rolled over onto her back. “Well, maybe,” she admitted.

Then she turned her head to look at me.

I bit my lower lip.

“You don’t seem too mad about that,” she said.

My heart was really racing now. Her voice carried a hint of admonishment, but it was mostly curiosity.

An open door?

“It’s kind of hot,” I managed to say, in the most neutral tone I could muster.

Scarlett recoiled just a little, and looked me up and down. My heart began to sink. She thought I was crazy. I could see the whole conversation going wrong, wildly wrong, ending in a fight. I wished I hadn’t started it.

But then she rolled onto her stomach again, resting her chin on her forearms. “Really?” she asked. Then she turned to look at me. “Not *really*.”

I leaned onto the pillow. What *did* I really mean by what I had said?

“I mean,” she continued, before I had a chance to speak, “how is it *hot*?”

I sighed at this point. Heavily.

She rolled onto her side again. “What’s *that* supposed to mean?”

The conversation was taking a wrong turn. I could tell. I shouldn’t have sighed. But the sigh had been more one of exasperation with myself than with anything else. I didn’t know exactly why it was hot, or how it was hot, or why I had an erection thinking about my wife cheating on me with Alessandro.

Scarlett looked like she might start *turning* scarlet if I didn't come up with something. Then she put a hand on my arm. "Remember what Joyce said."

Joyce was our marriage counselor from a few years before, who had advised us during a rough patch that when we didn't know what to say to the other person, and had a lot of thoughts in our head about why we didn't know what to say, it was best to just say all *that*, instead of making something up and muddying the waters.

"I don't know," I admitted. "I don't know why it's hot, or why I... like really, I do not know. I just started getting really.... turned on, by the idea. You know?"

Scarlett was looking at me. "By the idea of...?"

I went back to lying on my back. My cock was betraying me, making a tent in the sheets. I sighed again.

"Me flirting with Alessandro?" Scarlett suggested.

Her hand moved to my cock, and I pulsed beneath the sheet that had dragged with me when I rolled over. She twisted her hand to get it under the sheet and moved closer to me. "Me flirting with Alessandro?" she murmured. My cock twitched. I closed my eyes.

"Something else? Not me actually sleeping with him."

My cock bounced, pretty much, in her hand. I kept my eyes closed because I really couldn't face her reaction if it was as bad as I thought it could be.

"I know it's crazy," I said. "It's just... just a fantasy."

Her fingers closed around my cock and moved with my foreskin, rolling along the length of my shaft. "Hmm," she said, and I opened my eyes. "And what do I do in this fantasy?"

I stared at her. She was looking at me like she really wanted to know.

My mouth started to open, but then I had a danger signal start blinking in the back of my mind.

As any married man knows, there are all sorts of situations that arise in a marriage in which a wife says some version of "tell me the truth." And you get to thinking, when you're a rookie, that maybe the truth will set you free, or be a good idea, or something like that. Your marriage counselor tells you it will, and your wife tells you it will.

But it is not.

Not. Not, *not* a good idea.

The warning light was blinking at me furiously. This is one of *those* situations, it was saying.

“I..” I closed my mouth. Sometimes something as simple as forcing your mouth to close can save the day.

But Scarlett had this tousled hair, this flushed pink glow on her cheeks. Sweat hadn’t fully dried on her neck, and her lips were puffy from kissing. Her left nipple was slightly red from where I had bitten into her flesh, and it stood erect on the creamy mound of her breast. Her hand was stroking me, slowly, up and down, holding my twitching cock. Her eyes were wide and seemed to suck me in. She seemed excited.

“It’s mostly you taking a shower with him,” I found myself saying. “After tennis.”

Scarlett twisted her head a little in her hand. “When I’m all sweaty?”

My cock flexed, and her eyes lit up. She leaned closer to me, so her lips were next to my mouth. “Does he lick the sweat off my skin, or does he sneak into the shower when I’m already all wet?”

I closed my eyes again, and tried to think about something to distract me, because Scarlett had somehow sent me careening toward the edge of an orgasm in about ten seconds.

Right after we had just fucked.

She seemed to sense that I was getting close, because she slowed her stroking of my cock and drew her fingers along my shaft, pulling them together over the crown, playfully swirling the precum around on my swollen head.

I opened my eyes. I sucked in my breath, because I wasn’t sure what else to do to try and keep myself from just losing it.

“Or maybe he just lathers me up with soap, and gets me all slippery and wet before he bends me over...?”

My cock, freed from her grip, swung around wildly and got away from her fingertips.

Her eyes widened.

I couldn’t take much more of her teasing, and I didn’t want her to say anything about my perverted fantasy, so I grabbed her hair and pulled her mouth to mine. It had been my intention to roll over on top of her, and sink

into her pussy again, but Scarlett's body pushed against me and she climbed up on top of me.

Her thighs slid over my ribs, and a streak of warm wetness cooled in the air as she slid down my body to position her bottom on my cock. I could feel the softness of her butt, the slick folds of her pussy where they had caught against my anatomy. My cock throbbed against her body.

Scarlett rarely sat on top of me like this – it wasn't really my thing or hers. But the view was spectacular: the firm teardrop of her tits, upturned at the end, where her hardened nipples sliced at the cool air. The oval of her belly-button, shallower since she had lost a little weight. The length of her statuesque neck.

She squeezed her legs slightly against my thighs to rise up on them. She dropped a hand to grasp my cock, all the while staring into my eyes. I felt the tip of my cock being kissed by hot wetness, and broke free of her gaze to watch her slide the crown along the wet length of her slit. I could feel the hard button of her clit darting left and right when she ran my cock over it.

Her upper teeth sank into the fleshy pink of her lower lip. "In your fantasy, does he actually fuck me?" she asked.

"Oh, God," I moaned. I looked down to see her feeding my dick to her pussy. The heat of her body engulfed my dick slowly.

Scarlett seemed to be caught up in the moment. "I wonder how big his cock is," She mused.

"Keep talking," I breathed.

"It's probably big," she breathed. "Probably so big it stretches me out and I have to ask him to go really, really slow at first."

I closed my eyes again and tried to think about my go-to anti-coming thoughts: gross things I've seen, the movie *Out of Africa*...

But Scarlett was really throwing herself into this acting job, sliding down the length of my cock as slowly as she was talking about the way Alessandro would have to fuck her with his extra-thick one. "Ooooh," she moaned. "Oh, I bet it's almost too big for me to fit the whole thing inside of me."

I opened my eyes. "I bet I'd have to get on my hands and knees," she moaned. She sank down until her pussy lips touched me, and I could feel her juices and the load of cum I'd already fucked into her sliding out of her

and onto my balls. I lifted my torso and grasped her hip to keep her from moving, because when this happened I thought about how it would feel to have the same hot liquid spurt from inside of her and drip down my balls – after she had fucked Alessandro.

But I couldn't stop her pussy from quivering around my cock, squeezing me, milking the cum from inside of me. My mouth fell open and I gasped like a teenager fucking for the first time. I dug into her arm with my fingers and tried to keep myself from going over the edge.

Scarlett knew that I was going to come, so she started to bounce on top of me, a mischievous smile on her lips. "His cock would be so big I don't know if I could take it," she purred. "He'd blow his cum soooo deep inside of me..." but her own voice trailed off, just as the first spurt of cum erupted from my cock. I yelled, and drove myself in deeper, pulling her to me to stop her from grinding against me so hard.

"Wow," Scarlett said afterward. "That was fun."

And then she got up to take another shower, and wandered down the hall afterward asking me if I wanted something to eat.

By the time I got to the kitchen, it seemed like the time for talking about what had happened was over, at least for Scarlett. I didn't care, because I was just happy that we were finally getting back to being intimate, sexual, *friendlier* to each other.

But that was just the beginning.

Chapter 4

I don't know where I got the idea. After that night with Scarlett, I went a little crazy. From one moment to the next, I would be on a high or a terrible low. The highs were wild: I chose to remember only how wet her pussy was, and the way it pulsed around my cock, while she talked about Alessandro.

Maybe her deepest desires were the same as mine, and it would simply take some time to tease them out.

Sometimes I would think that the only thing I really cared about was that Scarlett was having sex with *me* again. That this fantasy about Alessandro served its purpose as just that – a fantasy. It was fun, it was harmless, my wife was sexually re-awakened by it...

The lows were brought on when I got around to thinking about it: the fantasy wasn't quite enough. Then I would go lower, thinking about how Scarlett had brushed it all off as a joke, as pure fantasy. I could sink into an even deeper low by thinking about what a perverse man I was to actually *want* my wife to sleep with another man.

Not really.

But, yes, really.

Up and down I went, for a week, and then on a Tuesday I was availed of some free time by a canceled deposition, and while I had about six million and one other things to do, I decided instead to swing by the club and see what came of it. Me being there, that is.

Either I'd have a nice lunch with my wife, who would be surprised I was there.

Or... I'd find that my wife wasn't there at all, and was instead at Alessandro's house, lounging around in *his* pool, naked.

The Mountain Vista Country Club parking lot gleamed with silver, black and chrome, packed to the hilt with the luxury cars of all the wives who had the whole day free to do water aerobics and tennis lessons (and maybe "do" their tennis instructors) and get bamboo and stone massages. I had to valet the car, and as I handed the keys to the uniformed attendant, I had to admit that I felt like I was living someone else's life.

Scarlett and I had never really even dreamed of ending up this way. Certainly not in New Mexico, where the heat and endless sunny days made me feel untethered and unreal. Everything moved slower here, and here we were rich, which is something we'd never really been before. Being rich was something we'd actually disdained.

Yet here I was, handing the keys to my Lexus to the valet at the Country Club, to go spy on my wife who was getting tennis lessons so that we could play mixed doubles on a trip to France to watch the French Open.

I had a momentary feeling of weightlessness, and then vertigo. A sense that so much of this was a mistake, that we should go home to Chicago and let the gray sky press us down into the cool cement and glass, into the world where we were not rich and we belonged to no clubs.

Then I remembered why I had come.

It was ten to two, so tennis lessons had ended (if my wife was telling the truth about them, which she really had no reason not to do). I pushed my hands in my pockets to try and look cool, and began my "casual stroll" along the open-air corridor that ran along the length of the pool area.

I had only seen the club on a few occasions: when I had followed Dan, at a brisk, excited pace, through the entire club as he pointed out all of the amenities. That had been part of my job interview, and so I hadn't seen a thing. I'd just been concentrating hard on trying to act like I would fit in at this kind of place.

I'd come for a few dinners, a few cocktail hours, and some of them had been poolside, but everything looked so different at night. The pool was a bright, aquamarine disk, and then wound around a fake island scattered with loungers on which very expensive ladies of all ages were taking in the sun. Hardly anyone was in the water; the aerobics classes had also ended.

I scanned the lounging women, hoping to see Scarlett. I ran my eyes over her twice before realizing it was her.

She was stretched out on a lounger, the back almost flat. A broad, black hat was lying on her face, which is one of the reasons I passed her figure over twice: Scarlett was not a broad, black hat kind of gal. I had never seen her wear one – not a hat of any kind, in fact. And I couldn't see her hair or her face; my mind had played tricks on me and assumed that the woman beneath the hat had dark hair.

The teeny swimsuit she had purchased was indeed teeny, yet another reason I had passed her over. But the shape of her breasts as they settled on her chest was unmistakable, and the criss-crossed tan lines were familiar. They were fading, likely because she pulled the straps of the suit down, as she had today, so that only her nipples and the slightest bit of flesh beneath them were covered by the rumpled black fabric of her suit. The ties were strewn next to her ribs on the white lounge. Almost as if someone had untied them and arranged her like that.

Her skin glowed in the sun. Her lean body was everywhere, for everyone to see. The deep oval of her belly-button, nestled in her smooth stomach. Her long legs, one bent slightly at the knee, showing the line of muscle on her thigh. The bottom of the suit was as skimpy as the top, hanging low on her hips, hugging the gentle curve of hip bone that arched like a dolphin under her skin on her extended leg.

I found a chair under an umbrella where I had a view of her, and I sat down, grateful for the shade. It wasn't as if I'd never experienced heat before: a hot day in Chicago's muggy city Julys had this beat by a long shot. Just... no one expected you to keep your suit jacket on in that situation. In New Mexico, however, they seemed to expect you to suck it up.

I ordered a Coke Zero, sticking to my diet, however unmanly it might seem. However much I would have enjoyed a stiff whiskey, or a cool beer.

Not much went on, as I sat there spying on my wife. Minutes ticked by, and I enjoyed the view of her. She barely moved. Women and men who passed by her – looking for a place to lounge, floating by in the pool on an air mattress – took long looks at her. I supposed everyone felt free to ogle her because of the hat over her face.

But most of the guys were old men (with the exception of a waiter, who looked quite young and spent a great deal of time with his hand on his forehead, squinting over the water from across the pool, at my wife's lovely body stretched out on the chair.

It was enjoyable to watch her, and to watch other men looking at her, but I decided to call it quits after a bit. It wasn't as thrilling as I'd hoped it would be. I placed my hands on the end of my chair and was preparing to push up and walk slowly over to her via a bridge on the opposite side of the island, when a shadow spread across her golden navel.

And there, standing above her, was Alessandro himself.

He was at the foot of her lounge, his shadow cooling the length of her body.

For a moment, my wife had no reaction. She shifted her body side-to-side, shoulders rolling sexily, but then settled right back in. I expected her to bring her hand to her hat and remove it, to see who was blocking her sun.

Instead, she remained as she was.

It was only obvious that she was speaking because Alessandro was listening attentively, and smiling at odd moments. When he spoke to her, he gestured, and then paused.

My heart pounded, and the cold rage I'd felt almost a week earlier slid down my insides like a syrup. I leaned forward, and then I decided to lean back and try to appear casual.

The exchange continued, and my jealousy burned more. After all, what was my wife doing that she didn't need to look and see who was standing at the foot of her lounge?

Alessandro moved closer to her head, leaned down, and plucked the hat from her face.

I was so expecting that he would lean over and press his lips to hers, that I almost imagined that I had actually seen exactly that transpire. Instead, Alessandro tossed the hat to a glass table next to Scarlett's lounge.

Scarlett propped herself up on her elbows and looked at him. Her lips were stained a sunny, fruit-like red that called attention to her mouth. As she sat up, the swimsuit rolled down tantalizingly to just above her nipple. Scarlett made to move to clutch the fabric to her chest. Her eyes fluttered open as she looked at Alessandro and grinned.

Her hair had been wet, and then dried beneath the hat, so pieces of it had risen up with static and others were clinging to her shoulders or tousled at the top of her head. It all made her look very slutty, and made my cock hard.

Sitting ten or so yards away, watching them over the shimmering aqua of the pool, had they been any other couple I would have said they were together. A new "together." Together, but not yet long enough to bore of each other.

Together in the way that people having affairs are together. Sizzling the air between them with their illicit passions, their secrets and lies

simmering like a desert mirage between them.

And even if that wasn't what was happening here, they were definitely flirting.

And I was definitely enjoying the show, at least in one part of my body.

This went on for a few moments, and then Scarlett shrugged. My wife swung her legs over the side of the lounge as she sat up fully. With one hand, she caught the falling top of her swimsuit and held it with stretched fingers so that it didn't fall forward and expose her full breasts.

She was facing me now, and it was hard to know in the blazing sun if she saw me sitting at the other side of the pool or not. Her mouth twisted a little, and there was a pause that made it seem like she was thinking.

She flipped her hair as she turned around to look at Alessandro. Her jaw moved as she said something to him.

And then, only a second later, Alessandro was behind her, and his hands were on her body.

I squinted.

No. He was finding the strings of her bikini, which I saw now she had untied completely.

I stared openly when Alessandro gathered her hair and pushed it over her right shoulder. I knew that Scarlett would be unable to stop the smattering of goosebumps that such a gesture would give her; she loved people touching her hair, and when done right (as Alessandro had just done), she had an involuntary reaction of pleasurable shivers.

Alessandro tied the bikini, one knot at the center of her back, and then, sliding his hands liberally along her arms, he drew the remaining strings up to her neck. The back of his hand seemed to brush over her breasts as he pulled on the strings. He almost certainly caught a view of what was beneath the fabric, of my wife's pink nipples.

Scarlett let her hair drop, and turned to thank Alessandro. Or at least that's what I assumed she was doing as she placed her hand on his arm and spoke to him, the fingers of her other hand running through her damp hair.

I heard her laugh from across the pool, a silvery lilt in response to something Alessandro had said.

I stared at the young Italian man. There was no way to misconstrue his intention toward my wife. He was moving in on her like she was prey,

his eyes on her body every time she turned her face away or moved; his eyes on hers like those of a panther when she looked back at him. He held his hands together, his thumb close to his lips, as he spoke.

I watched them for a few more minutes. Scarlett seemed to be trying to get up and leave, or at least give off a good impression of doing so. I could almost subtitle their conversation without hearing it: *Oh, no, no, I better go...Come on, stay, have a daiquiri with me. Just one.... No, I really have to get going...*

In the meantime, Scarlett's body language was anything but the body language of a woman who actually *wanted* to leave.

She gathered up her things, dropping them slowly into her purse, stopping to listen to Alessandro every few seconds. She swung her feet back up onto the lounge, and then toward Alessandro. She crossed them sexily, giving him, I was sure, a glimpse of the triangle between her panties.

She picked up her hat and put it on, he reached for the brim and convinced her to take it off.

A knife of cold pleasure cut through me when Alessandro smooth-talked as he reached toward Scarlett's hair, and tucked a strand of it behind her ear.

They spoke for a moment longer, and then Scarlett stood up. Alessandro reached for her hand.

I stared, half-horrified, half-delighted, fully erect, as Alessandro reached for her hand, and tugged on it. He wanted her to stay. His brown eyes met hers, looking up at her.

My wife didn't jerk her hand away from him. Quite the opposite: she physically lingered. Then, she glanced around the pool area, as though trying to see if she would get caught.

Again, she looked in my direction, and again, I could not see if she met my eye.

But surely she knew it was me?

She turned back to Alessandro and gave his hand a wide swing. It was the kindly swing of the hand from the woman who wants to let you down gently.

Or the woman who doesn't want to let you down, but has to play hard-to-get. A woman like Scarlett, who wanted to linger but was married.

Alessandro brought her hand to his lips. It was the back of her hand, very chivalrous. But he lingered as he kissed her skin, moments too long, and I thought I saw Scarlett's chest expand with a short, aroused breath.

Alessandro released her, and she walked past him to leave the area where they were sitting. He brazenly turned to watch her bottom, which she was shaking seductively as she walked.

Scarlett turned back to say something over her shoulder, with a smile.

Alessandro held a hand up. Whatever he said made Scarlett turn, freeze, and look slightly uncomfortable.

She shook her head unconvincingly.

Alessandro said something else.

And then I watched as he took out his phone, and my wife's lips moved in precise, short words. Forming, unmistakably, the ten digits of her phone number.

My heart slammed inside my chest. Scarlett turned on her heel and walked away, between some trees that lined the pathway to the footbridge joining the small island to the mainland.

I watched her as she walked in my direction. Her eyes were straight ahead behind her sunglasses; I could tell without even looking at her. I wanted to watch her face as she neared, but I was distracted by her lithe body, moving in fluid steps, her breasts jiggling slightly as she slinked along in high heels and her teeny bikini.

I knew Alessandro was watching her too.

And any man with a beating heart, though there weren't many around.

When I opened my mouth to speak to her, she was still walking with her gaze focused ahead of her, and too fast to slow down and speak to me. I felt a delicious chill thinking that maybe she had *not* seen me after all.

"Meet me at the car," she said, her voice garbled by an effort to avoid moving her lips.

She kept walking.

I was flying as I hurried out to the parking lot. There were logistical problems with what she had said, like... whose car did she mean? Scarlett herself had walked her slinky walk toward the ladies' changing room, so I assumed I had a minute to think about it. My car or hers? How would I get

my car out of valet parking fast enough? Why did she want to do that in the first place?

But I pulled my shit together, remembered that we were in Santa Fe, where there were no lines and nothing was more than ten seconds away. I gave the attendant my valet chip and my car was back in seconds, so I took a slow-mo drive around the parking lot twice, and found my wife – now in a sexy black sundress and the same heels and hat, walking out of the club.

She smiled, and in seconds she was inside the car, tossing her hat onto the back seat.

We drove out of the lot in silence, casting glances at each other with excited, adolescent smiles attached to them. My blood was boiling, but I still wasn't 100% sure what was going on.

"So..." Scarlett said finally. "How'd you like that?"

I was on a winding road that curled up into the hills, and eventually the mountains, but I looked over at her brazenly. She was smiling in such a devilish, un-Scarlett-like way that I left my eyes on her too long and had to swerve to avoid a truck.

Scarlett let out a yelp. Then she laughed. "I guess you liked it," she said.

"You knew I was there the whole time," I said.

Scarlett shifted in her seat. "Of course," she said, indignantly. "I just thought I'd test your... you know... commitment to the stuff we talked about. The other day."

"Commitment," I repeated.

"Well... I don't know. I just wanted to see what would happen, and suddenly there he was and there you were, so..."

There was another pause.

"Did you like it?" Scarlett asked, finally.

I looked over at her. "It was hot."

"He asked me for my number," she said, and my cock twitched in my pants. "At first I said I couldn't give it to him... but then, in the end, I did."

The whole time I had been driving – in the opposite direction of nearly everything, I had been looking for a place to pull over. The problem with New Mexico is that there is almost no shrubbery, so any place you pull over is exposed.

I turned anyway, onto a dirt path that was unmarked, probably somebody's property, and which held almost no promising signs of solitude except that it went out into a plain expanse with a slight curve of hill to it, which seemed to slope down after a quarter of a mile, thus tucking us, however slightly, behind it.

I braked hard and dust flew up behind the car. Behind me, I could see the road, but we were mostly below the horizon of the hill.

I turned to Scarlett as I put the car in park. "What did he say to you?" I asked.

Scarlett was staring at the dissipating dust cloud behind the car, her mouth open in half-disbelief. Her eyes snapped to mine.

"Uh... he said... I just want to check," she interrupted herself. "You're like, still into this right? You're not mad?"

I smiled at her and reached for her hand, moving it toward my crotch. Her fingers brushed the outline of my cock and her eyes widened a little. Then they gleamed. "I see," she said.

She shifted in her seat, leaving her hand on my cock. Her pinky finger moved slowly over the shape of it, grazing the length of my shaft with an agonizing tickle. "From the beginning?" she said.

I nodded.

"Well... I put on my suit and lay out there, hoping I'd run into him, because I have before. And... I dunno, I think I look pretty good in this suit."

"You do," I said, but my tone urged her to go on.

"So he came over and told me I looked like I was getting a burn," she said. I picked up the visual story I had witnessed and matched it to hers. Alessandro, standing at the edge of her deck chair, running his greedy eyes all over her body, analyzing her skin, deciding she was burning.

"And then he offered to put some sunscreen on -"

"Wait," I said. "What did he say?"

Scarlett blushed a little, but she didn't pull her hand away and her eyes glistened when they met mine. Her mouth formed a smile. "He said, 'I'm happy to put some sun lotion on you, if you want,' Or something like that." Scarlett made her voice husky and faked a terrible Italian accent to imitate him.

"And then?"

Scarlett waved her free hand at me. "That was a little over the top, you know? I said, that's okay and started to get up. That's when I saw you. And then I realized my top was all untied, so asked him to tie it."

"What'd you say?" Scarlett's pinky finger on my cock was driving me wild. I wanted her to stop teasing me and unzip my pants, grab my dick, lean over and get her mouth around me.

"Well," she said, and her eyes dropped to watch my cock when it thrashed inside my pants. "I said, 'you *can* help me out with these loose strings.'" Scarlett lifted her eyes to read my reaction.

I said nothing, but my cock pulsed.

"And so he did," she said. Her voice had dropped now.

"Did you like it? It looks like he got a little touchy-feely."

Scarlett started to say something, and then she looked confused.

"Um... Will...." she pulled her hand away from my cock. "I'm not, I don't really know how serious you are about this whole thing. I don't..." She dropped her eyes and looked at her hands. "I don't really know, like, where the line is."

I put my hand on her seat and leaned closer to her. "I thought I told you where the line is," I said. "It's... it's where you draw it, really."

Scarlett looked at me sharply. "Really? So if I was like, 'yeah, that felt really good,' you aren't bothered by it?"

I paused, weighing Scarlett's reaction. "I..." I started to say.

"You're not jealous or anything?"

She was challenging me.

"I mean, I am," I said cautiously. "But that's part of the thrill."

It was only as I said this that I realized I was speaking the truth, and it was by far the most sensible thought I'd had about my desires myself. *That* was it: I liked the jealous thrill, the hallowed-out cold ache in my chest.

Scarlett stared at me. "Well. He gave me goosebumps," she said.

She moved her hand over my thigh, finding my cock again. She seemed a little nervous, like the first time she had gone into a courtroom: she knew what she was doing, but she'd never really done it before. "And he said, 'you're sure you don't want any sunscreen. I'm really good at putting it on.'"

I sucked in my breath. "And..?"

“And for a moment I was tempted,” she said. “But then I got scared and I told him I had to go.”

She looked at me again.

Now, even though the air conditioning was blasting, it seemed incredibly hot in the car. The air between us seemed to shimmer.

“And he kissed my hand -”

“What was that like?”

Scarlett’s cheeks flushed again, and she looked away before meeting my eyes again. “Nice,” she said quietly, and when my cock twitched she went on. “It was... his lips were warm, dry. He seemed like... he was probably a good kisser.”

My cock throbbed. Scarlett gave a furtive glance out the back window, then down at my pants. For a moment, she chewed on her lower lip in indecision. I watched her face until I heard the click of the seat belt, and the shoulder strap slid over my chest.

“And then I was leaving, and he asked me for my number.”

Her fingers were at the waist of my suit. I placed my hand on her thigh, moving quickly along the length of muscle to the hot, sweaty interior of her legs. There was heat and moisture radiating from her swimsuit bottom, over which she’d thrown the sundress. My fingers probed as she unfastened my pants. I touched the fabric, and it was soaked through.

“At first I thought of not giving it to him. But then I did.”

I slipped a finger under the suit bottom and Scarlett’s legs clamped closed like a trap. She pushed my hand away. “Not here,” she said. “But...”

I stared at her. She pushed my hand away insistently. I retracted it and moved it toward her breasts. But she was too quick and had her own hand taking my cock out of my pants. I heard the click of her seatbelt, and then she leaned forward, into my lap, and I abandoned my quest to grab her full breasts.

Her palm was hot around my shaft. The air in the car was ice-cold on the skin of my cock, but I was so riled up I only pulsed harder as she licked me.

Scarlett’s breath warmed the head of my dick as she said, languidly: “I don’t know when he’ll call or what he’s planning to do with it...” I felt the wet, flat blade of her tongue on the ridge of my crown and I stared at her blonde hair in my lap. “What should I do if he calls me?”

My whole abdomen rippled as Scarlett closed her mouth around my dick and began to slide her lips down to the base. The heat of her mouth contrasted with the cold of the conditioned air, and a snake of pleasure wriggled through me as the entire length of my shaft disappeared inside her hot, soft mouth. I felt the soft mesh of the back of her throat bump against my crown, a twitch in her torso as she gagged slightly. I had to look up at the ceiling to control myself as she made her way up to my head and the cold air turned even cooler where her spit coated my dick.

Again, she descended to the base of my cock, this time moving faster. Her mouth had gotten wetter, and she didn't spasm when she reached the base. She sucked hard on me on her way back up, and then descended again and again.

It didn't take long, after I recovered from my initial shock, to send me hurtling toward the edge. Shock – because Scarlett hardly ever gave me blowjobs and when she did it was definitely not in public and not this intense. Not this... enthusiastic.

I rested my hand on the back of her head, and the motion of her bobbing raised and lowered it. I thought one more time of her flirting with Alessandro, pictured her sucking his cock, and I was gone. I didn't even have time to warn her: I was gripping her hair and muttering something incomprehensible, but I had already squirted once against the back of her throat.

Scarlett did not release me quickly, but instead made her way slowly up the length of me, as the final squirts of cum shuddered out of me and into her mouth. Her lips were locked around my shaft until she reached the very tip, her tongue swirling around and cleaning off the cum. She released me with a pop, and pushed herself back into her seat.

The red stain she had applied to her lips had faded but not smeared, and her mouth had an adolescent, puffy look to it. Her hair was tangled and clung to her cheeks in places. She met my eyes again, and ran her tongue along her upper lip.

I stared at her, still panting slightly from coming.

“What was that?” I finally managed to say.

Scarlett had retrieved a hair tie from somewhere, and was gathering her hair. She grinned. “What *was* that. *Exactly*.”

Then she looked over at me.

“That was hot,” I said lamely, not knowing what else to do. The blowjob had been incredible, but now that some time was gathering between filling my wife’s mouth with cum and the moment, I was starting to wonder about her sudden enthusiasm.

“Why so horny?” I asked.

She looked at me and shrugged. “I don’t know. It was kind of fun.”

“What... this, or flirting with another man?”

My wife looked at me for just a second longer than I might have wanted before answering: “Both.”

Then she looked behind us and giggled. “You owe me,” she said, “but we are *both* going to get charged with indecent exposure out here.”

I started to zip myself up. “*You’re* not doing anything,” I said.

“Yeah, right,” she said.

“I’d get you off,” I quipped.

Scarlett put her fingers to her lips. “I bet you would.”

I looked at her hopefully, and my hand made its way to her skirt, cover-up, whatever it was. “I would,” I said, in a husky voice.

She pushed my hand away and looked behind us again. “Get me home,” she said. “You’re not even a criminal lawyer.”

I tried to start the car, even though it was already running, and Scarlett put her hand to her face as though embarrassed of me.

After all that.

Chapter 5

I was supposed to be back at the office for a meeting in thirty-four minutes, from the time we departed the dirt road.

I was being reckless, dangerous, driving like an idiot. Even though Santa Fe is barely a city and you don't really need to look where you're going on the wide, wide streets with no traffic in them, I was a lawyer, dammit. I should be driving like one.

Conservatively. Professionally. Not fingering my wet wife with only one hand on the steering wheel and no brain cells dedicated to the act of driving.

Scarlett pushed her hands against the dashboard as I found her clit and stroked her to orgasm, trying to drive. While I did this, I felt myself coming to life again, wanting to blow off the afternoon, miss the meeting, whatever... and go home and fuck Scarlett's brains out. It was a juvenile, wild rush. My ears were ringing when I pulled unsteadily into the parking lot at the club, so that Scarlett could get her car.

I leaned over, my hand still under her cover-up and beneath the fabric of her suit, and we kissed for a while, which only drove me wilder.

Finally Scarlett pushed my hand away. "Get back to work," she said. "And we'll take this up when you get home."

"Screw it," I said. "I'll quit."

Scarlett giggled and opened the door, leaning back to give me one last kiss. It reminded me of long ago, when I was a man who dated or hooked up, took girls home and tried desperately to get them to come back to my place or stay in the car.

The feeling was invigorating.

"No way," Scarlett said, stepping out, pushing my hand back to my side of the car. "I like that house and we already put a down payment on it."

She winked, closed the door, and strutted to her own car.

I was almost as high that Scarlett had finally – finally – said something good about Santa Fe, as I was that when I lifted my fingers to my nose, I could smell the sweet and unmistakable scent of her excitement.

It didn't help that I received Scarlett's text in the middle of an extremely boring meeting detailing the progress on a class action suit I was not really involved with. What everybody tries, but fails, to tell you in law school is that most of your life is going to be boring as hell, with your neck craned over reams of paper, wondering if it was all worth it to sell 115% of your time to own nice things you never get to see.

My phone massaged my inner jacket pocket, and I took it out to read the text, expecting (and hoping) that my assistant had something urgent to pull me out of this meeting.

I had to fight not to jump out of my skin. The message on my screen drugged me:

[Scarlett]: *he sent me a text*

[Scarlett]: *what do I do?*

This was followed by a screen shot of his message. A certain satisfying injection of relief went through me when I saw that Scarlett had not programmed his name into her phone. I trusted my wife, of course... just, it felt nice to have that trust confirmed with evidence.

[5055117203]: *Bella. I have to change the schedule Thursday.*

Can you meet me in the afternoon, around four?

[5055117203]: *I'll make it up to you afterward.*

I almost convulsed with the energy it took not to roll my eyes. This guy.

I typed:

[Me]: *In meeting. I'll think it over. Meanwhile make him wait a little.*

I pocketed my phone, but it felt like it was burning through my jacket into my skin for the next forty minutes. The image of the screenshot had burned into my mind; I could read it over and over again. *Make it up to you afterward...make it up to you afterward.*

I could have been at a round table in French Literature, for all I heard. So many delicious possibilities were blossoming in my head.

When my assistant *did* actually text me, I nearly jumped out of my seat. “I have to take this,” I said, almost smugly, and I excused myself from the meeting.

“Oh, Mr. Green,” my assistant said, her plain, round face falling as she watched me approach. “It wasn’t necessary for you to -”

I leaned over the warped glass partition of her desk. “Krista, thank you. I really wanted out of that meeting,” I whispered.

Krista, who was torn in two by her competing rule adherence and ambition (she probably recited “one-two-three-s-t-o-p” at every stop sign, but she had also evidently trampled a handicapped woman to file something on time and remained semi-unapologetic about it) displayed several expressions on her face in quick succession, settling on a reluctant smile of complicity and a furrowed brow that indicated it did not sit well with her, though.

Whatever. I closed the door to my office and tried to look legally thoughtful while I typed my message to Scarlett.

[Me]: *Wow. He’s not being subtle at all. Why don’t you ask him to elaborate on that?*

I set the phone down and tried to concentrate on the screen in front of me. A box of unread dictations on my desk was glaring at me, requiring my attention.

I took out a legal pad and tried to look like I was thinking. I should probably have gone back to the meeting, but it was a class-action lawsuit I would only ever work peripherally on, nearly finished.

[Scarlett]: *okay... like, what?*

I had to suppress a laugh. Had Scarlett and I been together so long she’d forgotten how to flirt? As if it were somehow complicated.

I started typing, but Scarlett was ahead of me, the screen indicating that she was typing a message. Erasing. Typing again.

It all felt so deliciously adolescent.

I waited for her response.

[Scarlett]: *How about: How will you make it up to me?*

I smiled. Then typed.

[Me]: *perfect*

Scarlett did not respond for what seemed like ages, and I marveled at the way her antics were consuming me as though she were flirting with *me* again for the first time. The same agonizing knots twisted in my stomach and my chest as I waited for my phone to vibrate against my leg. Only back when I had hooked up with Scarlett, it had been on a flip-phone and in a time when things had moved slightly slower. Now every second seemed like an eternity.

Three notifications, none of them Scarlett, sent my pulse racing and my heart thumping against my chest.

Finally, a message from Scarlett, a screenshot:

[Me]: *And how will you make it up to me?*

[AD]: *I have my ways*

Then Scarlett again, directly to me.

[Scarlett]: *now what?*

The words, and all of their implications, were burning through me.

Under the burn, a flicker of reason, trying desperately to be felt or heard: what was it I wanted Scarlett to do now? Did I want my wife to tease this guy? Did I want her to go further than that? I imagined that I did, but did I really?

She had already abbreviated his name, almost as if she were having an affair.

What should I tell her to do? This guy was obviously moving in on her, ready to take it past flirtation and on to something else.

I typed and re-typed, looking for the right answer. I needed to get back in on the tail-end of the meeting I had abandoned, and I had a stack of work to do.

Finally I settled on:

[Me]: *Let him stew for a bit. I'll think of something but I have to get to work.*

I gathered up a few things in my briefcase, including the legal pad I'd been robotically taking notes on, and hurried to the conference room.

Just as I reached the doors, my phone buzzed in my pocket.

[Scarlett]: *Don't tell me this is distracting you. Pick up a bottle of wine on the way home and we'll plan our next move together*

I smiled, and kept right on smiling, right through the world's most mundane meeting.

Chapter 6

Scarlett was stretched out on the bed in a red camisole and beige panties, her feet fluttering over her bottom like seagulls homing in on a snack. I was sitting across from her, a laptop in my lap, the glare of the screen getting more intense as the sun disappeared completely. I was trying to finish the work I should have been doing at the office, and which absolutely needed to be done, but Scarlett was not making it easy.

She had agreed to let me work to finish things up when I first got home, after we'd had a wild lovemaking session. She had claimed that she had a few things she needed to do herself, related to the offer we'd put in on the house. I went to the second bedroom, a sterile room we never used, and set up my computer at the desk.

Scarlett had helped herself to a glass of wine, changed into the skimpy outfit she was wearing now, and pranced by the open door several times telling me absently that she thought we were going to get the house, and that she'd misplaced her slippers, and that she knew exactly what color of paint she was going to use on the front room of the new place.

Or something like that. I could only think about the way her breasts jiggled in her tank top, or how her bottom rolled while she walked. She seemed to have been doing butt-specific exercises, because, while she'd lost weight, she had a firmer ass. Definitely.

It all made it very hard to work.

But then Scarlett had come in and stretched out on the bed with her own computer and her phone. The way she had done it certainly seemed designed to make me fail at working. She had laid down on her front so that the rounded heart of her ass was mostly turned toward me, the v-shape of her lacy panties folding into the crease between her cheeks. Her legs moved playfully over her bottom, providing me with glimpses of the triangle between her legs, and then snatching it away.

She was driving me wild.

She tapped on her computer for a while as I struggled to focus on reading through my assistant's drafts of letters, which was no easy task because Jill was so unimaginatively circumspect and boring, it was like looking for a needle in haystack.

Scarlett at last abandoned her computer and slid her phone close to her after it dinged.

“Get this,” she said, turning over and sitting up. She pushed her loose hair from her face and settled into a childish cross-legged pose, leaning her elbows on her knees. “He messaged me again,” she said.

My heart leaped. “Wow,” I said. “He’s really moving in on you.”

Scarlett’s eyes flicked up from the screen. “Should we stop this?” she asked me. “Maybe we should stop it before it goes too far.”

I looked at her over the edge of my screen. “Why? What did he say?”

She dropped her eyes to the screen. “Bring something dressy for tomorrow. My buddy gave up his reservation to *The Hot*. He spelled it h-o-t.”

The Haute was a super-trendy haute cuisine place that a lot of hipsters loved, hence the post-post-post-ironic name. Or maybe it wasn’t ironic at all. I didn’t know. I couldn’t keep up with these things anymore.

“He’s Italian,” I said, finding myself oddly defensive of the man who was hitting on my wife.

Scarlett shrugged. “True.” Then she laughed. “I thought it was *The Hots*, anyway. Isn’t that place, like, I don’t know...six thousand dollars a plate?”

“He must be really anxious to make an impression,” I said.

Scarlett looked over her phone at me. I was still determined to, and pretending to work. She smiled sexily. “Indeed. Hmmm... what do I say?”

We stared at each other, and the air was electric. My heart kicked at my chest. “Uh...”

And then I had an idea. I cocked my head to the side. “Do you have any really sexy dresses lying around?”

Scarlett laughed. “Lying around?” She rolled her eyes. “Shouldn’t you know? You have anything in mind?”

I tried to remember all the dresses Scarlett had, all the things I’d seen her wear, and the only thing I could consistently conjure in my mind was her new skimpy swimsuit. That and a sort of montage of all the business suits she’d ever worn, which of course looked sexy but not... date-with-another-man sexy.

“What were you thinking, anyway?” she asked, flipping onto her back. I had a nice view of her breasts, spreading open slightly, the valley

between them yawning like a tributary between two sand dunes. The outline of her hard nipples peaked at the caps of her silk-enshrouded breasts. They jiggled slightly as she shifted her weight to get comfortable. In her hands, the message from Alessandro glowed.

“Huh?” I said absently, having entirely forgotten what we were discussing.

She looked up and back at me, and the scene was so sexy my cock jumped against the hot underbelly of the laptop.

“Why did you mention the dresses?” she asked. Her fingers were sprawled like spread legs on the edges of her phone, giving off a strange and erotic aura as she moved her forefinger along the side of the screen.

“I, uh... well... I thought it might be kind of sexy if you sent him a picture.”

Scarlett rolled immediately back onto her stomach to face me. “A what?” she exclaimed. She shook her head, and looked back at her phone, smiling. “That’s a little forward, don’t you think?”

I shut my laptop. “I don’t know,” I said. “Are we doing this thing or not?”

Scarlett bit the meat of her thumb. She was still looking at her screen. “Okay,” she said, hesitantly. Then her eyes met mine. “I don’t really have anything all that sexy, though.”

I looked at the time on my own phone. 7:37.

“Malls are open ‘til nine,” I said suggestively.

Scarlett laughed an incredulous laugh at first, but it sort of dissolved before it was complete. “Not really,” she said, and she wasn’t referring to the hours the mall was open.

I smiled and set my laptop down on the desk. “Yolo,” I said, in my best millennial-imitation voice.

Scarlett looked unconvinced, and for a moment I thought she would say something reasonable.

Instead, she looked back at the screen, up at me, and back again. “Okay,” she said. “Let’s go shopping.”

My heart felt as though it actually stopped.

“But... what do I do in the meantime?”

I looked at the phone, and imagined Alessandro holding his own phone. What was he doing on the other end of this conversation? Was he

waiting desperately for my wife's reply? Was he as excited as I was, or was he such a player that he had moved on to some other conversation as soon as he had sent the message? Which did I want him to be? Did I really want some good-looking man obsessed with my wife?

"Let him stew," I advised. "We'll send him a picture when we find the dress."

"It's after 7:30," Scarlett said, But her voice was excited, and so was she – I could tell by her wet, darting eyes, and the smile she couldn't hide, creeping at the corners of her mouth. She *wanted* to go shopping, *wanted* to take her picture in a sexy dress and send it to Alessandro. She just wanted to put forth a half-whispered word of caution.

"Don't worry," I said, taking her hand, "everything's ten minutes away in Santa Fe."

We looked for dresses in the nearly-empty fluorescent lights of the only mall we knew about, but to no avail. Nothing was quite as exciting as we wanted it to be, and the almost-empty, over-air-conditioned stores with sour-faced attendants glaring at us with irritation sort of put a damper on our elated mood.

Scarlett frowned as she scanned a rack of clothing, pushing things aside half-heartedly. "I don't really see anything," she said, discouraged.

I was behind a few racks of clothing and some mannequins and only heard her muffled voice. I wasn't ready to give up just yet.

"You looking for anything in particular?" a sales associate asked Scarlett. She was a red-haired rail of a girl who didn't look old enough to work in a factory in 1901 England. "It's just that... we're closing in like ten minutes."

Scarlett spoke to her as though she were a five-year old child. She even leaned down a little, as though the girl were very short. "What would you wear," she asked, "if you were going on a date to *The Haute*?"

The girl's eyes widened. "Well," she said. "I wouldn't shop *here*, honestly."

"No? Where would you shop?"

The girl became animated. "You should like, totally go to *Holly's Closet*. They have the hottest dresses, but like, you know, really grown-up."

“Are they in the mall?”

“Just over there. My friend Margot works there, there’s like, this silver dress, and I’ve wanted it forever but I so don’t have the boobs for it, you should just get it. I can tell her you’re going there.”

And so we rushed to *Holly’s Closet*, where the silver dress, which was, indeed, hot, was clinging to a mannequin in the window, and Margot was waiting with us with the same adolescent energy as her friend.

Scarlett’s mouth was open. “Oh my God,” she said, looking at the dress and squeezing my arm. “That’s like... no way.”

I pulled her into the store. “Just try it on,” I said.

The dress was a near-transparent material, made of some kind of heavy fabric that mimicked metal in the right light, but without looking trashy. It was a scrap of a dress, and even I wasn’t sure that I would want Scarlett to wear it out in public, but I wanted her to try it on.

I pulled one of the dresses from the rack. “Hmmm.... Only comes in small, medium, large,” I said.

Scarlett grinned. “Super-classy. I think maybe this is a -”

I held it up and looked at the tag. “Look, it’s two hundred bucks. Let’s just get it, and then if you don’t like it, we can return it. Or *whatever*.”

Margot, the rail-thin brown-haired version of the girl from the last store, agreed heartily by nodding her head. It was clear that she wanted to be out the door at 9:01.

I shook the dress.

Scarlett snatched it out of my hand. “I have to try it on,” she said.

Margot forced a plastic smile. “The dressing rooms are right here,” she said. Then she pulled a phone out to look at the time. When she frowned, the frown was for us.

“We’ll be quick,” Scarlett said. “I just have to see if it... fits... it’s for a... it’s an emergency.”

Scarlett was flustered at making Margot wait on us at the last minute. “Just go,” I said. And then I gave Margot a stern look in the event she decided to get lippy, but she was already swiping at her phone.

“Probably have to change your social media plans,” I said to her dryly. I have a real penchant for screwing with kids these days.

Margot made a nondescript sound and didn’t look up.

The dressing rooms were in a hallway that led to the back of the store. I sat down on a chair. The wall in front of me had a large chip of paint missing from it. I gazed around the store. All in all, the place was actually pretty trashy, the kind of store that twenty-somethings bought their club clothes at.

I felt my cock stiffening against my pants. Something about that – about the fact that Scarlett, who was in every way such a proper, corporate, almost *stuffy*, middle-aged lawyer, was actually in this store, putting on a dress that was so far out of her normal wardrobe – turned me on almost as much as the dress itself.

“Oh, my God,” Scarlett said, from behind a door. Then I heard her laugh through her nose. “No, I can’t,” she said.

I saw the silvery material pile at her ankles.

“Just let me see it,” I complained. “Come on. We’ve made poor Margot keep the store open late for us.”

“No way,” Scarlett said. But the dress was still piled at her ankles, and she hadn’t stepped out of it.

“Please,” I said. “Come on. Just let me see.”

I saw her hands reach down and gather up the dress. “Oh God,” she said. “Okay, fine.”

Her feet moved slightly as she adjusted the dress, and then she turned around and around again, pausing to look at herself in the mirror. Finally, her feet turned toward the door and I heard the latch as she pulled it back.

“Holy shit,” I said, after a silence.

The silver dress had not been done justice hanging on the scrawny mannequin. Scarlett’s firm breasts made two silo-shaped points in draping, shimmering fabric that barely clung to her front. Two suggestively thin straps held the front of the dress to her skin – but only barely. The material bunched together but not enough to cover the deep gouge in the center of the material, where Scarlett’s smooth skin was on display almost all the way to her navel. The bottom half of the dress came just to mid-thigh, clinging to her shape, which was smooth and rounded in all the right places.

Scarlett laughed. “It’s so... too young for me,” she said.

“But you look amazing in it,” I stammered. “I mean, really amazing.”

Scarlett let go of the door frame and looked down at her body. “Uh... yeah, I dunno. This is... like half of a dress.”

I moved toward her and placed my hands on her hips. I pulled her close to me and started to bunch up the fabric of the skirt in my hands. Our lips met, and we brushed them against each other.

It was as if the mall and the dressing rooms faded away to nothing. I had the urge to push her into the dressing room and fuck her against the wall, and the heat radiating off of her, the way her mouth lingered for more of mine, told me she wanted to do the same.

How long had it been since we had done anything like that?

To our right, Margot's throat-clearing pierced the bubble I had been sinking into.

"Um, guys... it's... I really have to close up soon. Do you want the dress? Or what?"

"Just buy the dress," I said, stepping away from Scarlett (but not without glaring at Margot).

"I'm not *wearing* this," she laughed. "Not in public."

"Wear it out of here," I said playfully.

She looked at me uncertainly. The sexual energy between us was palpable.

"I dare you," I added.

I watched my wife's eyes narrow and her lips purse as she considered the possibilities. She disappeared into the dressing room for a quick second, scooping something off a bench in the corner.

She returned to me, and pulled my hand toward her, prying my fingers open so that my palm was face-up and flat.

She pushed a silky wad into my hand. My fingers closed around it, and I felt the hard curve of the underwire of her bra beneath the smooth material.

Scarlett gave a toss of her hair, and then her lips turned upward in a mischievous way that was really quite new to her. I felt my blood race and my cock throb: she was, for that moment, so very much my wife and yet like another woman completely.

"Fine," she said, lifting her shoulders so that her posture was erect, her neck long and her belly so trim the dress hung loosely at her waistline.

As she strolled out of the store, her bottom rolled from side to side. She had really developed her ass with whatever it was she was doing at the gym, and while I'd noticed, it was only in that moment that I *really* noticed.

I started to walk after her, in a trance.

‘Hey!’ Margot barked sharply at me as I passed her. “You gotta pay for that.”

There were very few people in the mall, or the mall parking lot, but every single one of them gave Scarlett a look as she shimmered past them in that dress. After she left the store, she paused and pretended to look at some figurines in a glassware store window while I paid for the almost indecently scant amount of material she was wearing.

We were being spontaneous, but with a sort of middle-aged refinement.

When she saw that I was coming, she turned and rolled her round bottom away, just a little ahead of me. I watched the movement of the two spherical halves of her ass under the liquid metallic fabric, entranced. Then I scurried to walk next to her when we went outside.

Scarlett’s cheeks flushed and she looked at me out of the corner of her eye when a group of teenage boys whistled at her. “Oh my God,” she said, under her breath. We walked a little faster to the car.

“Okay,” she said, settling into the car. “Now, take me home so I can put some clothes on, this dress is crazy trashy.”

Seated in the car, the dress had ridden up her thigh and the lengthy slit in the side went all the way up to the middle of her hip. The material was casually draped around her pelvis and her middle, and the top hung low, almost to her nipples.

I tried to picture her sitting in the seat next to Alessandro, her thighs within his reach as he shifted gears, her pussy just inches away from the hem of her dress.

I let my gaze travel up and down and around Scarlett’s body, so by the time I got to her face, she was annoyed. “Honey,” she said. “Let’s go.”

I started the car, concentrating the best I could on maneuvering my vehicle through the mall parking lot and into traffic. My eyes kept wandering to Scarlett’s legs, the hem of the dress that seemed to be creeping slowly closer to her pussy.

“You should wear that,” I said absently, giving voice to the very image that surfaced in my mind at that moment, “and not wear any panties.”

The words were out of my mouth before I realized that I was actually speaking.

My eyes flew up to Scarlett's face, expecting her to be scandalized. She looked more bemused than anything. "Are you *joking*?" she said.

But that was all she said. Her arm was resting on the lip of the car door beneath the window, and she folded her elbow inward as she looked out the window with a faint smile on her lips. Absentmindedly, she brought her fingers to her lips.

We drove like this for a while, each of us lost in thought about the possibilities with Alessandro, about the heat between us in the dressing room. About where this would go from here.

At least, I think that's what she was thinking about, too, because a few stoplights later, I felt the weight of her hand on my thigh. Her skin was hot, it melted through the fabric, igniting my skin. By the time I looked over at her, her fingers were sliding down to my inner thigh.

She was looking at me. Her cheeks were flushed and her lips seemed plumper. Her pinkie finger moved casually along the seam of my pants, tickling my shaft ever-so-lightly through the material.

I remember the moment clearly because of my chest: my heart felt like it was being stirred around in a cauldron of ice water and flames.

On the one hand, there was no denying that Scarlett's excitement was delicious. The touch of her finger on my inseam, moving upward, tugging at the button, the zipper, the material of my pants, was exhilarating. I was driving too fast, with too little attention being paid to the road, the lights, the fact that we were lawyers and doing unlawful things in a vehicle.

But it wasn't so much the crossing of that particular line that added the ice-cold water into the swirl of things: it was Scarlett herself. She was hot in that trashy dress, but when she embraced it like this, a nagging feeling started up in the back of my mind.

The way back of my mind, though: more of my mind was interested in Scarlett going ahead with exactly what it was she was doing. I could feel the metal knot of the zipper as it made its way down, pulled by Scarlett's fingers. I gripped the steering wheel and stared at the road.

I gave her one last look before she leaned over in my direction. *You're not actually going to do this*, I wanted to say.

But before I could say anything, Scarlett's hand, slightly damp and very warm, closed around my shaft. In quick succession, before I could put a stop to any of it – not that I probably would have – her hair was brushing against the underside of my forearms, the scent of her shampoo and the back of her neck wafting up from my lap, and then the hot wetness of her lips closed around the crown of my shaft.

“Scarlett, I -” I said, but I cut myself off when my foot stretched out involuntarily and pressed on the gas. Scarlett's mouth was moving downward, enclosing more of my dick, her tongue working in circles inside of her mouth, tickling my shaft. And then she started to suck on me, really sucking, her lips moving up and down the half-length of me that she had freed from my pants and underwear. I gulped at air, held the steering wheel too tight, and tried desperately to concentrate on the lights and the street.

I finally pulled over on the side of a road that ran along a field on one side and some new town homes on the other.

Scarlett continued to suck on my cock. I pushed my foot into the brake, because I couldn't get at the shifter, and rested my hand on her hair.

Her tongue made its way around the tip of my cock again, and her lips started their descent, enclosing me, and I gripped her hair. “Scarlett,” I breathed, and tugged on her hair. Scarlett sat up and used her hand to stroke me as my cum exploded, three strong squirts, landing all over the place. I looked over at her as she watched me come, her eyes fixed on the head of my cock. My semen had splattered in thick ropes across her hand, her wrist, on her fingers, as well as on my pants and the steering wheel.

Scarlett smiled, and looked around the street where I had stopped. “Where are we?” she asked.

I shook my head, and reached for the gear shifter to put the car in park while I cleaned myself up a little. “What was *that*?” I asked.

Scarlett looked back at me and smiled. “I don't know,” she said, and it really seemed like she didn't. “But you better take me home to return the favor.”

I stared at her.

“Also,” she said, after I put the car in gear and exhaled sharply, pulling the car out onto the wide road and scanning the neighborhood for something I recognized. “We have to send that picture to Alessandro.”

“Lift your hair up,” I said to Scarlett. “And sort of... I dunno. Strike a pose.”

We had gotten to work on the photo almost immediately, but not before having a quick and dirty romp on the couch. This came as a great shock to me – I was actually a little tuckered out from all the sex we’d had today. Two incidents of which had been blowjobs in the *car*.

Scarlett gave me a look, and then she laughed. “Like this?” She made a duck-faced impression of a selfie-face, and pushed her hair up until it was a total mess, while crouching and thrusting her breasts out. It was a sarcastic imitation of all sexy Twitter photos, ever. And yet, it looked pretty damn good.

“Actually,” I said. “That’s pretty hot.”

She shook her hair down and rolled her eyes at me. But then she snatched the phone with one hand, caught her hair up in her hand with the other, and looked away as she held the phone away from her. She snapped two pictures and handed the phone back to me.

“They’re blurry,” I said. “But they’re hot.”

And they were. The deep cut between her breasts, which revealed so much of her tanned skin and the rising hills of her tits, gave way to the tantalizingly loose shimmer of metal over her abdomen, enough to keep you guessing. Then the fabric tightened over her pelvis, and against her round bottom, hinting at the perfect shape but just loose enough to make you crave more. In the photo, only her jaw line and a wisp of blonde hair showed of her face.

She climbed onto the bed and on top of me to look at the photos. She was playful but hesitant at the same time, and the combination was driving me wild. My cock was already recovering from earlier, twitching to life under my weight, pressing against the mattress.

“This one,” Scarlett whispered in my ear. Her body was pressed up close against my back, the soft curve of her breasts hot along my shoulder blades, her stomach firm along my spine. I could smell the tinge of sweat she had worked up on her arm, which she laid over mine to point to the photo she wanted. “Send that one. It looks the most like a selfie.”

I selected the photo of her choice, which I incidentally liked the best as well. I liked that her left leg was bent slightly behind her right, showing

the length of her inner thigh. Where, if everything went right, Alessandro's cum would dry. Maybe she would fuck him in this same dress, in a bathroom at *The Haute*, and take a picture of it to send to me.

A shudder traveled down my spine.

Scarlett looked at me with concern. "You okay with this?" she asked.

"I just... no, yeah, I'm more than okay with it, I just had a... a really dirty thought," I said.

Scarlett smiled. "And that was...?"

She had turned her attention back to the phone. She was starting to type below the photo.

"That you might fuck Alessandro while wearing that dress, and, uh... send *me* a photo."

Scarlett's face felt hot against mine for a moment, and she sucked in her breath. "That's..." she said, and then she left the thought completely unfinished. I couldn't have guessed in a million years how she meant to finish that sentence. That's hot? That's depraved? That's... not going to happen?

My heart started to stir in that cold-hot cauldron again.

"Is this too much?" she said, changing the subject to talk about what she was typing on the phone. She was already deleting whatever she had typed.

"Less is better," I managed to say. "Just write... 'how's this?'"

It was now hours after Alessandro had sent the message. I wondered what he was doing right now, where he would be when he saw the picture of my wife, how long it would take him to respond. And *what* he would respond.

"I think it's too much," Scarlett said, her finger hovering over the phone. "I think... yeah. I don't want to seem, I don't know, slutty. Or..."

I rolled her off my back, plopping her next to me.

"Hey," I said. "You don't have to go through with any of this if you don't want to."

Scarlett chewed on her lip, holding the phone, still deliberating about it. "It isn't so much that," she said. "It's just... I don't know. Aren't I a little old for this? I'm like, sending a picture of myself like I'm some teeny hoochie..."

“I think calling yourself a ‘tweeny hoochie’ automatically makes you a ‘middle-aged lawyer’ level of uncool,” I laughed. I took the phone from her. “Besides. Isn’t that the point of all this, kind of? Just to have some fun? Some much-too-young-for-you, sexy fun?”

Scarlett crinkled her nose. “I guess,” she said.

We were both on our backs now, looking at the phone. I had my thumb over the send button, and I was waiting for her okay, I really was. But she moved on the bed, and my finger hit the send button as she did.

“Agh!” she squealed, sitting upright like a bolt. “Oh no!”

“Shit,” I said.

Then I looked at her. “You were going to send it anyway,” I said sheepishly. “Weren’t you?”

She stared at the phone, open-mouthed, settling herself on her calves. “Oh my God,” she said. I couldn’t tell if she was horrified or thrilled. She brought her hand to her mouth. Then her eyelids slowly lifted and she stared at me.

I had no idea what she was going to say, and I’m not sure she did, either.

Then her phone hummed in her hand.

“Yes,” she said, reading Alessandro’s message – a nearly instantaneous response – from the screen. “Wear *that*.”

We looked at each other.

Scarlett set the phone down on the night table and looked at me. “Am I really going to do this?” she asked, but the question was just as much for herself as it was for me, or the air, or the sky.

I drew my finger along her arm, and was satisfied to see that goosebumps raised the pale hairs on her forearm, something I could only see in the silhouette of the bathroom light, which was on for reasons I couldn’t remember.

“It’s up to you,” I said.

Scarlett looked at me, and her smile grew stronger at first, and then fell, into a frown. She stroked her arm. “That’s not fair,” she said. “Don’t put it all on *me*.”

“Huh?” was about the only thing I could think of to say.

Scarlett hugged herself and then dropped her arms and let out an exasperated sigh. “It’s not just me, right? I don’t want to get stuck with this

decision if... I don't know, if it..."

"Turns out bad?" I finished for her.

Scarlett was looking at me.

I remembered, at that moment, a pop-science article I had read about how women wouldn't generally take big risks even in a game. The researchers had used the board game Risk to determine this.

"Listen," I said, thinking about this very thing. "Why don't you just... try out flirting with him this first time? Right? And I can call you with some fake emergency. Or even, you know... show up, so you *have* to leave. You know?"

I figured this was the equivalent of a half-assed attack.

Scarlett seemed to like it, too.

"Do I write him back?" she asked, holding the phone up.

I thought about it.

"Let him stew some more," I said. In truth, I didn't really want Scarlett getting into some kind of cutesy conversation with Alessandro.

Scarlett looked hesitant.

But then she set the phone back down on the night table, and rolled into bed with me. I put an arm around her and stroked her shoulder.

My eyelids were heavy and I was tired, especially after so much sex. The last thing I remember Scarlett saying was, again, "Are we really doing this?"

I murmured something, but I was already half-asleep.

Chapter 7

Thursday rolled around in slow motion, and incredibly quickly at the same time. I had a deposition and a discovery that day at work, so I was nearly too busy to think about what was going to happen between my wife and Alessandro that afternoon. I was also not thinking about what would happen if Scarlett decided she wanted out of her date sooner than later, and I couldn't get away from work. For all I knew, I would be there until ten pm.

I hadn't told Scarlett that, though. So a strange kind of guilt was gnawing at me all day, as the deposition dragged on into mid-afternoon, already threatening to make the rest of the day run later.

At three, we were still hacking away at it, and I was temporarily taken out of the room as I thought about Scarlett, getting dressed for her "lesson," adjusting the short tennis skirt to frame her hips perfectly, turning around and looking over her shoulder in the mirror to see how her ass looked. Scarlett, carrying her silver dress to the car, covered in plastic. Would she change at the club? I wondered what shoes she would wear.

And how would Alessandro – who had seen that silver dress and probably jerked off to it that very night – be during their lesson? Would he even give her a tennis lesson? Or would it be a very different kind of lesson she got from him? Would he skip over it entirely, and tell her to change her dress so that they could get on to bigger and better things, and he could more easily seduce her?

At four, I got a knot in my stomach that felt like the flu. What the hell were we thinking? That dress was scandalous, and the only thing it said was "fuck me." My wife wouldn't stand a chance against Alessandro's charms, and they would be fucking against a wall before her lesson was even scheduled to end.

I excused myself, and I must have looked bad enough to pass for ill, because Jamie, who was a bossy first chair, waved at me and nodded. I had beads of sweat gathering on my forehead.

I locked myself into one of the very lovely private bathrooms at the firm, and took out my phone to frantically type to Scarlett that I had been thinking and ...

And what?

I paused for a moment, trying to synthesize what I was thinking about. Did I not want her to go out with him? Did I not want her to wear the dress? What had I been expecting out of this “date” with Alessandro? And where did I think it would go from here?

But there were already messages from Scarlett. A half-finished sentence loomed on my screen, the last of several messages:

[Scarlett]: *I hope that's okay. I think i...*

My stomach did a pirouette. I touched the screen and pulled up her messages.

[Scarlett]: *Hey sweetie. I'm leaving now for my lesson... last chance to change your mind about anything.*

[Scarlett]: *okay... well... I think I've changed my mind about it*

[Scarlett]: *the dress, that is. Here's what I'm taking instead*

A selfie of Scarlett, hair in a ponytail, no makeup, posing in our bathroom, appeared on the screen. She was wearing a black cocktail dress, one I vaguely remembered seeing before, a very long time ago. It was pretty, but much more conservative.

Still, she looked hot.

Man, she looked *hot*.

I read on, relief dancing with disappointment in my chest:

[Scarlett]: *I hope that's okay. I think it would be a little too much to wear the other one... yet. Make him, stew, right?*

The last message had been sent over an hour ago.

I leaned against the wall, staring at the screen, my eyes unable to stop lingering over the picture of my wife. I typed and re-typed, and finally settled on:

[Me]: *Clever choice. You look amazing*

I sent it, and breathed heavily, feeling a little sick as my fingers kept typing and I stared at the message they had written.

I took in a deep breath, looked at the ceiling, and pressed my thumb to the screen.

When I looked down, the message had been sent.

[Me]: *I haven't changed my mind about anything.*

I splashed cold water on my face and returned to the deposition. My fingers itched to keep typing. *Text me if you want me to bail you out. Don't do anything you don't want to do.*

Don't fuck him.

Fuck him like a slut.

Is it still too late to wear that dress?

Please find a suit to wear.

But I didn't write any of these things. I just thought them, over and over, while I watched the clock and wondered what my wife was doing at every tick of a minute. Getting closer to Alessandro, closer to crossing a line, closer to... What? What would it mean for us?

I had an urge to suddenly put the brakes on everything, and I took my phone out of my pocket and tried to type without looking at it, under the table (a useless effort, in case you're tempted to try). But I couldn't find the words to stop her, even though a rational part of my brain was telling me that I'd gotten enough out of this adventure already. Enough: Scarlett was excited about sex again, warming up to Santa Fe, giving me blowjobs in the car.

It was enough.

But I'm the kind of guy who always wants more.

The phone went back in my pocket and I tried to focus on my work.

The message came in at 7:05pm. I got it immediately: everyone had turned their phones on and most people were addressing family concerns of one type or another. Where are you? Will you be home for dinner? The

unwritten rule was that it was fine to sort that stuff out – as long as you stayed and finished your work in the end.

It was an attachment only. I had no idea what I was looking at, at first.

And then, slowly, the image began to take form. Not the image in the picture: that was, undoubtedly, a bare-naked, fully *waxed* pussy, sheltered between two pale and toned legs, spread slightly, as though done illicitly, under a table, or somewhere public...

And that pussy, I realized the more I looked at it, was my wife's.

It took a bit to realize it, though, because while Scarlett had always been pretty... tidy... she was never a full-Monty kind of girl.

The wax job stunned me so much I could do nothing more than stare at my phone, at her snatch, and wonder when she had done that.

Behind me, a frat boy intern tisked. "Nice," he said.

I set the phone face-down and looked up at him, turning my chair.

"Dude," he said. "I spend half my *day* looking at porn."

I raised my eyebrows.

"Not.. I mean, you know, while I'm waiting for a copier and stuff. There's... here, we need you to look over these files."

He skedaddled, unaware that I was only raising my eyebrows because he'd thought that my wife's pussy-picture was porn.

I opened it again. It was only then that I began to put it all together: not only was this my wife, and not only had she shaved her snatch, she was out on a date with her hot tennis instructor, and she was taking pictures of her snatch.

That she hadn't bothered to caption.

I closed messenger. Then I opened it again and zoomed in on the picture, searching in the terrible resolution for some sign that her pussy was not only bare, but touched. Touched by Alessandro. Swollen, or red, or dripping with cum.

I only saw that her clit was hard, protruding a little, but who knew what that meant? Maybe it was always like that.

My stomach felt cold again.

I started to type a message back to her, and erased my thoughts over and over again.

I put my phone away and stared at the file the frat boy had given me. The words swarmed in front of my face, meaningless. I could only see my

wife, laughing at some table with Alessandro, leaning on her elbow and touching her fingers to her lips, one hand between her legs with her phone.

Or my wife, the black dress pushed up to her hips, her legs spread and Alessandro holding her like she weighed no more than a blow-up doll, his shaft pistoning in and out of her in some laundry room at the club.

Or maybe in the car. Maybe Scarlett was on top of him, her legs perched on either side of his muscular thighs, her hand guiding the tip of his cock to her dripping pussy. Some of her juices plopping onto the crown of his dick, and she was smearing them with her thumb just before engulfing his big, fat cock in her wet flesh.

I opened the photo again and again, trying to figure out how it had been taken.

I typed:

[Me]: *Did you go out without any underwear? You naughty girl.*

There. That was fun, playful. It showed I cared, that I was into what she was doing. Why *wasn't* she wearing any underwear? And when had she shaved her snatch?

I added to my message:

[Me]: *I like the haircut, btw. Really, really like it.*

I stared at my sent messages. I was starting to feel a little desperate. It was 7:45. Why hadn't she written back? Why wasn't she wearing underwear? And didn't women only shave their snatch if they were planning on sleeping with someone new?

Dan was talking to me. He had been for some time, and I was answering him with nods of my head and "yes," and "no." The occasional piece of information about the case rolled effortlessly off my tongue.

But I was miles away.

Miles away.

"William. You look sick. You look sick as hell. You wanna cash it in for tonight and pick this up tomorrow?"

“I’m fine,” I said weakly. But I did feel sick. In a way. Sick like you might feel if someone stabbed you with an Epi-pen you didn’t need.

“Go home and get some rest,” he said, forcefully. “I can’t have you half-assing this motion.”

I folded the file up, and stood up, unsteadily. I wasn’t sure if I was hamming it up a little, or actually weak-kneed, or just plain losing my mind, or acting like a teenager who would do anything – anything ridiculous – to score. “Uh,” I said. “Okay. I’ll go home and sleep... it off. I usually... feel fine if I just pop some pills and sleep.”

Dan nodded, and went on immediately. He was a no-nonsense kind of guy.

I went to the bathroom first. I typed a message to my wife, who had not written back.

[Me]: *where are you? Text me if you want me to come rescue you.*

I hurried out to the car, as if there were some kind of emergency I could go to. I didn’t drive in the direction of our town home. I told myself I was going past the new place, but I took every turn in the wrong direction, going to the country club.

I drove past it, up to the road where we had parked and had sex in the car. I turned around and went back to the club. There was non-valet parking left, and I sat in the car after parking it and checked my phone.

No messages from Scarlett.

God, what had I done? Why in the hell had I given my wife permission to go out with this creep? He was young, good-looking, a tennis player. Maybe he was independently wealthy. It had been fun as a fantasy. It had been fun while it made Scarlett hornier, prone to giving me blowjobs and talking dirty. But now that I was alone in my car, wondering where she was, staring at a picture of her shaved snatch which might be the last thing she ever sent to -

The phone vibrated in my hand, and my keyed-up state made me shake and drop it into my lap.

“Jesus,” I muttered.

[Scarlett]: *Everything's fine here, no need to rescue*

I stared at the phone, waiting for more messages to appear, for her thoughts to continue. I wanted details about what “fine” and “here” meant.

I waited. It felt as though an eternity passed, but in all likelihood it was only five minutes. I wondered if I should write to her, ask her where she was, exactly, and what she meant by “fine.” But when I tried to type a message, it felt too crazy: wasn't I the one who had nudged her into doing this, all of it? The dress, agreeing to go out with Alessandro? Not wearing panties, which had been my suggestion?

I stared out the window. I couldn't even remember if it had been a suggestion, or not. Had I only thought of it, fantasized about it, and not even voiced it?

My stomach coiled into a tight ball.

I looked at the club. Would they have stayed here a while? Or would Alessandro have preferred to take her somewhere else, before going to *The Haute*, which I had discovered wasn't open until 9? Or worse yet, would Scarlett have preferred to take him somewhere else until then? Away from people who might know us, or be associated with our ever-growing social circle?

The thought of Scarlett taking him to another location revolted me as much as I appreciated it: it was nice, on the one hand, that she might have thought about the repercussions to my reputation by taking him somewhere else. And yet it was horrifying, because that would mean that she was serious about something happening between them. Something real, something physical.

And I still had no idea how I actually felt about that.

I got out of the car, thinking to myself that Alessandro didn't really know who I was. I could take a look around the club, see if they were there, sit down and watch them the way I had before.

If they were there, of course.

I floated through the club as though I were in a dream, without my feet touching the floor, it felt like. The restaurant by the pool had opened up some doors that I didn't realize even existed, so the whole place was open to the pool area, and candles lit the whole area with a surreal romantic light on the ordinarily sun-bleached stone pathways.

A fitting transformation, I supposed.

The place was about half-filled, with a lot of gray-haired couples and men with much younger women. About the norm for this rich-people's club. And so it was not hard to spot them: two young, toned people together, looking beautiful. Alessandro's black hair actually shone in candlelight, and Scarlett's bare arms glowed with her new tan.

They were seated at a small round table at the edge of the restaurant's boundaries, close to the pool. Glasses of various sizes and shapes were scattered on their table, and little plates: the look of a table that had ordered many drinks over a long period of time and which the waiter was at loathe to return to because the couple was so intimate.

And intimate they were. My knees went slightly weak at the sight and I found the first table I could, in the middle of the layout, almost tucked behind a tall column between the big, opened doors of the restaurant.

Scarlett was facing me, but she didn't see me at all. Her eyes were on Alessandro, watching him talk, a flirtatious smile on her lips. Her legs were crossed beneath the table, lined up in a pretty diagonal to the side. She had on a sexy pair of heels that wrapped around her ankle in intricate straps; I found myself staring at them because they were so alluring, even though I've never been a foot guy. They were so unlike anything I'd ever seen her wear.

She had both arms on the table and was leaning over it, the candles lighting up her skin with a rose blush. Both Alessandro and I had an excellent view of the slight dip in her black dress, which gave a peek at the curve of her breasts, and the dark valley between.

I ordered a gin and tonic, without remembering that I did so, and stared as they talked. I waited for my wife to look up and around, with even just a hint of nervousness at what she was doing. Or to look at her phone, to feel guilty or even uncomfortable that she was at a restaurant with her tennis instructor, sitting like *that*, talking so close and so long to a man who she surely knew had a sexual interest in her.

And what of Alessandro, I wondered. Did he know she was married? Of course he had to, I thought, almost at the same time that Scarlett lifted her hand and twisted her wedding ring on her finger, almost like she had read my mind.

But even as she played with it, and fingered it, it seemed to be a mere habit; she didn't take her eyes off Alessandro, and her smile didn't falter as she asked herself what she was doing.

I gulped my drink and ordered another.

I took out my phone and deliberated about what message to send to her. Inside, my organs liquefied to frothing boil as I played out all of the possibilities: that she would ignore my text, that she would laugh and show it to Alessandro and they would shake their heads about what a fool I was, that she would lie to me if I asked her where she was.

I settled on taking a picture of them and sending the picture. The waiter brought my next drink while my fingers hovered over the screen.

Then I sent it.

A whole lifetime went by after I did that, and stared at my wife, waiting for her to respond. I didn't even know where her phone was, or how long it might have taken for the photo to travel to space and back, and be reassembled there on her device. But minutes that seemed like hours ticked by afterward, and Scarlett just kept smiling and looking at Alessandro, talking and sipping her wine, telling stories with her hands moving flirtatiously. She tapped her lips with her fingertips, tucked her hair behind her ear, moved her foot in a circle beneath the table.

And all the time, the searing pain in my chest spread out. Jealousy, so cold it burned through me.

Alessandro reached forward at one point, and touched her hand. He grasped it firmly, and shook it slightly, and I stared as my wife reacted by widening her eyes and laughing. It took me a moment to realize that the gesture was part of some story: his voice, the words unintelligible, rose above the quiet murmur of people talking and dishes clanking. It was followed by Scarlett's laugh: a falsetto peal of laughter I hadn't heard in ages.

Alessandro leaned in to speak to Scarlett, leaning over the table and letting his arm slide closer to her. Scarlett smiled conspiratorially, and leaned in closer as well. Her foot bobbed forward as she did, and brushed against his leg. She didn't move it. Her slutty-wrapped foot was against his calf.

They spoke, and Scarlett let her eyes drop as though thinking something over. Then she leaned back in her chair and Alessandro raised his hand and turned toward the wait station.

My heart dropped for a moment. The check. That must have been what he was doing.

What did that mean? Good or bad? Were they leaving to fuck somewhere? Or were they leaving separately?

Scarlett brought a hand up to the table and flipped over her phone, which had been sitting on the table all along. She swiped her fingers over the screen and my blood turned to ice as I watched her: surely she was looking at the picture I had sent her.

Her face remained calm, expressionless, as though she had read a boring news item. Alessandro spoke to a waiter while she picked up the phone so he couldn't see it. I couldn't tell if she was typing or not.

But worst of all: she didn't look over at me, didn't even glance.

Alessandro turned his attention back to her and Scarlett set the phone down. Her eyes never even flickered in my direction.

Maybe she hadn't gotten the photo.

I looked at my phone, confirmed that I had sent the message. It had been read.

My heart was beating in too-slow swells that kicked against my chest but deprived me of oxygen. Another drink appeared at my table. I stared at my wife, who went back to talking to Alessandro.

The waiter came back and Scarlett began to wave her hands in protest. The waiter set two more drinks down, and Scarlett made a big show of refusing the drinks. It was as if I could hear her voice, telling him she couldn't drive, she had to get home, she was already drunk...

But not *really* protesting.

Alessandro leaned forward and put his hand on her knee.

This is when Scarlett broke. Alessandro never would have noticed it, nor would many people, but I knew my wife. It was sort of like a glitch in the matrix: a brief flicker of horror, so fast the average human would not see it.

Scarlett was out of her depth, or something had crossed a line with her. I had no way of knowing what it was: Alessandro's hand on her knee or something he had said. But her skin paled momentarily, her smile became a

plasticized version of itself, and she raised her hand to roll the ends of her hair between her thumb and forefinger. A sure sign.

She recovered in nanoseconds, and her face was back to normal. Words formed in her mouth, all with a smile, and Alessandro retreated, his hands waving gently in that universal sign of “no sexual overture intended” that all men make, all over the world, when they get semi-rejected. They sipped their wine.

But Alessandro was going back in. He gave it some time, he made some small talk. He leaned forward in micro-movements until he was back close to her, flirting with her, trying to reel her in.

The fucker, I thought.

But I was also deeply, inexplicably turned on. Watching my wife as though she were some other person, watching another man try to reel her in.

I started to get edgy after what seemed like hours passed. People were leaving, I was feeling like an obvious stalker. Someone we knew might see us. I wanted them to *do* something: either for Scarlett to cut him off or for them to leave in a hurry to go fuck.

Just as I was reaching the pinnacle of impatience, Scarlett took her eyes off Alessandro for just a second, and looked right at me. It was a brief glance, but it was unmistakable. The corner of her mouth turned up in a mischievous smile. She knew I was there, she knew I was watching.

And she wanted me to know that.

After she did that, she took her forefinger and moved it lazily over the rim of her wine glass, while she leaned her head to one side and said something to Alessandro.

That was sexy enough, all by itself, to burn right through me, from heart to cock like a slow-moving acid.

But the kicker?

At the same time, she uncrossed her legs, and pulled them apart.

Just slightly. I didn't even get to see anything *really*. Just the tanned skin of her thighs, disappearing into a shadowy triangle where I knew her pussy was bare and open to the warm night breeze. She drew her free hand along her thigh, right there in the restaurant, though no one could probably see what she was doing but me. All the way up, taking the fabric of her dress with her, until she dipped her finger into the shadows beneath her skirt.

While she did this, she kept talking to Alessandro, her eyes on his face, her other hand making the sexually-charged slow circles on the rim of the wine glass.

My stomach felt like a shifting ice block.

She straightened out her skirt, pulling her hand up to the table. Her legs closed. She stopped talking, and there was a pause while the two of them looked at each other. Alessandro's face was mostly obscured but I could see the line of his jaw, that he wasn't talking.

Scarlett lifted her hand, the one that may or may not have just dipped into her pussy, and rolled her thumb over our wedding ring again.

Alessandro's jaw moved as he started to speak.

Scarlett let her left hand fall forward, right to his lips. Her fingertips were against his mouth, and if she had dipped her fingers into her pussy it was impossible that the tangy scent of her did not reach his nostrils.

The gesture she made was one of silencing him. She said one more thing, picked up her phone and a purse that seemed to materialize from nowhere, and then she rose from her chair.

As she walked past him, he dropped his hand to caress her calf, and she looked down and back with a smile but kept walking.

Alessandro let his hand fall back, hanging next to him dejectedly. He stared straight ahead.

My heart soared as my wife walked out to the edge of the pool and then kept walking. She looked at me sideways, and gave her head a slight jerk, as she strolled out of the club.

I beckoned the waiter to get the bill from him. Alessandro remained where he was, looking toward where my wife had been sitting.

I wondered if he was plotting his next move, or thinking about something she had said – if so, what? - and I almost felt sorry for him. I was high and I also felt disappointed.

Just as I stood up to leave, my phone buzzed.

[Scarlett]: *I took a cab. Meet me at home.*

I barely remember the drive.

Chapter 8

Scarlett came to the door when I arrived, looking like she didn't know what to do with herself. She was still in her dress, but a lot of the confidence she'd radiated had fallen away. She didn't seem to know what to do or say as I got out of the car and walked toward the steps to the house. Her expression was a mix of horror and excitement, anxiety and anticipation. Sort of kid-at-Christmas meets car accident.

I myself might have looked the same, but I took decisive action once I reached the doorway where she was standing. I slid my fingers into her hair, just above her jawline, and pulled her toward me to kiss her passionately.

She might have wanted to say something: I felt slight resistance as my lips met her mouth and I pushed my tongue between her teeth. She pulled away a little, but I pulled her toward me, and her body relented, melted, became pliable as I pushed us both into the house and kicked the door shut with my foot.

I pushed her through the hallway and several doorways as I fumbled for some way to free her from her dress. I tugged at the shoulders, hoping it would slip off, then I felt for a zipper at the back and found none. My cock was throbbing against my zipper, but Scarlett's hands soon freed it and my pants started to fall, making it hard to walk. Not that I noticed.

I gave up on getting her out of the dress and jerked the shoulder of it down. I heard a small tear in the fabric but I didn't care – her left breast was freed from the confines of the dress and bobbed over the material, her pink nipple hard and waiting to be sucked.

My other hand went under the dress to find her smooth pussy. Since she was walking backwards (and I was pushing her), I may have run my fingers over it several times without realizing it. But when my fingers got wet and sticky, I knew I had the place, rolling under my skin as she walked. She was wet, and her skin was as smooth as silk, and it made my blood boil like nothing ever had before.

I pushed her onto the bed and she squirmed, hiking the dress up. I shimmied out of my pants, staring at her pussy: the skin where she used to have hair was slightly pale, more pink, totally smooth, as though nothing

were there at all. It glistened, though, and in the center it split open to reveal a sliver of the red-hot flesh that was between those bare folds.

I wanted to ask her when she did it, why she did it, who it was for (me or him), what she had said to him at the restaurant, if her fingers had been dipping into her cunt before she touched his lips... so many things. Her mouth moved as though she had something to say as well, but instead of any of this, I fell on top of her and clutched her hair in one hand, holding her head to the mattress so that she could only look right at me.

“That was so fucking hot,” is all that I said before I guided my cock to her slick pussy. I slid into her with so much ease that it seemed absurd: I didn’t remember my wife ever being this wet, this hot, this ready to fuck without me first licking her clit to excite her.

We looked at each other, and, at least in my mind, the only thing I could think about was the montage of hot images I had just watched at the restaurant.

It was a wildly quick and dirty fuck. I think she came within moments, and I followed her, racked by an orgasm that was more intense than any I’d had before. I leaned against her, one arm supporting myself so I didn’t crush her. My hand slid on the mattress and pulled on her hair, and she gasped. I sort of enjoyed it though, and maybe she did too, because her pussy quivered around my cock and she squirmed in pleasurable discomfort.

I released her hair and rolled onto my back.

For a moment we said nothing.

Then Scarlett sat up. She looked at her dress, where it was torn, and let it drop from her shoulder. She didn’t seem perturbed by it.

She looked over her shoulder at me. “I was going to ask you if that was... too much... but I guess...” she said, and smiled to end her sentence.

I sat up and played with the torn dress. “I’m sorry about your dress,” I said. I dove right in. “Why did you end up not going to *The Haute*?”

She shrugged. “Too much,” she said vaguely, then added, as though I would be confused about what that meant. “I decided.”

Something was troubling her. And as soon as I had that realization, something began to trouble me too. I kissed her shoulder. “What’s wrong?” I asked.

Scarlett let out a sigh. There was a long pause.

“Is it maybe too much?” she asked, exhaling again. She looked at me. “You know?”

“But you didn’t do anything,” I said, playing with her dress again. My eyes were on her breast, on the bit of nipple I had never sucked, and my cock was twitching back to life again already. “Except maybe...”

Scarlett looked down at me. As if she sincerely had no idea what I was talking about.

“Oh, that,” she said suddenly.

“Did you actually touch yourself?” I dared to ask. “Back at the restaurant.” I wasn’t sure I wanted the answer, no matter what it was.

Scarlett looked hesitant. “I mean... it wasn’t like, dripping or anything.”

I exhaled.

Her eyes moved back to look at me. I was making circles on her arm, moving inward toward her breast. I bit the material of her dress. “So what did you say to him, anyway? Tell me what happened.”

Scarlett turned toward me, lifting one leg up to half a cross-legged position. I could smell her pussy, my cum acrid inside of it. My eyes dropped involuntarily to her bare snatch, and my left hand moved without my permission to rub my thumb along the swollen red line of her gash.

Scarlett let me do it.

“You really want to hear this?” she asked.

“If you want to tell me,” I said.

“Don’t you feel... I don’t know. Jealous? Or bad? Or like... like, this is a really *bad* thing to be doing?”

I moved my hand along her inner thigh and met her eyes with mine. “It *is* bad,” I growled. “Tell me all about it.”

Scarlett looked like she was either going to laugh or cry. “I think maybe it’s a little... I don’t know -” She gasped when my fingers made their way back to her clit, and flicked it. Her breath became shallow and her eyes grew dark as her pupils consumed them.

“You seemed to be having a good time,” I said. “You seemed very in control.”

I was starting to finger-fuck her, the slick contents of her pussy dripping all over my forefinger and middle digit. A shudder traveled

through me when I thought about what it would be like to do the same thing – to feel the same slimy cum-filled walls of her pussy, knowing that the cum on my fingers belonged to Alessandro instead of me.

“I feel *out* of control,” Scarlett said, in a half-whisper. Her eyelids grew heavy as I turned my fingers inside of her and sought the rough patch of her g-spot. But the walls of her silky cunt were too wet, too cum-filled, to feel my way around. I drove them in further and curled them outward toward the base of her clit. She mewled slightly.

“That’s part of the fun,” I said. “Don’t you think?”

Scarlett’s mouth was half-open, and she started to shake her head. I moved my thumb to the face of her swollen clit – and she spread her legs willingly to enable me to do this – and rubbed, and the shake of her head stopped, like an unfinished sentence, hanging there, half-turned.

“You like it,” I said next to her ear. “Don’t you? It’s okay if you do.”

Scarlett’s eyes opened. She turned her head slightly to look at me. She looked a little scared.

“I don’t...” she said, but her thoughts fell apart as I rubbed her clit and drew my fingers in and out of her.

“Did you want to fuck him tonight?” I asked. “It’s okay if you did. It *looked* like you did.”

Scarlett’s cheeks reddened. I didn’t know if it was from my words, or the fact that another orgasm was boiling up inside her. She put a hand on my shoulder and moved her pussy closer, grinding against my hand.

“Tell me what you feel out of control about,” I said. “That you want to fuck Alessandro?”

Scarlett mewled again.

She was getting closer, which I could almost not even believe. She had *just* come, only minutes before. Her pussy quivered around my fingers and her nails were digging into my shoulder.

She really was a little out of control; I had never seen her like this.

I slowed what I was doing, and the ripple of disappointment that went through her was strong enough that I felt it through her skin. “Don’t stop,” she complained in a whisper.

“Tell me what you feel out of control about,” I prodded. “And I’ll make you come again and again.”

She pushed against me to get my knuckles grinding into her clit, but I pulled my hand away and brought my hand to my lips. I licked the inside of one finger suggestively, enjoying the taste of her pussy, which was surprisingly dominant, even over the cum I had just fucked into her.

I put my fingers into her mouth, and opened it. She surprised me by licking my fingers, cleaning off some of the mingled juices.

“Tell me,” I said, “Or I’ll tease you all night.”

I punctuated the threat with a delicate swipe over the liquid on her clit.

“I... I liked you watching,” she said.

“That’s all?”

She looked at me.

“And I wanted to do all kind of slutty things while you watched me.”

I rewarded this utterly orgasmic sentence by thrusting my fingers inside of her. Against all odds, my cock was hard again and I was ready to fuck her brains out.

We entangled ourselves again, rolling on the bed, thrusting and fucking wildly. I let my imagination take over, picturing Scarlett being fucked by Alessandro exactly as I was fucking her, her legs spread wide and her mouth open, her eyes looking up at him with the same wild need.

Scarlett’s pussy trembled, and then clenched me, as she came again, and strained up at my shoulder to sink her teeth into my flesh. She twisted her fingers on my nipple as she did – another strange first, a thing that wasn’t something we usually did, and it made me wonder where it came from. There was enough erotic content in that wondering alone to send me over the edge. I filled my wife’s pussy again.

We lay together, Scarlett’s head on my shoulder, in a long silence afterward.

I think both of us were a little stunned by what had just happened.

I stroked her arm, and I was dozing off, when I remembered the question – well, one of them, at least – that had been nagging me all night long. That is, when I wasn’t more occupied by other things.

“Hey, when did you wax?” I said, and I felt Scarlett move her head, and the shape of her mouth change against my skin. I couldn’t see to what: a smile? A frown?

There was a pause that I thought might have been a little too long. “Oh, I did that yesterday,” she said. Her lips formed a new shape on my chest. She brought her hand to the spartan smattering of hairs on my pecs and played with them. “Do you like it?”

I exhaled. “Do I like it? It’s hot as hell,” I said, very honestly.

I left out the part that something about it – something about her doing it without telling me first, made me uneasy.

“Why?” I said, after a long pause.

Scarlett answered immediately, half-yawning, and the immediacy and casualness of her voice made her answer sound truthful:

“That swimsuit is so skimpy. I went in for a wax because who can keep up with shaving all summer? Plus it gives me bumps. And the lady was like, just go all the way.” There was another heavy pause between this sentence and her next. “So I did.”

“It didn’t have anything to do with Alessandro?” I asked.

Scarlett pushed herself up to look at me. It seemed like she was going to accuse me of something, and because this was a complicated matter, I felt like I was doing something worth being accused of (though I didn’t know exactly what that was. Being too jealous after pushing my wife to have sex with another man? Who knew?)

But Scarlett changed her mind and gave me a half-smile. “I mean... it may have been why I agreed to do it, partly. You know...” She lay her head down on my chest again. “Just in case.”

I felt my cock, as though I were eighteen again, pulse beneath the sheet. My stomach twisted in a new and convoluted knot.

There was a long silence while I pondered whether or not I was enjoying myself.

“Are we really going to do this?” Scarlett asked, her voice swallowed by a yawn.

I took too long to answer, so by the time I drew my hand down her back and said, “If you want to,” I think she was asleep.

Chapter 9

Even though it might seem strange, or even unbelievable, we sort of set what had happened aside until the next week. We filled the weekend – me with some work, Scarlett with studying for the New Mexico bar, and some shopping for the new house. I was so content with the new atmosphere between us that I didn't want to rock the boat, do something to disturb it.

And her next meeting with Alessandro was like a secret we shared together, something in the future that we didn't want to ruin with too much talking.

At least, that's how I saw it.

I didn't know what Scarlett would do next with him. I didn't really know *what* I wanted Scarlett to do with him next. The only thing I could be sure of is that I wanted her to do something, that I loved the thrill of anticipating her next lesson, and the cold, jealous nausea and then hard, erotic heat that would travel through me in waves.

I went to work on Tuesday and suffered through the day, which was incredibly busy. Ordinarily, I threw myself into my work, wholeheartedly, forgetting everything else and the passage of time. It was what had propelled me to earn this job, at this prestigious and high-paying firm (even if it wasn't in Chicago).

But now I was obsessed with my wife the same way I was usually obsessed with work.

Her messages did not disappoint:

[Scarlett]: *I just went to my tennis lesson.*

[Scarlett]: *I could feel his erection against my ass the whole time.*

[Scarlett]: *He's asked me to go with him to get some new shoes*

I was reading these messages at five pm, because I had been caught up in a serious meeting about a drastic misstep in a class-action suit, where no texting would be excusable. Not only that, it looked like I was going to be balls-deep in work until at least nine pm, which was the unofficially

“okay” time to leave, and still look loyal to the firm, when something like this happened.

The messages were old, time-stamped from earlier in the afternoon.

I closed the door to my office and sat down to savor them. My mood turned sour and paranoid almost immediately afterward.

I looked at the clock. Then I typed.

[Me]: *New shoes, huh? For who?*

I waited a long, long time for Scarlett’s reply. Half an hour, which felt like a century.

[Scarlett]: *For me. Psst don’t tell anyone but I kind of think it was a ploy to get me alone with him.*

I smiled when I read the message, but it felt a little like a wince in my gut. Scarlett’s next message came through as I was typing my hesitant response.

[Scarlett]: *We’re going for a drink now.*

[Me]: *How’d that happen?*

[Scarlett]: *He’s a smooth guy. How soon can you be here? This isn’t as much fun unless you’re watching.*

My cock was unprofessionally hard under my desk at that particular moment, when someone knocked on the door. My head was spinning, and the only thing I could think about were Scarlett’s words: *isn’t as much fun unless you’re watching...isn’t as much fun unless you’re watching....*

“I’m... yeah, I’m sort of busy,” I called. Then, hopelessly, trying to remember to behave with some decorum, I croaked: “Come in.”

It was Jill, who, like her name, seemed imported from the fifties to be an assistant. “Mr. Green, Jack is asking me to bring down the RBG files.”

I stared at her over my desk.

What the fuck was she saying? *It’s no fun unless you’re watching?*

“I... they’re over there,” I said, trying to sound grumpy.

“Thanks, Mr. Green. So sorry to disturb you.”

Jill awkwardly removed the box of files and edged out of the room while I tried to look busy with a document on my desk.

While Jill was in the office, Scarlett had written me two more texts.

[Scarlett]: *Hello? I would have thought that would get you going.*

[Scarlett]: *He wants to go to this place with ‘good sangria’ in El Dorado. I’ll text the address. When can you be here?*

I tried to get my shit together.

[Me]: *A bunch of stuff just blew up. I can’t leave until 9-ish*

Nearly twenty minutes ticked by. After three, I tried to get my head in the game – the game that made my living, that had leased me a car and made me move to New Mexico and pass their oddly bat-shit crazy bar exam – but words on the paper all swarmed in front of me and my cock sucked away every last drop of oxygenated blood that was supposed to go to my brain. *Watching, watching, watching...*

Finally, my phone buzzed. But it wasn’t Scarlett.

More waiting.

Then, at last:

[Scarlett]: *I’ll do my best to wait for you*

I sucked in my breath and tried to compose myself.

What the fuck did that mean, she’d do her best to wait for me? *Wait for what?* I wanted to type.

But I didn’t.

After all, Scarlett was an attorney, and she chose her words carefully. She knew it was much more fun if I didn’t know.

Chapter 10

I was tortured by Scarlett for the next few hours, as I struggled to concentrate and attempt to extricate myself from my work as quickly as possible – a new game for me. My head was on my wife, no matter how hard I tried to rein it in to the work at hand.

She texted an address at seven, and then a new one at eight, with what seemed like a hastily, drunkenly written message that had been auto-corrected to total garbage:

[Scarlett]: *History only nose*

This was followed by another, almost ten minutes later:

[Scarlett]: *Sorry. This one now. This address now.*

[Scarlett]: *Get here soon*

I did my best, but it was almost 9:30 by the time I left. I spent all the time until then trying to concentrate, yet unable to stop thinking about what was happening between them at that moment. Scarlett, who had evidently blown Alessandro off last Thursday, had probably only made him more determined, more intrigued, more in the mood to conquer my wife. He was obviously trying a different tack now, the tried-and-true bait-and-switch. But he was also undoubtedly encouraged, because Scarlett was not going to agree to go shoe-shopping if she really *really* wanted to keep her marriage vows.

My chest ached.

I was so obsessed with my thoughts that I forgot I had GPS in the car, and programmed the address into my phone, which I left on the seat. It was just one more way that Scarlett and I were nouveau-riche, I supposed.

I arrived at the bar, a casual but trendy-looking place, not a chain but resembling a Chili's to such a degree that I wondered if they had ever been sued.

My eyes darted around the parking lot and seizing on every couple, every movement. I typed to her:

[Me]: *I'm here*

There was no response. I realized that I had no idea if they were still there. I didn't know what Alessandro's car looked like, or if they had driven together. Scarlett's car was not in the lot. Had they left? How much should I bother them? Should I send another message?

I hunkered down into the seat, burning with jealousy but enjoying it immensely. Maybe Scarlett was somewhere else, drunk as her first message, banging the shit out of Alessandro.

Maybe she didn't care if I watched at all.

Luckily for me, before I could get too dark and inside my own thoughts, the door to the bar opened and they emerged: Scarlett in a tight pair of capris and a scandalous tank top that looked as though she had purchased it at the same store as that metallic dress. It tied behind her neck and then hung down her front. Only a slender string across her back kept it tied there: the back was bare. She was wearing heels.

She looked perfectly, delectably slutty. Unlike herself in many ways. I quickly sent another message.

[Me]: *I see you*

Alessandro opened the door to his car for Scarlett, who did not go digging in her purse or so much as flinch, so if she felt or heard that a message had come through, she didn't show it.

It was wildly infuriating, and hot at the same time. She tossed her hair back and treated Alessandro to her magnificent, flirtatious smile.

I burned inside, gripping the wheel of the car.

It *seemed*, and was easy enough to believe because I wanted to, that Scarlett was just putting on a show. But she hadn't read my message, so she possibly didn't even know that I was here. Was this how she acted all night? What else had transpired between them, inside the bar, as their inhibitions melted away?

Alessandro closed the door for her and then got in on the driver's side. The brake lights went on briefly, then off. The car stayed where it was.

I couldn't see through his darkened windows: what they were doing, where they were positioned in the seats. But the car remained where it was for a long time. Long enough for a decent conversation... but too long for just a conversation.

And conversation was not what Alessandro was in it for. No, they were in there while he made a move on her. Maybe they were kissing, maybe he was trying to convince her to go home with him.

Was she resisting? Did she want to, but only wanted to do it if I was watching? Or was it worse, and she wanted to do it without me now that he had his lips on her mouth and he was such a good kisser?

The back of the car said nothing to me: it offered only a blank stare, for what seemed like an eternity.

The brake lights went on again, and the white reverse lights. I started the car but left the lights off. I looked at my phone again, and then watched as Alessandro reversed. I saw them, facing each other, my wife smiling and looking as unconcerned as a woman could look, like she was on a first date or something. My eyes zoomed in on the position of her arm – it was stretched out at an angle.

The kind of angle that would place her hand on Alessandro's knee.

I just saw a flash of this scene and then they were gone, his white Audi braking only minimally at the street. When he turned into traffic his car roared, which irritated me.

I followed them.

For a while, the car just drove. They were headed back in the direction of the country club, and so it seemed likely that she was just getting her car and going home, teasing him more, claiming to be married and unwilling to cheat.

But at a crucial turn, they went another way, onto a smaller road. I hung back, driving slowly. A car moving the opposite way honked at me and flashed his lights. I had forgotten to turn them on.

I put my hand on the switch and then hesitated.

Just as I was thinking about whether or not to play spy games, Alessandro's car moved oddly, pulling a little to the left and into the – thankfully empty – oncoming lane. It jerked suddenly, and then drove wobbling and drifting, ever slower.

For a moment I thought Alessandro was drunk, and I worried about Scarlett's safety. I grabbed my phone, turning over whether or not to call the police or her.

But when the car slowed and came to a stop next to the curb, I realized my mistake.

I drove as slowly as I possibly could, and tried not to gawk, but in the end it didn't matter. Alessandro was not focused on who was in the street looking into his car. His mouth was open, he was looking straight ahead.

And the passenger seat next to him... appeared to be empty.

My blood burned and I whipped my head back to watch where I was driving. My cock was hard, my mind was filling in the rest of the picture: my wife in his lap, her mouth around his cock, her lips sliding up and down his thick shaft like she had done to me just weeks before. I could almost hear the wet sound of her saliva streaking down his fat prick.

Robotically, I turned into a driveway just around a small bend in the road, and backed out to turn the car around. I drove back down the street, my eyes on the windshield of Alessandro's car, on his face as it came into focus, on the minute rocking of the vehicle as my wife bobbed her head up and down on his shaft.

And then I passed the car.

I considered making another pass, though I couldn't say exactly what I wanted out of it: more pain? More desire? My cock was aching and my chest was tight. I pulled into the parking lot of a taco place and sat in a darkened corner by the dumpster, breathing hard.

My wife was giving Alessandro a blowjob in the car, less than 500 yards away from me.

I sat in the car, unsure of what to do with myself, my blood on fire and my insides reeling.

At long last, Scarlett sent me a message.

[Scarlett]: *sorry I missed you. Coming home now.*

I read and re-read the message.

What did I want from it? What was so unsatisfying to me about it?

Would Scarlett lie to me, if I asked her what happened? Or would she simply not tell me about it if I didn't ask? Why did I feel like I had any right to feel as... possessive of her as I did right now, when I had been the one to push her into this? Was I just sorry that I hadn't been there? Or sorry that she didn't wait until I was where I could watch her?

I decided not to write back. I tried to start the car, which was already running.

I drove home in a daze, and while I was driving Scarlett sent me another message.

[Scarlett]: *Yoo whoo. I did something really naughty that I have to tell you about. See you there?*

This made me feel better. Much better.

What didn't make me feel good... or maybe it did?... was that I was subject to such wild swings of my emotions, all based on the slightest provocation from Scarlett. Maybe that was the high, the thing I wanted from all of this.

But just like anything I'd ever done that made me high, I could smell it in the air:

It was dangerous.

Chapter 11

Scarlett was already home, and she had poured herself a glass of wine, drunken half of it, and sent me two more messages asking me where I was. She had changed out of her clothes and into a slip-like nightie, which made me wonder why in the most delicious way.

When I came through the door she slinked toward me, and her sexual energy was amped up to a level I didn't really remember her ever being at before.

She slid her arm around my waist. "I have a surprise for you," she said.

I raised my eyebrows. At the moment, I just didn't know what to say, so I decided to stay silent and see what Scarlett came up with.

What she decided to tell me.

And what she didn't.

She set her wine glass down and pulled me toward the kitchen table, where her purse was tossed carelessly. She sat down on the table and spread her legs, pulling me toward her. Her fingers went to work loosening the knot of my tie.

"Where were you?" she asked. "I held him off as long as I could."

I raised my eyebrows again. "Does that mean... something happened?"

Scarlett looked up at me. "I told you," she said. "It's not any fun unless you're watching."

Her eyes were wide and looked as truthful and deep as they had ever looked. For a moment, she was telling me a lie and my world was breaking apart into pieces: my wife was such an incredible liar and she was lying about something she had no reason to lie about. All was lost, I was a fool, and everything she had ever told me was suspect. Anger boiled up and my fingers twitched with a desire to throttle her.

But just as quickly, it was all gone. She reached behind her and fished her phone out of her purse.

"You weren't there, but I managed to get *something* on my phone."

My insta-rage was taking a minute to boil down. I was steeped in testosterone, in lust and anger and the thought of bending her over and

fucking her in the ass was pecking at my sanity.

“Something like what?” I said.

Scarlett brought a finger to her mouth and sucked it. She drew the phone down my chest sensually, and tapped it lightly on my erection.

“Things got pretty heated in the car,” she said.

She smiled at me. My anger was evaporating, and pure lust was taking over.

“And?”

“And.... I ended up giving him a blowjob. In the car.”

I took the phone in my hand. “And?”

She took the phone from between my fingers. “I think I got some audio. I was thinking... I could show you what I did, while you listen to it.”

Her knee was against my cock, so she felt it when I pulsed wildly against the confines of my underwear and pants. I sucked in my breath, and tried to say something, but no words occurred to me at the moment.

She swiped her fingers over the phone and set it on the table, her eyes gleaming mischievously. For a moment the sounds were nonsense: the rubbing of the microphone against something, the curved hollow of a sound bubble as the phone was moved. Distantly, traffic. A horn.

Then Alessandro’s voice: “Jesus.”

More rustling.

As this prelude went on, Scarlett slipped her hands between my legs and traced the form of my cock with her fingers, over the material of my suit, before she unclasped the pants and tugged to make the suit and the underwear fall together, pushing them down to my knees.

As she did this, she rolled on her buttocks until she was at the edge of the table. Her eyes were on mine, and over this searing look the sounds from the car filled the air:

“Jesus, Scarlett...”

And then a rustle. A zipper, another rustle.

Scarlett dropped between the table and my legs, down to her knees, keeping her eyes on mine the whole time. She had her hand around my cock, and it was pointed out straight and erect.

On the audio of her phone, just barely audible, I heard the sound of her wet mouth as she did something to Alessandro...

She showed me, in real life, in our kitchen: she extended her tongue and swirled around the head of my cock. As the wet sounds increased in frequency on the audio, her tongue moved faster, and her lips closed around the head of my cock just as Alessandro said “Yeah, baby, oh, fuck, just like that...” and then murmured something in Italian.

Scarlett took me into her mouth and moved the heat of her tongue and her lips slowly down toward the base of my shaft, where she paused and lingered before going back up.

“Oh, keep going,” Alessandro’s voice was saying. “You can do it.”

Another slurping sound. In real life my wife slid her mouth up to the head of my cock and left her lips very close to the pulsing crown as she said, at the same time as her own voice on the phone:

“It’s too big, I can’t get it all in my mouth.”

Her eyes were on mine, a smile on her lips.

“Just try,” Alessandro was saying, and a layer of sound beneath his voice betrayed that he was pushing Scarlett’s head down his shaft, More slurping, a cackle like a gag. “That’s it.”

In the kitchen, my wife swallowed my cock to the base. So she had been able to get his fat cock all the way to the back of her throat. How much bigger was he than me? Had she enjoyed it, swallowing all of that meat?

The audio on the phone degenerated into slurping and sucking and the fervent breathing of Alessandro, who said “Oh yeah, of fuck,” and something in Italian every three seconds or so.

And then he groaned.

My own cum was boiling up, ready to burst in her mouth.

“That’s it,” Alessandro said. “Swallow it for me, baby...”

More Italian, which sounded very dirty.

“Did you swallow his cum?” I asked.

The audio in the car became muffled. A thunk was heard – the phone must have fallen. On the screen, light appeared where it hadn’t been before and streaked across the screen.

I came into my wife’s mouth as she looked up at me.

Answering the question, I suppose: she kept her lips sealed around my cock at the base as I gripped her hair and pushed her into me, delivering my seed to the back of her throat in three successive squirts.

She released me noisily. The audio on the phone ended just as Alessandro was saying, “Oh, fuck, baby that was -”

Scarlett fell back on her heels and took her forefinger for a leisurely trip around her mouth, tracing her lips and the little glob of cum that had pooled in the corner of her mouth.

I exhaled sharply and stared down at her.

“Holy... shit...” I said.

She stood up, and turned slightly to scoop up the phone.

She didn’t get a chance. I slid the straps of her slip down and pulled until the fabric peeled away from her like a wrapper. Her breasts burst out from behind the material and bounced in front of me. I caught one and scooped it up to my mouth, bending over slightly to get my lips closed around her hardened nipple. I bit slightly into it and she gasped. My free hand was pinching the other nipple, and she squirmed in my hands as I pushed her onto the table.

I kissed her on my way down to her legs, but only briefly, hungrily. I had just come and I couldn’t fuck her just yet, though my cock was quickly springing back to life. I pushed her legs open roughly and hiked her skirt up.

I was surprised to find that she was wearing a thong: white fabric nestled in her ass crack and just covering the smooth peach slices of her pussy. I pulled on it, jerking it to one side, noting that the fabric was soaked like someone had just taken it out of a bucket of warm water. I could smell her pussy: tangy and sweet, entirely her, nothing but her wild excitement gushing all over her panties and the kitchen table.

She propped herself up on her elbows and I dropped to my knees on the floor, grasping her buttocks in my hands, pulling her to me. It was a surprisingly good fit, the kitchen table, her pussy, my mouth. I marveled at it for a moment before pulling her wet, juicy gash toward me, my mouth wide open to take in as much of her soaked vestibule as I could.

My mouth sank into her like she was a ripe fruit. The taste of her filled my mouth: she was so wet that already her excitement was dribbling down my chin. I explored the silky inner lips, darting my tongue into the sodden hole of her vagina, and then I closed my lips around her hard clit and made her gasp.

Her hand went to the back of my head.

In my mind, as I ran my tongue over the face of her clitoris and she squirmed in my hands, I pictured the image of Alessandro in the car, staring ahead with his mouth agape, as my wife sucked the cum from his huge cock. I imagined her lips stretching wide, her jaw aching, her throat convulsing as she gagged on every last inch of his meat.

“Oh!” Scarlett wailed, as her thighs tightened around my ears and her muscles rippled in spasms on her abdomen. She was looking down at me, watching me, but her eyes were consumed as she looked inward somewhere. “Oh God, oh my God,” she said.

She leaned her head back. “Don’t stop,” she said.

I brought her very close to the edge, and then I slowed my licking of her clit. Her thighs squeezed around my head and she clawed at my hair. “Don’t stop!” she pleaded.

I pulled away enough to speak, my breath hot on her clit. She quivered as I spoke: “Tell me how big his cock was,” I told her.

“So big, oh please, don’t stop.”

I licked her lazily. I wanted more.

“Oh...” she wailed. “It was...fine, it was so big... it... I’ve never seen a bigger cock.”

“Did you gag on it?”

She looked at me. “I... yeah. Yes. Okay? Please...”

I sucked on her clit and she started to get worked up again. Then I slowed. “Show me,” I said, looking up at her face. “Show me how wide you had to open your mouth.”

Then I gave her a lick just for good measure.

She hesitated, and then, her hips shaking and her thighs wet with her excitement, her clit actually spasming next to my lips, she relented.

She opened her mouth. Wide. Even wider.

And then, even though I was already extending my tongue to start massaging the face of her clitoris, she brought one hand up, and put it in her mouth, and spread her fingers open, pulling her jaw down even wider.

I sucked her clit until she screamed. She fell back on the table, her legs spread and quivering.

I stood up, and my cock was hard as a rock by then. I pushed myself into her, and as she lay there, mewling, her mouth open wide, I fucked

another load of cum into her, the image of Alessandro's wide cock in her mouth superimposed over the sight of her pulling on her own jaw.

After we took a shower, which ended in more sex, we lay on the bed, our limbs entangled, once again on the cusp of sleep. I was determined to have a conversation with Scarlett about what had happened – not just the car and the blowjob, but everything leading up to that. While the sex was what was important to me while *we* were fucking, when all was said and done in that arena, I had an itch to have been a fly on the wall, watching Alessandro flirt with her, listening to her reactions to his attempts. Was he a cheesy, Italian-lover stereotype? Dumb as rocks? Or well-spoken and clever?

“So... how did all of this end up happening tonight?” I asked, after we lay in contended silence for a while.

Scarlett stirred against my chest. “All what?” she asked.

For a split second I thought she was making a joke of some kind so I laughed. Then I realized, as she turned her head up to look at me, that she really was asking for clarification.

“All... this. You know. I'm curious. How did *Alessandro* get you to go shopping with him, how did he segue into the bar, what happened in the car that made you decide to... you know.”

And when, when did you get my texts? And did you decide before or after them to go this far with Alessandro?

“Like, you want to know what he *said*?” Scarlett asked incredulously, lifting her head and perching her chin on the back of her hand. Her long fingers played with my chest. I could feel her smooth pussy against the outside of my thigh when she turned; a streak of slippery cum followed its movement when she rolled to face me.

I kept my eyes on the ceiling. “Yeah... I guess. I want to know how he seduced you. Is he a smooth talker, or what?”

Scarlett chewed on the knuckle of her thumb and grinned, I could see it out of the bottom of my eye. “He's... well, I don't know. Just a regular guy.”

I sighed. “Humor me,” I said. “How'd he start putting the moves on you?”

Scarlett laughed lightly. "God, Will, like every other guy. He was like, oh, Scarlett Green, that's a very colorful name." She mimicked his Italian accent.

"And you were like?" I prodded.

Scarlett tossed her hair and bit into my chest. Hard. "I gave him the same line I give everyone who says that."

My sister's name is Noel and she married a guy named Derek Winter.

A pang of very real, very foul jealousy, unlike the other kind I felt when I thought of her sleeping with Alessandro, clawed inside of my chest. "So you just used all the same lines on him that you did on me," I said.

I sounded angrier than I meant to.

Scarlett pushed herself up on one arm, so that her hair was hanging down and brushed against my chest as her body swayed. Her other elbow dug painfully into my chest. "My name wasn't Scarlett *Green* before I married you, you idiot. We never had this conversation."

Then, in a softer voice: "Anyway. He's just... I'm only going along with this because of you. He's sort of..."

"Dumb?" I offered hopefully. Scarlett professed to hate stupid men.

She made a face. "Eh... not so much dumb as just... shallow. Young." She looked at me, and I must have seemed unconvinced because she leaned forward and kissed me. "Don't worry. You have nothing to worry about."

I felt myself getting hard again, though for completely different reasons than before.

"And so what did he say, how did he get you to go to the bar with him?"

Scarlett put her hand on her face, as though she were embarrassed. "Oh, God, I don't know. I really don't know. Something like... oh, now you have new shoes, it's an Italian tradition that we go drink to celebrate or something like that."

I snorted, but at the same time, I thought about it honestly: it wasn't that much stupider than some of the things *I'd* said to women to get them to go have a drink with me.

"And so you said?" I continued. I really wanted every detail from the story.

Scarlett smiled. "I was like, 'oh, really? Okay?' and then we went."

I paused. "Why was your car at the club?"

“We drove together.”

“To the shoe store?”

Scarlett’s expression was turning a little annoyed. “Yeah. Why?”

I held my hand up, to indicate that I was just probing. “I just wanted to know, okay?”

Scarlett kissed my chest, then moved her tongue around on my nipple. “You trying to steal his moves?” she asked. Her hand had slid down my chest and found my cock, hard, twitching in response to her suggestions. “Is that it?”

“I just want to know how this Italian guy is seducing my wife, is all,” I answered. Just saying “this Italian guy” sent a wave of uncontrollable desire through me, and my cock pulsed in Scarlett’s hand. She grinned, bringing her mouth back to mine.

“Did you get my text before or after you gave him that blowjob?”

Scarlett squeezed my cock. “Were you watching?” she asked.

“I followed you,” I breathed.

Scarlett smiled. “Good. Because it’s not the same unless you’re watching.”

And from there... the conversation fell away, and it was mid-morning and far too late ask for clarification by the time I realized that Scarlett had never really answered my question.

“So what do you think *Alessandro* has planned for you today?” I asked Scarlett on Thursday as she poured me a travel mug of coffee.

Scarlett smiled secretively and pushed the mug across the counter with two hands. “A tennis lesson,” she said simply. Then she raised her eyebrows innocently. “What else?”

I raised *my* eyebrows. “That’s *my* question.”

Since the night that Scarlett had given him head in the car, Alessandro had sent two semi-cryptic text messages: *That was a great lesson* and *Don’t forget your new shoes today. I have some new drills for you.*

Scarlett had shown them to me, and we had made a lot of jokes about them. She had asked me what to write back to him, and I had been the one to encourage her to keep him guessing. We had finally settled on: *see you then.*

“What if he thinks I’m not interested?” Scarlett asked.

It was hard to believe that anyone as good-looking and her age could be that naive.

“Scarlett,” I said plainly. “You’re a hot married woman who gave him a great blowjob in his car while he was driving. I think he got the message.”

This had made her laugh, but I saw her poring over the messages with her lower lip between her teeth, thinking about sending him something else. I had pretended not to notice.

“I wonder what kind of drills he’ll have you doing?” I mused aloud.

Scarlett set the phone down. “I hope this doesn’t mean I don’t get my tennis lesson,” she said. She lifted her coffee cup to her mouth. “I was getting really good.”

I blinked at her, not sure what percentage of her blasé tone was a joke.

“Message me,” I said.

Neither one of us really knew what that would mean. I couldn’t come running to every text, obsess over every encounter, try to watch everything she did.

We kissed. I held on to Scarlett for a little longer than usual. She searched my eyes. “Are you sure we’re doing the right thing?” she said.

I hesitated before saying “Yes,” as convincingly as I possibly could. It was long enough that I knew that Scarlett had picked up on it, the whiff of doubt. But she played it off well, and we kissed again, and I left her in the kitchen, her hand on the counter, the phone close to her fingertips, her lesson with Alessandro only hours away.

Both of us wondering if it was a good idea or not.

Scarlett ended up deciding that it was best to tease Alessandro on Thursday, though she never really gave me the details. She sent me a breezy text that afternoon:

[Scarlett]: *I’m just going home see you there*

When I got home, she was in yoga pants and making a delicious dinner for us, which I ate even though it was very late and I had been well-fed by takeout on the firm just hours before.

When I asked her why she hadn’t gone out with Alessandro, she had leaned provocatively on the counter and placed an olive between her teeth.

Her smile was alluring.

“Partly to tease him. Partly to tease you. Partly because... I don’t know how far I want this thing to go yet.”

We had sex that night, with those words lingering in the air and stirring me up in ways that I felt like Scarlett herself wasn’t aware of. After all, I didn’t know where my feelings came from, how far I wanted to take them. I assumed that Scarlett would eventually sleep with Alessandro, but part of me wanted this perpetual fantasy to be dragged out as long as possible. So that we would never have to reckon with any reality.

Which I’ve found eventually comes around, and usually sucks.

Over the weekend, things didn’t change much. But Monday night, when I got home late, Scarlett was still awake. She was wearing yoga pants again, a dark pair that flattered her figure in incredible ways, somehow accentuating her curves but making her look even leaner.

She had a troubled expression in her face. She was cradling a glass of wine to her chest when she walked into the kitchen to greet me, her eyes thoughtful and slightly red at the rims. It was the sort of appearance that many people might mistake for crying, but Scarlett had a tendency to get like this when she spent a lot of time thinking.

Although, I had never seen her do this when she didn’t have a legal case to think about.

The wine glass was one of those enormous, over-sized jobs that you would only find in corporate housing. It was half-filled with red wine, and Scarlett’s pink lips were darkly stained from the glasses she’d already consumed.

She didn’t seem too drunk as she entered the room with a business-like air and approached to kiss me on the cheeks.

Scarlett gets a business-like attitude that is hard to miss, when she is about to business or chop your personal problems into little legalistic pieces, or make a case for buying expensive throw pillows or shoes.

But I could feel it in my gut: today’s business-like attitude was not about any of those things.

“I’ve been thinking,” she said, after kissing me, and even she said it like she knew it was completely unnecessary. She had my hand in hers and

pulled me toward the kitchen island, where she sat me down and got another glass for me.

When she tugged the cork out of the wine bottle, only about a quarter of it sloshed around beneath the dark green glass, and she emptied it unceremoniously into my glass.

She took another gulp of her own, over-filled glass, and met my eye.

“I want to break things off with Alessandro. I’m going to quit my tennis lessons tomorrow.”

I brought out my poker face, even though her words set my pulse to racing without the meaning of them even having time to get to my brain. I took a sip of my wine and considered things.

Scarlett waited. This was another rule from marriage counseling. WAIT. (Why am I talking?) It’s a good rule, and like most rules the marriage counselor had given us, there was a close counterpart in the advice that lawyers gave their clients (shut the hell up).

Scarlett doesn’t make declarations like this lightly, the way some women do. So I knew that whatever I thought about it, she wasn’t really asking me, or hoping I would change her mind. She was going to do it.

Now all that was left was for me to react to the news.

I was deeply conflicted about it, I could feel that in the hot-cold burns that streaked through my body. My heart rate accelerated and my vision dulled, I felt angry and I felt relieved. My diaphragm seemed to move oddly for a moment, and I hiccupped once. I gulped some wine to chase it away, but it was an isolated event.

“How come?” I said finally.

Scarlett’s eyes were dulled from the wine she’d consumed, but her features were all put together in an expression of assuredness.

“It’s too much,” she quietly. “Too big of a risk.”

She paused, and I repeated to myself to WAIT, WAIT, WAIT and say nothing, even though I wanted to.

“I like what we have now,” she said, and her voice was like glass, smooth and convinced. Convincing. “I’m happy we did... this. I think we needed it. But I don’t want to risk it. That’s why.”

I tapped my wine glass.

She was right, of course. I agreed with her completely. A big part of me was really relieved, and that part of me felt like it was filled with breath

of fresh air. I felt light, like I was floating.

“I feel that way, too,” I said.

I looked down at the counter.

“Really?” Scarlett said.

It was a big question. What does “really?” mean, anyway? I *did* feel that way; I’d had these very same thoughts.

But “*really*?”

Not completely. Spiraling through me was a black coil of disappointment. That part of me was crashing to the ground. My mouth was fighting a frown.

“I’ve had exactly these same thoughts,” I said. My voice sounded hollow. I stood up, and went around the counter to pull Scarlett to me, as though having her touching me (and not looking at my face) would make the relieved part of me win over, sound more real.

I supposed it worked. Scarlett’s hands moved over my back, and she bit one of my nipples through my shirt. “I’m so glad you think that,” she said. “And anyway...”

She looked up at me, and her eyes were lusty, derailing me from whatever thoughts I was having. “We’ll always have it as a... you know. Fodder.”

We kissed.

It was passionate in many ways when we made love that night. A part of me clung to Scarlett and held her close while I fucked her slowly, in a way that was more about love than lust. In the end, Scarlett wanted me, and wanted our marriage, and didn’t want to risk what we had. And our sex life was ignited again, and we felt close again.

And that was all very, very good.

I wanted to be very, very happy.

But there was something missing that night, as great as it all should have been. We came at the same time and both acted like it was great.

But something was missing.

I feel asleep consoling myself: I was a middle-aged man, and this was about as good as it got. I should just be happy we had that great time, grateful that she didn’t want to push it any further and risk what we had.

Sure, I was confused by her sudden change of heart, but it was all for the best.

All for the best.

I had pretty much convinced myself of that by Tuesday morning. I wished her luck and checked to make sure that she was sure: her face was stone-like in its assurance. She smiled warmly and kissed me.

“It’s for the best,” she said.

Chapter 12

When Scarlett told me the story that night, she did it seated on the same stool, chewing on her thumb and refusing to look at me, as though she were reciting the lines of a deposition.

She had wanted to tell Alessandro personally, because that was the kind of person she was. After all, she had been leading him on, she had sucked his cock, she had flirted with him and let him pay for tons of drinks. Also, she was quitting lessons, and say what you will, he was a good instructor and deserved at least a professional cut-off.

While she told me this part of the story, she fingered her wedding ring, running it in circles around her finger, the diamond disappearing and then re-surfacing. She did it absent-mindedly, with an erotic touch. I stared at her fingers as she wound it around and around, and I couldn't help getting caught up in the symbolism of it: that her wedding ring was there, a thing she played with, sometimes without even knowing it.

Alessandro had seemed to know what she was going to say before she even said it. He was drinking some water in the club bar that looked out on the tennis courts, a fitting end, in my imagination, to the story that we had started there in that very same place.

As she told the story, I pictured it in my mind: Scarlett's hesitant smile, the way she would have stopped just a little too far away from him, her face set in those same business-like features she had shown me the night before.

"We need to talk," she had said, but he had already been smiling a little disappointedly, like he knew what was coming.

"You're quitting," he had told her. And then he had nodded, and taken a sip of his water.

He had asked her if I had found out – and I had loved that he called me "your husband," in the story, and that he had no idea who I was.

She had been partly honest, and partly a lawyer-liar: she told him she thought I might have started to suspect. She said she had given it a lot of thought and realized she wasn't willing to pay the price if I found out.

Alessandro had taken it well, there in front of James, who probably wasn't even right there, but whom I imagined, shining a glass, watching the

conversation soulfully. He probably heard it all the time.

And then he had asked her if she wanted one last drink, for old time's sake.

I could see her also in my mind. Shrugging, her pony-tail bouncing. She had probably figured that Alessandro was the kind of guy who fucked women all the time and so things ended this way all the time, and he was a professional of sorts. She had probably assumed that he had really *meant* that they should just have a *drink*, for old time's sake.

I asked her what they talked about: she couldn't remember. It was a boring, strange conversation, she said.

Then she had kissed him on the cheek, he had wished her good luck and told her to keep playing, because she was very good.

When she had looked back at him, he had been sipping his water. A neutral expression on his face.

I remember looking down at my own drink when she got to this point in the story. Thinking it was the end, feeling like... I don't know. The losing team of a championship that was played really well, or maybe the winner, but one who won on a technicality rather than true merit.

Not victorious, but not defeated.

There was a long pause while I tried to think of something to say, and then I heard Scarlett exhale sharply.

I had a client once, back when I handled bodily injury claims for an insurance company in Michigan, where the stakes were high. The guy had a head injury, so he often told the same story over and over – not even a story really – about the moments after the accident when the police lights had lit up the falling snow in blue and red, and he had thought about how beautiful it all was. And now that was the final moment of his life from before, just before when he realized that his leg had been crushed and he would never walk again.

I blinked slowly, my eyelids a momentary veil, and I had a thought like that. A foreboding cold started to overflow inside of me. Was this it? The last moment of “my life before?”

I suddenly wanted Scarlett to stop speaking.

“But then,” Scarlett said.

I looked up at her sharply.

She had her eyes on her fingers on the counter.

“Then, uh...”

Her eyes welled up with tears.

“That isn’t all that happened.”

The implications of what she said took a moment to circulate. I had seen it coming, after all. I had wanted it, encouraged it. And then I had lived with the disappointment that it hadn’t happened. I had told myself that I was happy it hadn’t happened, that it was best left as a fantasy.

I had repeated this to myself so many times I had actually begun to believe it.

Maybe, I thought for a moment, there wasn’t much to this story. Just a kiss, or something... less.

But Scarlett’s wet eyes told me the story before she did.

“What happened?” I asked.

Beneath my fear, the anger that was spooling up, tensing my biceps and making me grind my teeth – there was also renewed excitement. My breath caught in my throat.

Scarlett looked at me, then down at her hands, and a tear spilled from her eyes.

“I went to the dressing room,” she began. “And then... I don’t know how it happened. He was right behind me. And things... just sort of... went... from there.”

My blood boiled. “Went from there... to what? Did you have sex with him?”

Scarlett gave her ring another spin around her finger. She nodded.

“Where?” I asked.

Another tear spilled from Scarlett’s cheek.

“Hey,” I said, reaching for her hand. I had to admit to myself, it wasn’t exactly what I *wanted* to do; it just felt like the right thing to do. I wanted to throw a chair across the room, interrogate her, make her tell me this story while I fucked her from behind. I didn’t really want to hold her hand and be consoling, but beneath all the layers of emotions I was feeling, it felt like the right thing to do. “Remember, I asked you to do this... you know? So...”

“I know, but then I was supposed to end it. I wanted to end it. Now...”

She looked around the kitchen.

“Now what?” I asked.

“Now.... I don’t know. Everything is so much more complicated.”

I squeezed her hand. “It doesn’t have to be,” I said.

Scarlett chewed on her lip.

“I don’t know,” she said.

“Tell me what happened,” I found myself saying. I’d like to be able to say that I asked her that in a therapeutic way, like I wanted her to get it off her chest. But I wanted to hear what had happened, every sordid detail. I wanted to hear what Alessandro had done to convince my wife to retreat on her promise to cut things off.

Scarlett put her hands to her face. “So... what happened? It all happened so fast.”

“Honey,” I said gently. “It’s okay. I asked you to do this. It’s not *bad*. But I just... I want the details.”

Scarlett looked at me. “You want the details?” she whispered.

I stood up and moved close to her, pulling her to face me, her legs between mine. I guided her hand to my erect cock, so that she could feel that I meant what I was saying.

Pretty much. I was pretty sure I meant what I was saying.

“I want you to tell me what happened,” I said.

Scarlett looked unsure.

“It will be like I was watching,” I coaxed.

There was no way to hide the flutter of arousal that went through her, and she didn’t try. Her cheeks flushed and her pupils dilated. Her lips opened, and a puff of air preceded the story.

She was wearing a taupe skirt and a white blouse. I reached forward and pulled at the buttons at her neck, and the light linen fabric, so thin it let the color of her skin through it, fell open and the lacy top of her bra peeked out. I unbuttoned the next one, admiring her breasts, the way her chest was rising and falling with her rapid breaths.

“Did you shower afterward?” I asked.

I moved my other hand under the skirt, all the way along the length of her thigh, while Scarlett watched me. She looked as though she had no idea what to do next, how much to say, how aroused to be. I would be lying if I said I didn’t like the thrill it was giving me, keeping her in the dark like that, holding sexual power over her.

I nudged her legs apart, and she spread them reluctantly but obediently. As soon as she did, the scent of her pussy wafted from under the skirt. My fingers found her pussy, bare and smooth, with no panties in the way.

But the only scent was of her, and her soap.

I got close to her and moved my lips over hers in a tease. "That's too bad," I said. "Next time, don't."

I pushed my fingertips into the soaked lips of her pussy, finding her hole, dipping into her sticky nectar and the just-fucked canal. Surely, even with a shower, some trace of him remained, and some of what I felt coating my fingers was the cum of another man.

Scarlett squirmed.

"Tell me all the details. Where did you go?"

Scarlett's eyes darted around. I bit her lower lip. "He pushed me into a changing room," she breathed.

I vaguely recalled the changing rooms, with their heavy doors and the wood benches along one side of them, the striped cushions on top of them, exactly what you would expect to find in a club for rich people.

I fingered her, slipping my fingers up to claw forward at the root of her clit, at the rough patch of her g-spot. She was as wet as I had ever felt her, so if she was guilty in one way, she was aroused in another. Like me.

"And then what?" I asked.

Scarlett's eyelids lowered sleepily as I pressed my thumb against her clit. "It was sort of... sort of fast after that," she said.

I pictured it in my mind as she told me: he had pushed her up against the wall.

"Did he say anything?" I asked.

Scarlett's eyes opened. I knew she wanted to tell me that he had, but the truth was that he had not.

I skipped the question. I pulled at her blouse with my free hand to expose her lace-cupped breasts. I held her neck with my thumb on the soft hollow of it.

"And then what?"

Fear raced through her eyes. "And then we... fucked."

"Against the wall," I said.

“Yes,” Scarlett said, and her eyelids drooped again as I pinched her clit. She gasped, I pinched her again. I squeezed lightly on her neck. “You’ve been a very bad girl, Scarlett,” I said. “And how was his cock? I want you to tell me about it.”

I could feel Scarlett getting close to coming. Her abdomen was moving in ragged gasps, her muscles closing around my fingers.

I brought her very close to the edge, and then I pulled my hand from inside of her and brought my sticky fingers to her mouth. “Did you suck his cock?” I said, as she sighed in disappointment and opened her mouth to take my fingers inside.

I moved my fingers inside her mouth, fucking her with them all the way to her throat. My other hand pulled at her blouse and her bra, no longer exercising caution not to rip her clothes. Her left breast spilled from the confines of her bra and I twisted the nipple as I watched her gag slightly on my fingers.

She shook her head slightly.

“No,” I said. “So you just got right to fucking?”

I pulled my fingers from her mouth.

She licked them as I slid them out, then played with her lips. “Up against the wall?” I asked.

I barely gave her time to nod. I saw her in my mind, her hair splashed against the subway tiles inside the room, her legs splayed and then crossed over Alessandro's bare ass.

“Tell me about his cock.”

Scarlett demurred.

“Tell me about his cock,” I insisted.

“It’s huge,” Scarlett said.

“Did it hurt when he put it in you?”

Scarlett opened her mouth a little, as if she remembered the sensation and it made her gasp slightly. “Just a little,” she said breathlessly.

“And then?”

I moved my hand back to her pussy, brushing my fingers lightly over her lips, the tips grazing the hard, protruding nub of her clit.

“And then I felt full.”

“Is his cock longer than mine?”

Scarlett's face looked apologetic, shamed, but her pussy gushed and her body was coming toward me, rolling in waves of pleasure, wanting more. She nodded.

"I want you to say it," I said.

"His cock is... it's thicker, it's longer."

I closed my eyes to ride out the spasm of nausea and lust that gripped me. I imagined how Alessandro's cock had probed my wife, deeper and fuller than I ever had or ever could. Touching her in places I would never be able to. I imagined him holding her easily with one hand under her ass, his dick sawing into her, her pussy sloshing like it was right now.

I wondered if her pussy would be loose, stretched, full of cum when I fucked her.

I worked her up again and then pulled away before she came, and she mewled.

"Get up," I said. "Turn around."

She let me manipulate her until she was on the counter, bent over, her skirt up and over her and her glistening pussy between her legs. I massaged her ass with one hand while I got myself out of my pants and guided my dick to her pussy. I was so hard that I thought I would come from just the touch of her unfaithful cunt against the tip of my cock.

I slid inside her, gliding like I was moving through butter. My mind was filling up with images: of her pussy stretched wide by Alessandro's dark Italian meat, of her legs bouncing against his ass while he rammed himself inside of her, of his cum oozing from her gaping hole. Of her tits bouncing as he fucked her senseless.

"You did good," I said hoarsely as I rammed my cock as deep inside of her as I could. Her pussy seemed slightly stretched, though perhaps it was my imagination. I wanted her to fuck Alessandro until it really was, to feel the damage he would do with his giant cock. I realized this as I sawed in and out of her.

I wound her hair in my fingers and pulled her head back as I fucked her. "That's it," I said. "Tell me how long it took you to come... tell me..."

But I had to leave the sentence unfinished because I needed to concentrate on myself, on not coming, not just yet.

"I came... I came..." Scarlett leaned forward and then threw her head back and I felt her pussy pulse and squeeze me. I released her hair and she

leaned forward on the cool of the counter, her hands flat on the marble top.

"I came twice," she gasped, and her legs trembled as she came in waves. I wasn't even sure if it was one orgasm right after another, or just one long one. Whatever it was, it sent me over the edge – that and her husky voice saying "I came twice."

I fucked my cum into her, and then stood behind her panting.

I kneaded her ass, looked at the damp hair on her neck, her rumpled blouse. My cock pulsed inside of her again.

"Next time," I said, panting slightly. "Don't take a shower."

I let my cock slip out of her, landing against my thigh, semi-hard, with a wet flop. I stared at the cum running in rivers down her thighs.

I put a finger into one of the rivers and scooped up a glob of our mingled juices. Scarlett pushed herself up, and I moved close to her, sliding my other hand around her waist, holding her possessively.

Then I put my finger on her lips, and she opened her mouth to suck my cum and hers from my finger. My cock throbbed against her ass. She gave a weak smile and a little, gaspy laugh. "Oh no," she said. "I don't think I can go again... I'm really sore."

Sore from fucking Alessandro.

My cock twitched again. I pulled on her jaw. There was always her mouth. I leaned in and whispered next to her ear. "That was so hot, baby. That was... it was so hot."

"You're not mad?" she said, turning around to face me. I shook my head slowly.

"Is that all?" I asked. "All that happened?"

Scarlett's eyes dropped down to where my cock was twitching and pulsing back to life. "Wow," she said. Then she looked at me. "That's all that happened," she said in whisper.

We looked at each other for a while, and then she started to slide down, the island against her back. She pushed me back slightly, and looked up at me as she tugged my pants further down, to my ankles.

"For now," she said, her hand on my cock, guiding it to her mouth. While she swallowed me whole, her eyes were locked on mine.

Chapter 13

Scarlett and I took a shower together, and then lay in bed, caressing each other's bodies, and made love again. Scarlett moaned beneath me and squirmed as I tried to enter her gently, softly. I knew she was sore from fucking Alessandro, and the rough way I had taken her over the island. I fucked her slowly, reclaiming her for myself, and filled her again with my cum.

Scarlett rolled on her side and I spooned her. I kissed her arm, trailed my fingers down the length of her body, playfully threatened to start fingering her again. She slapped my hand away. "Oh, I can't anymore," she said. "I'm so sore."

My cock throbbed again, and she turned to stare at me in disbelief. "You're an animal," she said.

"It's hot," I managed to say, because I was really reduced to monosyllabic grunts for the most part and it was all I could get out.

Another doubtful expression took over Scarlett's face. She rolled on her side.

"Honey," I said. "I really mean it when I say that."

"I know," she said, but her voice was weak.

"You sound like something's wrong," I said, my hand still following the ups and downs, the rolling hills of her body. "What is it?"

She was quiet for a moment. "I don't know. I just... I feel guilty, you know?"

"But I wanted you to do it."

"I know," she agreed. "Just..."

"It was really hot," I said again.

She was quiet.

"Didn't you have a good time? With him?" I brought my hand up to encircle her, wondering, for the first time – and I felt like a bit of a jerk – if maybe he hadn't been any good, and if she was disappointed.

"It's not that," she said.

"So he was good?"

She nodded.

"It's just..." she began. Then she sighed. "Oh, I don't know."

I was pretty sure that there was something else to that sentence. Something much more.

“Just what?”

Scarlett wriggled her way back to look at me. I played with her hair, pushing it from her forehead.

“You really aren’t mad?” she asked.

“No,” I assured her. I kissed her. “This was a fantasy of mine, remember?” I said.

Scarlett turned back to me, and I expected her to say something else. But the time ticked away slowly, and then I heard her say my name as I was dozing off.

“Will,” she said.

There was a long pause before I answered, a murmured “mmmhmm?” against her neck.

But by then, Scarlett had maybe changed her mind about what she wanted to say, or fallen asleep. Or perhaps I did, and she said it, alone in the dark.

When I woke up, Scarlett was already awake. The shower was on, the scent of shampoo filled the air, along with the rare whiff of something otherwise foreign in this desert locale: humidity. A falling rope of water crashed against the tile and stirred me from my sleep.

The night came back to me: like everything, it was much different in the sobering light of day. The same mixture of eroticism and insecurity coiled and released in my chest.

I remembered that as I fell asleep, I had the idea in my head that Scarlett had done this as a one-off. Sure, I had told her not to shower next time, and I loved thinking about her pussy being stretched: but after I came, those thoughts seemed more like dirty talk in the heat of the moment.

Hot, sensible, but only while your cock is wet.

The shower turned off. I heard Scarlett’s feet plop on the floor, a strangely carpeted bathroom floor that we had never ceased commenting on. We had supposed it had something to do with the dry air.

She was toweling her hair dry when she turned the corner of the dividing wall and saw that I was awake.

She paused the toweling of her hair, and her step was broken by the tiniest pause. She almost seemed surprised to see me there, as if she had half-expected me to disappear, like a one-night stand.

But she smiled right after that, and I shook off my feelings of paranoia. Scarlett came and sat down next to me, still toweling her hair.

I opened my mouth to ask her what she had planned for the day, when she started talking and cut me off.

“Listen,” she began, and it had that tone – *that* tone, the one for a talk you might not want to have. My stomach coiled tighter.

She looked down at me, and took in a deep breath.

“I like what we... did yesterday, and everything. I really did. But, um... I don’t think...”

I helped her out: “You don’t want to do it again.”

Scarlett made a strange face, half-smile, half-grimace. “Yeah... I don’t think so. I think... I think we got what we wanted out of this, you know, and now... it’s just a good place to stop. We’re moving, I’m going to take the bar and I need more time to study, there’s... it’s like, there’s too much going on for this.”

She looked at me, and I must have had a bad expression on my face, because she quickly turned toward me, lifting her leg to fold it under her bottom and placing her hand on my arm reassuringly. “No, no, I didn’t mean it like... not that it’s *only* that; we’re too busy but also... I just think it’s better to... you know, end this adventure while we’re ahead of the game.”

She made her funny face again.

I lifted her hand, and pressed her fingers to my lips to kiss them. I inhaled the scent of her skin, but it was sterile, washed clean. Fruity. Unlike her.

“I ran out of my soap,” she said distantly, as though she had read my mind. It was vaguely unsettling.

When I think about it now, I think I had wanted Scarlett to wake up and tell me she was done, that she wasn’t going back to tennis, or for that matter, the club. That we would have our fun with this adventure by dirty-talking and remembering it. She was right: our sex life was rejuvenated. We would move to the new house and start enjoying out new love – with no tennis lessons, and no country club.

It was a little disappointing, but in many ways, a relief.

“I think it’s for the best,” I told her, my breath on her hands. “You read my mind.”

After all, what kind of idiot would actually want his wife starting a regular thing with her hot Italian tennis instructor? I had what I really had wanted: my wife and I were excited about sex again. The jealousy and the adventure had been a much-needed injection into our stale marriage.

Scarlett leaned forward and kissed me.

“Okay,” she said. Then she studied my face. “Are we good?”

We *were* good. I smiled at her and said, “We’re good.”

“I love you, Will.”

I pulled her to me, kissed her, and told her I loved her, too.

Scarlett smiled, and went to dry her hair. She winked at me in the mirror as she blow-dried it naked. I admired her form, I settled back on the pillow with my arms above my head and thought about how lucky I was. I envisioned our new life in our new home, our rejuvenated sex life, starting a family. Whatever I had felt unsettled about washed away.

This had been a fun adventure, but it was for the best that it ended now, before too much was risked or someone got hurt.

It was probably for the best.

It just isn’t what ended up happening.

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

APOLOGY!

Due to a glitch in the Amazon system, I've had to remove direct hyperlinks from my backmatter. I apologize for any inconvenience this causes my readers. Any of these titles can be located on [My Author Page](#)

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

A Taste For Teasing

Oren knows he's a lucky man with a hot wife: Monica is blonde, stunning, and has a killer body. She was even a cheerleader in the NBA in her university days – and there are even more interesting jobs in her resume than that. But Monica is also a practical, down-to-earth, and happily married woman.

Things take a turn one year when they're vacationing with friends. Oren discovers that he has a taste for thinking about his wife with another man. And Monica has a taste for... well, something. Monica is becoming a hotwife before his eyes: but Oren can't be sure of *who* she's teasing. Is his fantasy coming true, or is it turning sour? Was there more to Monica's past than she ever let on? Is a hotwife really what he wants?

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Houseguest

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to is wife – maybe even himself?

Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:

Interracial Hotwife Bundle

Includes *The Tenant*, *Not Black and White*, and *Grand Slam* for \$5.99

Lisa Plays Her Part

Lisa and Luke married young because of an unexpected pregnancy, and Lisa never had much experience with other men as a result. But when a dark, handsome, wealthy man she almost slept with (and always wondered about) resurfaces in her life, Lisa is confronted with agonizing desires... and choices. Now that their nest is empty and they don't have the same reasons to stay together, will Lisa and Luke reconnect, or will Lisa choose to make this the final act of their marriage?

Megyn For The Win

In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn – one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor - the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

A romantic, interracial hotwife story with a win at the end!

Claudia Changes Tack

Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable.

It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken. But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

Hotwife Suspense By Arnica Butler

Nila's Long Con

It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he

never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of *A Well-Laid Trap*, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

A Well-Laid Trap

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

Fun Summer Swinger Titles:

Clothing Optional

Sy Price and his wife find themselves in an unexpected situation when their Belize vacation resort turns out to be "Clothing Optional." They're even more surprised to find out that "Clothing Optional" is code for quite a bit more. They decide to make the best of things and enjoy their vacation. But there are a lot more surprises in store for Sy when Jackie decides to fully embrace the hotel amenities...

A Summer Vacation

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along.

Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Try To Have Some Fun

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless. Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties. One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

Explore darker themes by Arnica Butler:

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.